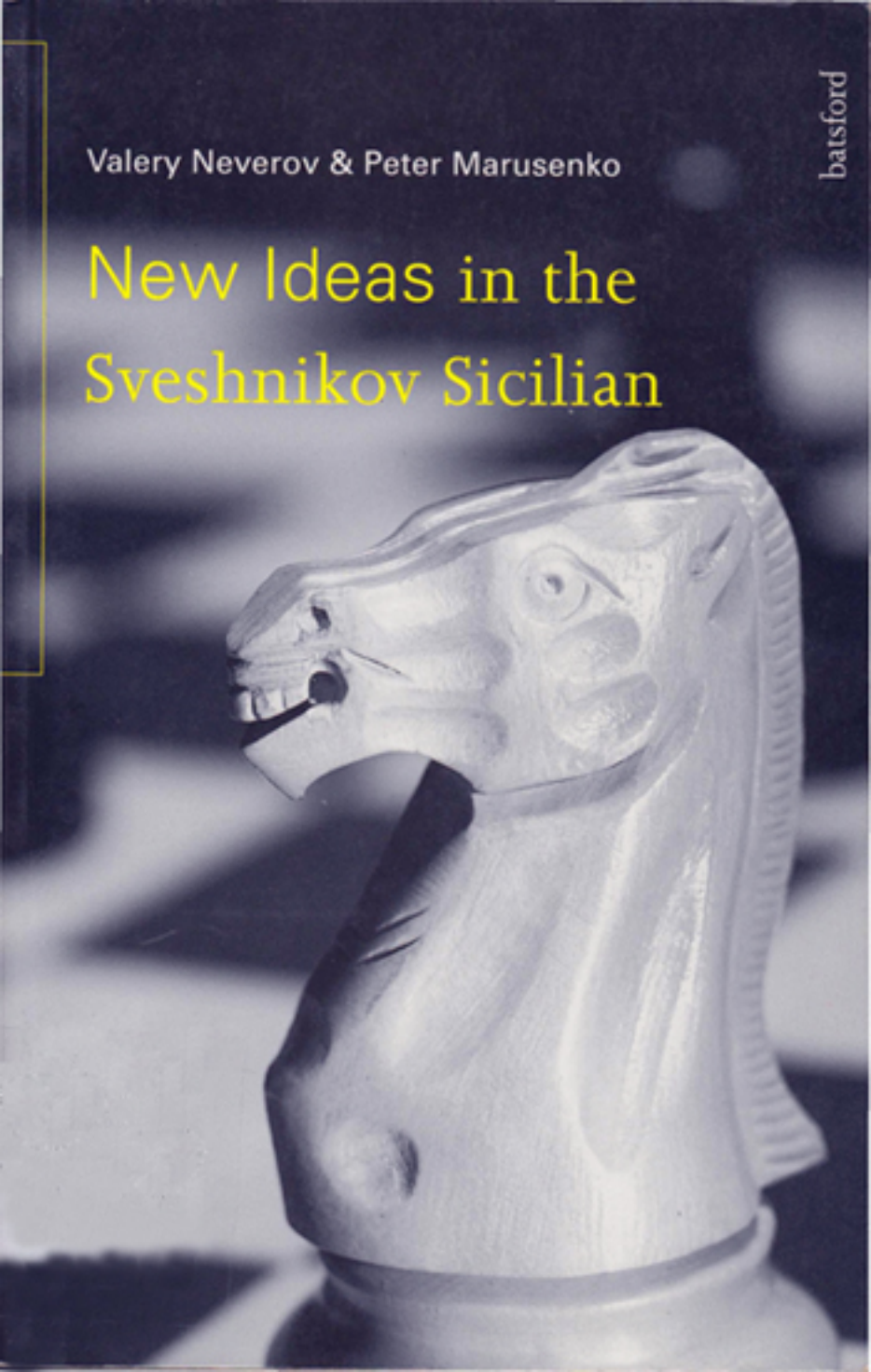
Valery Neverov & Peter Marusenko

New Ideas in the Sveshnikov Sicilian



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Valery Neverov and Peter Marusenko

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Symbols

+	Check
++	Double Check
#	Mate
!	Good move
!!	Excellent move
?	Bad move
??	Serious blunder
!?	Interesting move
?!	Dubious move
⩲	Small advantage to White
⩱	Small advantage to Black
±	Big advantage to White
∓	Big advantage to Black
+–	Decisive advantage to White
–+	Decisive advantage to Black
=	Even position
1-0	White wins
0-1	Black wins
½-½	Draw
Ch	Championship
OL	Olympiad
Z	Zonal
IZ	Interzonal
Ct	Candidates event
(n)	*n*th match game
(D)	Diagram follows

Introduction

The Sicilian Sveshnikov is one of the most popular defences in contemporary chess practice. Its theory is developing rapidly. Since the publication of Sveshnikov's book *The Sicilian Pelikan*, many hundreds of games have been played, greatly enriching the theory of this variation. Our book is about these games and the conclusions to be drawn from them.

Before sending the reader forth through the labyrinth of the many variations of this system, we would like to talk about the common thread in them. Two factors appear to be fundamental to the system: Black's gaping hole on d5 and White's slight lack of development. It is no joke to say that the white g1-knight makes four or five moves at the very outset – as if the knight has promised his queen he will make as many moves as possible, and is not allowed to do otherwise.

Thus the main battle takes shape. Which, then, is stronger: White's static superiority or Black's dynamic advantages?

This controversy has been going on for a long time in chess history. Tarrasch was clearly in favour of White. His opponent was the great chess player and philosopher Lasker. His use of what was to later become known as the Pelikan Sicilian stemmed from his deep understanding of chess strategy. This is what B.Weinstein, the author of *The Thinker*, the brilliant work on the second World Champion, said of the conflict: "Pressure on weak points! Doesn't that remind you of stress testing under a heavy load? Testing to destruction! But if the construction is solid it will resist, and the attack will fail".

Another route – the dynamic one – is also possible; gather all one's forces in the decisive area (even at the cost of weaknesses in other places) and then inflict a blow, acting quickly and energetically, so that the opposition cannot make use of these weaknesses. Thus, Lasker's strategy was based effectively on ideas which were much more wide-ranging and fruitful than the basic principles of pressure on weak points, ideas of superior mobility, space and ammunition, and an advantage in strength.

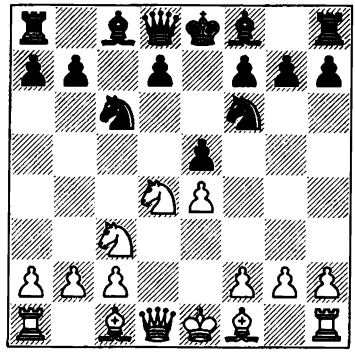
It has long been well known that the basic strategy in chess lies in the struggle to control the key squares, and, in the first place, the central squares, as the pieces which are arranged on them are the most active. And although in the course of the game the objectives of attack might change more than once, the fight for the e4-, d4-, e5- and d5-squares carries on practically permanently.

To show the reader graphically the essence of the conflict, we have chosen a basically old game, and in the years that have passed since the game was first played, the theoretical assessments of individual variations have changed, but the ideas have remained. The game which you will now examine has been commented on more than once, but previously not all the evaluations have seemed justified to us. So, the reader will judge who is right.

Karpov – Dolmatov
Amsterdam 1980

1	**e4**	**c5**
2	**♘f3**	**♘c6**
3	**d4**	**cd**
4	**♘xd4**	**♘f6**
5	**♘c3**	**e5** *(D)*

Isn't it strange that this is one of the most popular continuations of the Sicilian Defence? What attracts



W

Black to leaving d5 so weak? The fact is that from the very first moves the conflicts of the position are heightened, and both sides face difficult strategic problems. Indeed the move ...e5 has clear positional advantages: the d4-knight is driven from its central position, and White has less freedom of movement in the centre, and on the kingside.

6	**♘db5**	**d6**
7	**♗g5**	**a6**
8	**♘a3**	**b5**
9	**♘d5**	

So one white knight sits proudly on d5, but the other occupies a sad position on a3. This is another advantage of ...e5, and at the same time is a reference point for Black in similar situations; it is important that at least one of the knights is hemmed in.

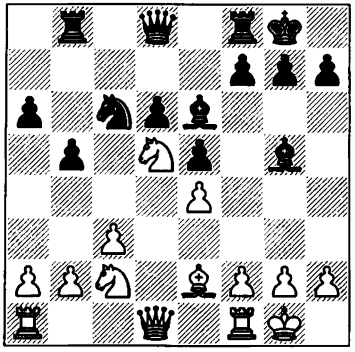
9	**...**	**♗e7**
10	**♗xf6**	**♗xf6**
11	**c3**	

This move prepares ♘c2 followed by a4. The battle for d5 is already in full swing: no sooner is the f6-knight removed, than White tries to eliminate the b5-pawn and give the light-squared bishop an active position on c4. The most pressing problems for Black are to finish his development, and find better squares for his pieces, especially his bishops (...♗g5, ...♗e6), and thanks to his e5-pawn he need not fear an assault by the white pawns.

11	**...**	**0-0**
12	**♘c2**	**♖b8**

Directed against a4.

13	**♗e2**	**♗g5**
14	**0-0**	**♗e6** *(D)*



W

Note that Black is already at full strength to fight for d5. The white knight, placed on this square, is cut off from the remaining light pieces (the g5 bishop controls e3, the b5-pawn prevents the enemy bishop from landing on c4, and when the opportunity arises, ...a5 is possible, stopping ♘c2-b4). After Black has dealt a blow to the e4 pawn with ...f5, the white centre turns out to be surrounded from the flanks.

15 ♕d3

Preparing a place for a rook (which one depends on the circumstances) on d1 to support the central knight. This means that Black must distract it with other problems. Threats along the f-file, created by doubling rooks, serve this aim well. Such is the strategic outline of the battle, and moreover the d5-square itself can be practically ignored by Black, with his pieces more or less flowing round it.

It remains for the game to be shaped definitely. If **15...f5** then 16 ♗f3 (threatening after ef and ♗e4 to replace the pawn on its battle station, as the bishop on e4 will be more actively placed than on c4) 16...g6 17 ♖fd1 ♕d7 18 ♘cb4 ♘xb4 19 ♘xb4, and White is on top. In the event of **15...a5** 16 ♖fd1 ♕d7 17 ♕g3 h6 18 h4 ♗d8 19 ♘ce3 ♔h8 (with the idea of 20...♘e7) 20 ♖d2 ♘e7 21 ♖ad1 the black bishop lags behind.

But he does have at his disposal the interesting idea **15...♖b7!?**. Then it is dangerous for White to

play **16 ♖fd1** f5 17 ♗f3 ♖bf7 18 ef (it's already better for the rook to go into reverse gear with 18 ♖f1) 18...♗xf5 19 ♕e2 ♗h4! with powerful threats (20...♕g5, 20...e4) showing that **f2** is insufficiently defended. If White puts the other rook on d1 – 16 ♖ad1 – then Black may continue 16...a5, and 17 ♘**de3** is no good because of 17...♗xa2, whilst in the event of **17 ♘a3** b4 18 ♘c4 bc 19 bc ♘e7 or **17 ♗f3** ♕c8!? followed by ...g6 and ...f5, Black has good counterchances. Besides, 15...♖b7 frees b8 for the knight, e.g. **16 ♘cb4** ♘b8!? with the idea of ...♘d7-c5 and then ...f5 (although the simple 16...♘xb4 is also reasonable).

15 ♕d7

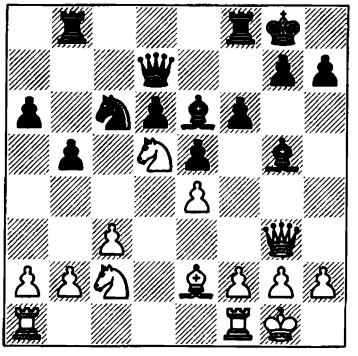
A quite acceptable decision, although it seems less significant than **15...♖b7**.

16 ♕g3

Here the queen does not get in the way of her own pieces, and meanwhile is not susceptible to any attack. Besides, she is attacking the opposition's dark-squared bishop, which is placed on an important diagonal (exerting control over e3!). **16...♗h6** is impossible here because of 17 ♘f6+.

16 f6!? *(D)*

Black is seeking the possibility of leaving his bishop on the c1-h6 diagonal, insofar as his next move 17...♗h6 followed by ...f6-f5 is still possible. But **16...♗d8** doesn't look bad either (from this position the bishop aims at both flanks). **16...h6** is worse, as weakening g6 makes play linked with carrying out ...f7-f5 more difficult.



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17 ♖fd1 a5?

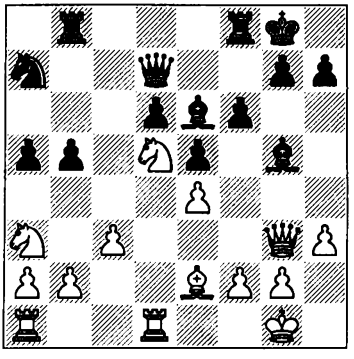
Why not **17...♗h6**? Maybe Dolmatov, when he played his 16th move, calculated the following variation: 18 ♘cb4 ♘xb4 19 ♘xb4 a5 **20 ♘a6** ♖c8 (20...♖b6 21 ♘c5) 21 ♕d3 ♗c4 22 ♕xd6 ♕xd6, and then, having discovered the intervening check 23 ♗xc4+, avoided this line. In vain! By continuing 23...♖xc4 24 ♖xd6 ♖xe4, we can see that only White will have difficulties. If instead of 20 ♘a6 he had chosen **20 ♘d5**, then after 20...f5 Black has good counterplay (as we will see later on, such a correlation of the light pieces, that is two

bishops against knight and bishop, is quite favourable for Black). Dolmatov's move exposes the serious weakness of the light squares, especially in combination with ...f7-f6.

18 ♘a3! **♘a7**

If 18...b4, then 19 ♘c4.

19 h3! *(D)*



B

After two precise moves the following part of the game takes on a technical character for Karpov. White's plan consists of the following elements:

1) exchanging the lesser pieces (light-squared bishop and knight);

2) opening a file on the queenside and invading with the knight into the enemy camp;

3) preparing and carrying out an attack against the king.

How can Black defend himself? Passive defence will spell his doom quickest of all. Therefore he must use any possibility to change the character of the struggle, for example, at this point a pawn sacrifice was possible: **19...g6** 20 ♗g4 f5 21 ♗xf5 (in the event of 21 ef gf and 22 ♗e2 then 22...♕g7 with the idea of 23...f4, and if 22 ♗xf5 then 22...♖xf5 23 ♘e3 ♕g7 with a double-edged game) 21...gf 22 ♕xg5+ ♔h8 with some compensation. Dolmatov missed this possibility.

19 ... **♔h8**

20 ♗g4 **♖fc8**

20...g6 is better.

21 ♗xe6 **♕xe6**

22 ♕d3 **♖c5?**

Now the rook cannot help defend his king. From now on Karpov virtuously prevents all his attempts to get into the game. **22...g6** would have been more persistent.

23 ♘c2 **g6**

24 b4! **ab**

25 ♘cxb4

It is instructive to observe the realization of an advantage. Here White also had at his disposal the continuation **25 cb** with the idea after a2-a4 of gaining an 'extra' passed pawn. But this opens the c-file, which Black controls at the moment. However, it does not give the opposition any counterplay; one must open precisely the file which can be seized.

25 ... **♖b7**

26 a4! **ba**

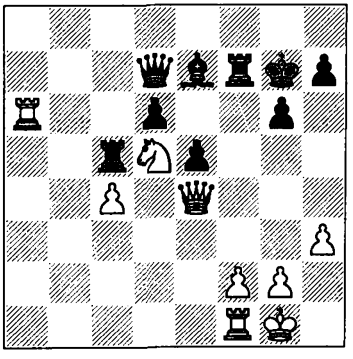
27 ♖xa4

Now Black has an unhappy choice; patiently await his fate, or sharpen the game, and although at the risk of hastening a sorry denouement, Dolmatov chooses the second path.

27	**...**	**f5**
28	**♖a6**	**♘c8**
29	**♖a8**	**♔g7**
30	**♕e2**	**fe**

Or 30...♘e7 31 ♘xe7 ♗xe7 32 ♘d5.

31	**♕xe4**	**♕f5**
32	**♕e2**	**♖f7**
33	**c4**	**♗h4**
34	**♖f1**	**♘e7**
35	**♖a6**	**♕d7**
36	**♕e4**	**♘xd5**
37	**♘xd5**	**♗e7** *(D)*



W

A picturesque position! Now it remains only to prepare an attack on Black's weaknesses, of which there are plenty; the d6 pawn, the bad dark-squared bishop, and the insecure position of the king.

38	**♖fa1**	**♗f8**

If 38...♕f5, then 39 ♕e2 ♗h4 40 g3 ♗xg3 (if 40...♕xh3, then not 41 gh ♕xh4, and Black has succeeded in sharpening the position, but 41 ♖a7! ♗d8 42 ♖xf7+ ♔xf7 43 ♖a7+ ♔f8/e8 44 ♕f3 ♕f5 44 ♕b3 winning) 41 fg ♕xh3 42 ♖1a3, and White is victorious.

39	**♕e2**	**♖c6**
40	**♖6a3!**	**♖c5**
41	**♖f3**	

By exchanging this piece, which is important for the opposition, White again underlines the helplessness of the rook on c5.

41	**...**	**♖xf3**
42	**♕xf3**	**♕f7**
43	**♕g4!**	

The third part of the plan remains; a direct attack on the king. The kingside pawns will move forward for this. The black rook was stopped beforehand, and in return for its freedom it must become the next weakness.

43	**...**	**h5**
44	**♕e4**	**♖c8**

44...♔h7 does not save Black because of 45 ♖a3 ♗g7 46 g4 hg 47 hg ♖c8 48 ♖h3+ ♔g8 49 g5!.

45	**♖a3**	**♕f5**
46	**♖a7+**	**♔h6**
47	**♕e3+**	**g5**
48	**♕e2!**	**♖b8**

49	**g4!**	**hg**
50	**hg**	**♕b1+**
51	**♔g2**	**♖b7**
52	**♖xb7**	**♕xb7**
53	**♕f3**	**♕c8**
54	**♕f6+**	**♔h7**
55	**♕f7+**	**1-0**

Of course, although the above game is typical, it far from exhausts all of the many clashes of strategic ideas brought out by players of the Sveshnikov. We should add that this system wages war on all new adherents. It forms part of the permanent opening repertoire of Grandmasters Alexei Shirov, Vladimir Kramnik, John Nunn, Murray Chandler, Ketevan Arakhamia as well as many other prominent and rank and file chessplayers.

In the book we will examine 31 main and hundreds of subsidiary games. Insofar as the move order in the Sveshnikov can be either 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘b5 d6 7 ♗g5, or 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 ♘c6 6 ♘b5 d6 7 ♗f4 e5 8 ♗g5, then the move numbers in both the main game and the subsidiary games are taken from the first move order given above.

1 9...♗e7 10 ♗xf6

In this system White actively fights for control of d5. He gives up his light-squared bishop in return for his opponent's knight and fights to put his own knight on d5. In the event of an exchange White is prepared to replace it with other pieces. Black's counterplay is most often linked with the thematic move ...f7-f5 and activity on the kingside and in the centre.

Game 1
Zapata – Shirov
Manila 1992

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♘d5 ♗e7 10 ♗xf6 ♗xf6

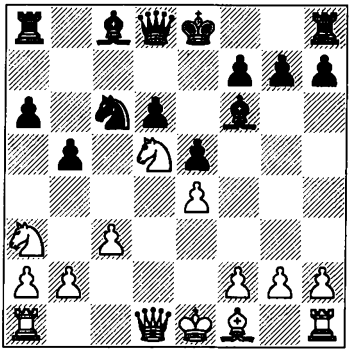
11 c3 *(D)*

One of the standard positions arising in the Sveshnikov. Hundreds of games have been played in it in recent years. The continuations 11 c4 and 11 g3 will be examined in the notes to Game 3.

11 ... ♗b7

In this variation Black tries to position his pieces more usefully before he castles.

12 ♘c2



B

The game Ljubojević-Illescas, Linares 1992 featured the novelty **12 ♕g4**, but after the continuation 12...0-0 13 ♘c2 ♘b8! 14 ♖d1 (14 0-0-0!?) 14...♘d7?! (14...♗g5 =) 15 ♗e2?! (15 ♘ce3! ±) 15...♗g5 Black had equalized.

Beliavsky-Shirov, Linares 1994, developed otherwise: **12 ♗d3** ♘b8 13 ♘c2 ♘d7 14 a4 ba 15 ♖xa4 ♗g5 16 0-0 0-0 17 ♖a2 a5 18 ♗c4 ♘b6 19 ♘xb6 ♕xb6 20 ♕d3 ♖ac8 21 ♖d1 ♖fd8 22 b3 g6 23 ♖da1 ♖c5 with an edge to White.

12 ... ♘b8!?

13 a4!

Three alternatives deserve looking at:

a) **13 c4** is certainly worth testing: 13...0-0 14 cb ab 15 ♗e2 ♘d7

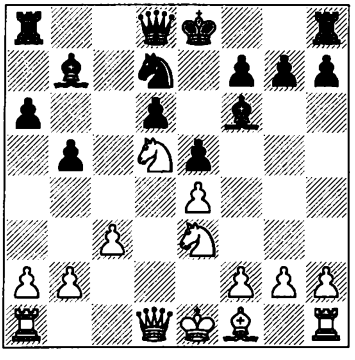
16 0-0 ♘c5 17 ♗f3 ♗g5 with an equal position, Brodsky-Rogozenko, Nikolaev Z 1993.

b) **13 g3**:

b1) **13...♗g5!?** 14 h4 ♗h6 15 g4 ♗f4 16 ♘xf4 ef 17 f3 ♘c6 18 ♕d2 ♕f6 19 0-0-0 ♖d8 20 g5 ♕e5 21 ♘e1? (21 ♘d4!? ±) 21...d5 22 ♘d3 de! with a very complex game in which Black has the chances, J.Polgar-Illescas, Dos Hermanas 1994.

b2) **13...♘d7** 14 h4 0-0 15 ♘ce3 g6, and then Zso.Polgar-Ochoa, Las Palmas 1994 featured 16 h5. After 16...♗g5 17 hg fg 18 ♗g2 ♘f6 19 ♕d3 ♗xe3 20 ♘xe3 ♕e7 21 0-0 ♗c6 22 a4 ♔g7 23 ab ab 24 ♘c2 White would have achieved an advantage.

c) **13 ♘ce3 ♘d7** *(D)* is another possibility:



W

c1) **14 ♗d3** 0-0 15 0-0 ♗g5 16 ♕e2 ♗xe3 17 ♘xe3 ♘c5 18 ♖fd1 g6 with an equal position, N.Friedrich-Krasenkov, Berlin 1990.

c2) **14 ♘f5** 0-0 15 ♘xd6 ♗xd5 16 ♕xd5 (or 16 ed ♘b6 17 ♘e4 ♘xd5 =) 16...♕c7 (16...♕b6? 17 ♘xf7!; 16...♘b6!? 17 ♕d3 g6, and unexpected problems with the knight arise for White) 17 ♖d1 (17 ♘xf7? ♘b6) 17...♘b6 (17...♘c5!? 18 ♘xf7 ♕xf7 19 ♕xc5 ♗h4! 20 ♕d5 ♗xf2+ 21 ♔e2 ♗b6 with a complex game) 18 ♕b7 ♕c5, and Black receives an advantage in development and more active pieces for the sacrificed pawn, Morris-Krasenkov, Andorra 1991.

c3) **14 g3 0-0 15 h4!** and now:

c31) **15...♘c5** 16 ♗d3 g6 17 ♗c2 a5 18 a3 ♗g7 19 h5 ♗c8 20 hg fg 21 ♕e2 ± Anand-Kramnik, Monaco 1994.

c32) **15...g6**, and two routes have been tested:

c321) **16 ♗h3** ♗g7 17 h5 ♘f6 18 hg hg 19 ♕d3 ♘xd5 20 ♘xd5 ♗h6 21 ♖d1 ♔g7 22 ♗g2 ♖c8 23 ♘e3 ♗xe3 24 ♕xe3 ♖h8 25 ♖xh8 ♔xh8 26 ♗h3 ♖c4 27 f3 ♔g7 = Anand-Nunn, Monaco 1994.

c322) **16 ♕g4** ♗g7 17 h5 ♘f6 (17...f5 doesn't work because of 18 ♕h3 ♘f6 19 hg hg 20 ef! gf 21 ♕xf5 ♘xd5 22 ♕e6+) 18 ♘xf6+ ♕xf6 19 ♖d1 ♗c8 (19...♖ac8 20 ♗g2 ♖fd8 21 0-0 ♖c5 22 ♖d3 ♗h6 23 ♖fd1 ♗xe3 24 ♖xe3 ♗c8 25 ♕e2 ♗e6 with equality in the game

Mortensen-Nu nn, Vejle 1994) 20 ♕e2 ♗e6 21 ♘d5 (21 ♖xd6 ♕e7 and ...♗xa2) 21...♕g5 22 hg hg, and now: **23 ♕d3** ♖a7 24 a3 f5 25 ♕e3 ♕xe3+ 26 ♘xe3 ♖d7 27 ♗g2 (27 ♗h3 is a better move) 27...♔f7 = Stripunsky-Krasenkov, Pardubice op 1993, or **23 ♘c7!?** ♗c4 24 ♕f3 ♖a7 25 ♗xc4 bc (25...♖xc7 26 ♗d5 ±) 26 ♘d5 ♖b7 27 ♖d2 ±.

13 ... ba

14 ♘ce3 ♘d7

It is not expedient to support the pawn by means of **14...♗c6** because of 15 ♘f5 0-0 16 ♗c4!, and serious difficulties arise for Black. However, **14...0-0** deserves attention, for example 15 ♖xa4 ♘d7 16 ♕g4 ♘c5 17 ♖a2 ♗g5 18 ♗c4 ♗xe3 19 fe h5 20 ♕xh5 ♘xe4 21 0-0 ♖c8 22 ♗b3 ♗xd5 23 ♗xd5 ♘f6 24 ♖xf6 ∓ Klovans-Kalinichev, Münster 1993.

15 ♕xa4 0-0

16 ♖d1 ♗g5

17 ♕c2 ♘c5

Another plan was also quite possible: **17...♗xe3** 18 ♘xe3 ♘f6 (or 18...♘c5 19 ♗d3 a5 and the position is unclear) 19 ♗d3 ♕c7 20 0-0 ♖fd8 with an approximately level game.

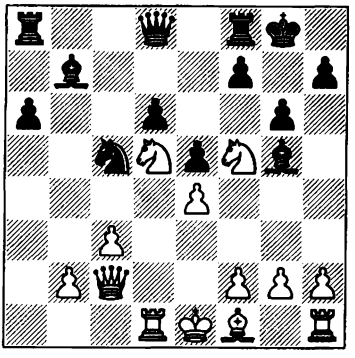
18 ♘f5!

Other continuations are worse:

a) **18 ♘c4?** ♗c6 19 b3 ♖b8 ∓.

b) **18 ♗d3** ♗c6 19 ♖a1 ♗xe3 20 ♘xe3 ♕h4 21 0-0 ♗xe4 22 ♗xe4 ♕xe4 and White only has sufficient compensation for equality.

18 g6 *(D)*



W

19 b4!

For the time being Zapata is actively fighting for an advantage. The timid **19 ♘g3** only leads to equality, whilst interesting complications arise after **19 h4** gf (not 19...♗f4? 20 b4! ±) 20 hg ♗xd5 (Black should avoid 20...♘xe4 21 ♘f6+! ♘xf6 22 ♕xf5 ♗e4 23 ♕xf6 ±) 21 ♖xd5 ♘xe4 22 ♗d3 ♕xg5 23 ♗xe4 fe 24 ♕xe4 f5, for example, 25 ♕c4 ♔h8 26 ♖xd6 ♕xg2 27 ♖xh7+! ♔xh7 28 ♕c7+ ♕g7 29 ♖d7 ♕xd7 30 ♕xd7+, and the chances are equal.

19 ♗xd5

Black must be circumspect. The two lines **19...♘e6** 20 ♘xd6 and **19...gf** 20 bc ♖c8 21 h4! ♗h6 22 cd have unpleasant consequences.

20 ♖xd5

White must be on the alert. In the event of **20 bc?** ♗c6 21 h4 (21 ♖xd6 ♕c7 is also good for Black) 21...♗f6 22 ♘xd6 Black seizes the initiative.

20	**...**	**♘b7**
21	**h4**	**♗f6**
22	**♘h6+**	**♔g7**
23	**♘g4**	**a5!**

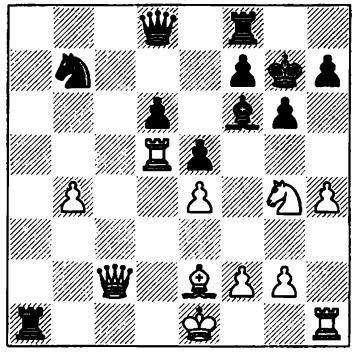
Shirov must not give his opponent an opportunity to increase his advantage quietly. With the text move he is activating the knight or rook. Although with exact play White will preserve a small advantage, all Black's resourceful counterplay presents Zapata with some difficult problems.

24 ♗e2

A less tense situation arises after **24 b5** h5 25 ♘xf6 (25 ♘e3? ♗xh4 26 ♘c4 ♕f6 27 g3 ♗g5 ∓) 25...♕xf6 26 ♗e2 a4 27 g3 ♘c5 28 0-0 ♖ab8, and White's position moreover remains preferable.

24	**...**	**ab**
25	**cb**	**♖a1+** *(D)*

This is the crucial moment in the game. Now after the correct move **26 ♖d1** ♖xd1+ 27 ♕xd1 h5 28 ♘e3! (28 ♘xf6 ♕xf6 29 g3 ♘d8! 30 b5 ♘e6 31 ♕xd6 ♖a8 32 0-0 ♘d4 33 ♕xf6+ ♔xf6 34 ♗d3 ♖a3 35 ♖d1 ♖b3 =) 28...♕d7 29 ♘d5 Zapata's chances would have been better.



W

26 ♗d1?!

An error which allows Shirov to seize the initiative.

26	**...**	**♕c8!**
27	**♘e3?!**	

It never rains but it pours! After 27 ♕xc8 ♖xc8 28 ♘xf6 ♔xf6 29 0-0 ♔e7 the endgame would have been level. Now it is even more difficult for White to untangle the mess his pieces have got into.

27	**...**	**♕xc2**
28	**♘xc2**	**♖b1**
29	**♔d2?!**	

29 ♖b5!? with the idea of castling, would have been more accurate.

29	**...**	**♖c8**
30	**♖h3**	**♖c4!**

Black is gaining time to transfer the rook to c7. Naturally, 31 f3, totally excluding the h3-rook from the game, cannot satisfy White.

31	**♔d3**	**♖c7**
32	**♔d2**	**♘d8!**

The knight returns to the game with decisive effect. After the capture 33 ♖xd6, 33...♘e6 has many threats.

33	**♗e2**	**♘e6**
34	**♖c3**	**♖xc3**
35	**♔xc3**	**♘f4**
36	**♖d2**	**♘xg2**
37	**♗d1!**	

37 b5 ♗xh4 38 ♘a3 ♖c1+ 39 ♔b2 ♖c8 loses quickly.

37	**...**	**♗xh4**
38	**♘a3**	**♖c1+**
39	**♘c2**	**♗g5**
40	**♖xd6**	**h5**
41	**b5**	

Playing 41 ♔b2 would have significantly prolonged White's resistance. However, in this case as well, after 41...h4 42 ♗g4 ♖f1! 43 b5 ♖xf2 44 b6! ♘e3 45 b7 ♖xc2+ 46 ♔b1 ♖c4! 47 b8♕ ♘xg4 48 ♕b3 ♖xe4 the pawn will inevitably queen. Now we have a rapid denouement...

41	**...**	**h4**
42	**b6**	**h3**
43	**b7**	**h2**
44	**b8♕**	**h1♕**
45	**♖d7**	**♕e1+**
46	**♔b2**	**♕xe4**

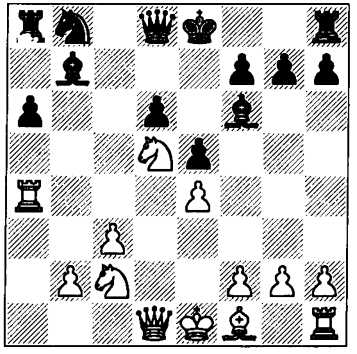
0-1

The next game made a huge impression on the entire chess world. In an interview at the end of the Zurich tournament, Kasparov said it was one of the best games he had ever played. This duel took place soon after he had suffered a sensational defeat at the hands of a computer in London. 'A computer could never have found the idea of the exchange sacrifice', the World Champion remarked.

Game 2
Kasparov – Shirov
Horgen 1994

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♘d5 ♗e7 10 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 11 c3 ♗b7 12 ♘c2 ♘b8 13 a4 ba

14 ♖xa4 *(D)*



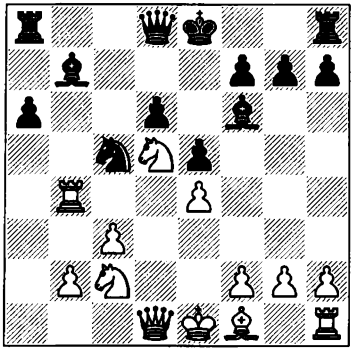
B

A more precise move than we saw in Game 1. At first glance it seems to have little point. What could be so interesting about such a natural pawn capture? True, the

slightly illogical nature of this move draws attention to itself. The black knight can speed to c5, and will now arrive there with a tempo. On b4 or c4 the rook is also not supported for long. What, then, can Kasparov have in mind?

14 ... ♘d7
15 ♖b4 ♘c5 *(D)*

Bearing in mind the World Champion's next move, **15...♖a7** would have been better, with the idea of 16...♗a8 (it stands to reason that the exchange sacrifice doesn't have the same effect now: 16 ♖xb7?! ♖xb7 17 ♗xa6 ♖xb2), and in this situation the rook on b4 could find itself under attack in future. However, it was very hard to foresee Kasparov's next move.



W

16 ♖xb7!!

A thunderbolt from a clear sky! Played in the style of Nimzowitsch, Petrosian, and indeed of Kasparov himself, this represents a typical positional exchange sacrifice. White does not gain any kind of profit immediately, although the strategic superiority of his position more than makes up for the material loss. What advantages are in question? In the first place, Black has lost his light-squared bishop, which would have played a large role in organizing a counter-attack. As a consequence of this, the role of the blockading d5-knight has grown, and, as it has no opponents, it is more powerful than the rook. Moreover, Black's light-squared bishop was in full control of his territory. Secondly, the black knight is now (and, as it turns out, until the end of the game) excluded from play. Thus it is unclear whether this is an exchange sacrifice or winning two pieces for a rook.

So, White's plans have become obvious, but it was not easy to come to this paradoxical solution. The ability to find such obscure ideas marks out the outstanding players from the merely good ones.

This novelty of Kasparov's is one of the most important in the Sveshnikov in recent years.

16 ... ♘xb7
17 b4!

An important link in White's plan. As we have already noted, it

is not easy for the b7-knight to find its way into the game, as it can only do this via d8, but the queen, which occupies this square, does not have another comfortable spot.

17 ... ♗g5?!

If **17...a5**, then 18 ♗b5+ is very unpleasant. However, it was worth thinking about **17...0-0**, for example, 18 ♘a3 ♕e8!? 19 ♘c4 (19 ♘c7 ♕c6!) 19...♗d8 20 ♗d3 a5 21 0-0 ab 22 cb ♕a4, and Black's pieces are better placed than in the game.

18 ♘a3

White has no need to castle quickly, due to his opponent's lack of counterplay, so he activates the second knight.

18 ... 0-0
19 ♘c4 a5
20 ♗d3

Naturally the b4-pawn, which is fulfilling the role of a watchman, is not going anywhere.

20 ... ab
21 cb ♕b8
22 h4!

Before castling it is useful to drive off the bishop.

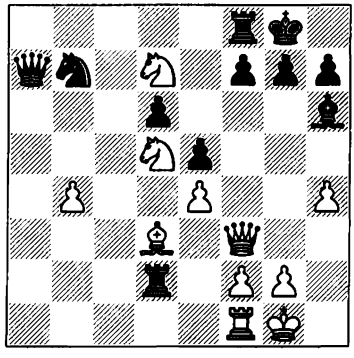
22 ♗h6?!

This gives the impression that Shirov did realize the true danger of his position. The standard idea **22...♗d8** is stronger. Of course, it is not easy to decide upon this move, which in the first place takes a square away for the knight, and in the second place makes the earlier move 17...♗g5 look pointless. All the same, he should have recognized his mistake and played it anyway.

23 ♘cb6 ♖a2
24 0-0 ♖d2?

The black rook encroaches on his opponent's position, but the misfortune is that there is no objective for attack there, whilst the main thing is that Black himself drives the opposing queen on to the offensive. **24...♕a7** immediately would have been better.

25 ♕f3 ♕a7
26 ♘d7 *(D)*



B

White begins to lay his cards on the table. Now if the attacked rook retreats to a8 or d8, then 27 ♘e7+ ♔h8 28 ♕xf7 (threatening 29 ♘f8) 28...g6 29 ♘f6 ♗g7 30 ♘e8 leads inevitably to mate. If

26...♖e8, then 27 ♗b5 is very strong, while **26...♕a3** is refuted by 27 ♘e7+ and 28 ♘xf8. Therefore Black must return the exchange.

26	**...**	**♘d8**
27	**♘xf8**	**♔xf8**
28	**b5**	

The b-pawn, so fruitfully employed on b4, now rushes forward.

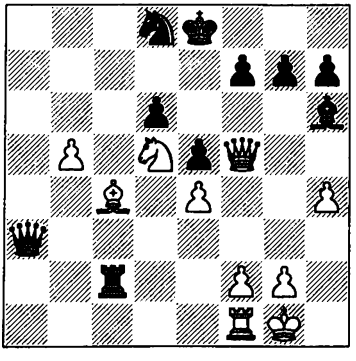
28		**♕a3**

Black's attempt to exchange queens is unsuccessful.

29	**♕f5**	

Kasparov leaves his bishop to the mercy of fate, because in reply to a capture on d3, there follows an interesting double strike: 30 ♕d7 with the threat of 31 ♕e7+ and 31 ♕xd8#.

29	**...**	**♔e8**
30	**♗c4**	**♖c2** *(D)*



W

White energetically directs the decisive attack.

31	**♕xh7**	**♖xc4**
32	**♕g8+**	**♔d7**
33	**♘b6+**	**♔e7**
34	**♘xc4**	**♕c5**
35	**♖a1**	**♕d4**
36	**♖a3**	**♗c1**
37	**♘e3**	**1-0**

This little masterpiece will undoubtedly end up in all the chess manuals. However it can in no way have any pretensions towards being a refutation of the opening variation. The game is an illustration of how important it is to notice the opening nuances and know how to make use of them. Shirov got away with the knight's position on b7 against Zapata, but Kasparov made full use of the unhappy position of that piece.

A more prevalent continuation for Black on his 11th move is to castle. However, Shirov nevertheless returns to his favourite bishop move to b7. All his pieces interact magnificently with each other.

Game 3
Tiviakov – Shirov
Oakham 1992

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♘d5 ♗e7 10 ♗xf6 ♗xf6

11	**c3**	

The most popular continuation. Otherwise:

a) Frolov's attempt to breathe new life into **11 c4** deserves attention. After **11...b4 12 ♘c2**:

a1) **12...a5** 13 ♘xf6+ ♕xf6 14 ♗e2 0-0 15 0-0 ♖d8 16 ♕d2 ♗e6 17 b3 ♖ab8 (17...♕e7 is more precise) 18 ♖fd1 ♖d7 19 ♕e3 and White has a small positional advantage. Frolov-Yakovich, Moscow 1991.

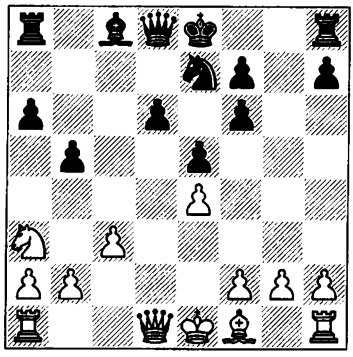
a2) Things turned out better for Black in the game Frolov-Ikonnikov, Schwäbisch Gmünd 1994: **12...♖b8** 13 ♗e2 0-0 14 0-0 ♗g5 15 ♗g4 ♗e6 16 b3 ♕d7 17 h3 g6 18 a3 f5 19 ef gf 20 ♗h5 ba 21 ♖xa3 ♔h8 22 ♕d3 a5 23 ♖d1 ♕g7 24 ♕e2 ♖g8.

b) Ljubojevic's attempt to develop the bishop on g2 was not particularly successful. After **11 g3** 0-0 12 ♗g2 ♗g5 13 0-0 ♘e7 14 ♘xe7 ♕xe7 15 c3 ♖b8 16 ♘c2 a5 17 ♖e1 ♗e6 18 ♘e3 ♗xe3 19 ♖xe3 ♖fc8 20 ♕d2 ♖b6 21 ♗f1 h6 22 a4 ♗c4 23 ab ♗xf1 24 ♖xf1 ♖xb5 the game was level, Ljubojević-Illescas, Linares (3) 1993.

11 ... 0-0

The standard knight manoeuvre **11...♘e7** is also possible, although in this case one reaches a position from the variation 10 ♘xe7 ♘xe7 11 ♗xf6 gf in which White has gained a move (c2-c3). However, making use of this factor is not so easy.

a) **12 ♘xf6+ gf** *(D)* and now:



W

a1) **13 ♘c2**:

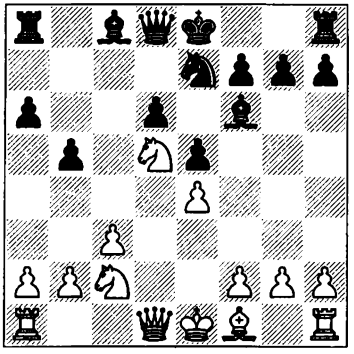
a11) **13...♗b7** 14 ♗d3 f5!? 15 ef ♗xg2 16 ♖g1 ♗b7 17 a4, but now in Brodsky-Osipov, USSR 1991, White managed to achieve an advantage after **17...♕b6?!** 18 ab ab 19 ♖xa8+ ♗xa8 20 ♘e3, but Black should have continued **17...ba** 18 ♖xa4 d5 with an unclear game.

a12) Black tested **13...d5** in the game Berset-Shabalov, Saint Martin 1993, but after 14 a4 ba 15 ♘e3 de 16 ♕xa4+ ♕d7 17 ♗b5 ab 18 ♕xa8+ he had no compensation for the loss of the exchange.

a2) The game Krivets-Mikhević, Bled 1994, developed thus: **13 ♕f3** f5 14 ef ♗xf5 15 ♗d3 ♗e6 16 0-0 0-0 17 ♗c2 f5 18 ♗b3 ♕d7 19 ♖ad1 ♗xb3 20 ab and White had somewhat the better chances.

a3) The Latvian player Lanka uses the move **13 ♗e2** quite successfully, for example, 13...♗b7 14 ♗f3 f5 15 ef d5 16 g3 ♘xf5 17 ♘c2 and now **17...♕d6** 18 a4 ba 19 ♖xa4 a5 20 0-0 0-0 21 ♕d2 ± Lanka-Chevalier, France 1990, or **17...0-0** 18 0-0 a5 19 ♗g2 ♕d6 20 ♖e1 ♗c6 21 ♕h5 ± Lanka-Muse, Germany 1994.

b) In some case White avoids exchanging on f6, preferring instead **12 ♘c2** *(D)*:



B

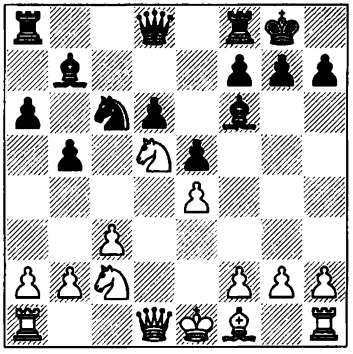
b1) **12...♗b7** 13 ♘ce3 ♗g5 14 ♘xe7 ♗xe7 15 ♘d5 0-0 16 ♗e2 ♖c8 17 0-0 ♖c5 18 b4 ♖c8 19 a4 ♗xd5 20 ♕xd5 ♖xc3 21 ab ab 22 ♖a7 ± Kholmov-Horak, Pardubice 1994.

b2) **12...♘xd5 13 ♕xd5** with two possibilities for Black:

b21) **13...♖b8** 14 ♘b4 ♗b7 15 ♕d3 0-0 16 ♗e2 ♗g5 17 ♘d5 f5 18 ♗f3 g6 19 0-0 ♔h8 20 ♖ad1 ♖c8 = Acharia-Ripatbin, Calcutta 1994.

b22) **13...♗e6** 14 ♕c6+ ♔e7 15 ♘e3 ♕c8 16 ♕b6 ♖b8 17 ♕a5 ♕d7 18 ♖d1 ± Lopez-Berset, Geneva 1994.

12 ♘c2 ♗b7 *(D)*



W

13 ♗e2

L.Levitt-Volodin, corr 1991/2 continued **13 g3!?** ♘b8 14 ♗g2 ♘d7 15 0-0 ♗g5 16 f4!? ef 17 gf ♗h6 18 ♘ce3 g6 19 ♕g4 ♗g7 20 ♖ad1, and White's pieces occupied magnificent positions.

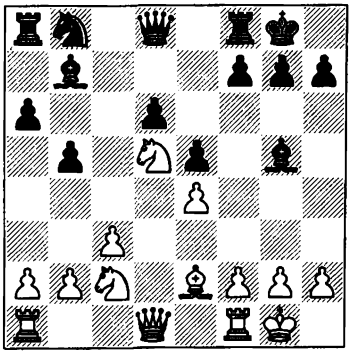
The continuation **13 a4** occurred in Maliakin-Gagarin, USSR 1991, to Black's advantage: 13...ba 14 ♖xa4 ♘b8! 15 ♗c4 ♘d7 16 0-0 ♘c5 17 ♖a2 ♘xe4 18 ♕f3 ♘d2 (the only move; 18...♘c5? 19 b4 e4 20 ♘xf6+ loses) 19 ♘xf6+ ♕xf6 20 ♕xb7 ♘xc4 21 ♖xa6? ♖ab8. Maliakin could have maintained the balance by means of 21 b3!

♘d2 (21...♖fb8 22 ♖xa6! +–) 22 ♖d1 ♖ab8 23 ♕d5 ♘xb3 24 ♖xa6. (*Typesetter's Note:* 24...♖fd8 keeps the extra pawn, e.g. 25 ♖xd6 ♖xd6 26 ♕xd6 ♕xd6 27 ♖xd6 ♘d4! 28 ♘e1 ♘e2+, etc.).

13 ♕g4 deserves attention, for example, 13...♗g5 14 ♖d1 ♗c8 15 ♕e2 f5 16 h4 ♗h6 17 ef ♗xf5 18 g4 ♗xc2 19 ♕xc2 g6 20 g5 ± Mortensen-Kharlov, Copenhagen 1993.

An original pawn sacrifice occurred in Berelovich-Cherniaev, Sochi 1993. After **13 h4** ♘e7 14 ♘xf6+ gf 15 ♗d3 ♔h8 16 ♘e3 Black should have played 16...f5!, and if 17 ef, then the cold-blooded 17...f6 with the idea of continuing ...d6-d5. Black is better despite his small material deficit.

13	**...**	**♗g5**
14	**0-0**	**♘b8** *(D)*



W

Black is trying to manoeuvre his knight to a comfortable position on c5, where it will have an active influence over the centre.

15 ♕d3

Attempts to move play to the queenside immediately will not be successful for White: 15 a4 ba 16 ♖xa4 ♘d7 17 b4 ♘b6 ∓.

15 ♗g4 ♖a7 is also possible:

a) **16 a4** ba 17 ♖xa4 ♘d7 18 ♗xd7 ♕xd7 19 ♘cb4 a5! (19...f5 20 ef ♕xf5 21 ♕e2 a5 22 ♕xb5 ♗xd5 23 ♘xd5 +–) 20 ♕a1 ♕b5 with chances for both sides (L.Levitt).

b) **16 ♕d3** ♘d7 17 ♗xd7 ♕xd7 18 ♖ad1 (18 c4?! bc 19 ♕xc4 ♖c8 with the idea of ♗xd5) 18...a5 (18...g6!?) 19 ♕g3 ♕d8! 20 ♘ce3 g6 21 ♘f5 with an unclear game, Novik-Chekhov, Leningrad 1991. However, 21 c4! would have given White an advantage.

15	**...**	**♘d7**
16	**♖fd1**	**♘c5**
17	**♕f3**	**g6**
18	**♘ce3**	**♔h8**

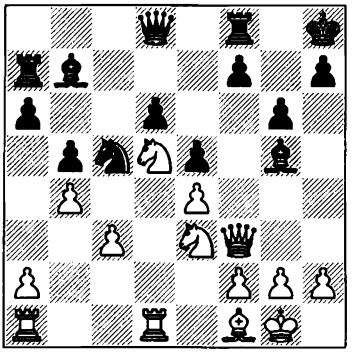
A necessary preparatory move. The hurried **18...f5?** doesn't work because of 19 ef gf 20 ♘xf5 e4? 21 ♘de7+! ♗xe7 22 ♕g4+ ♔f7 (22...♗g5 23 ♖xd6 +–) 23 ♕g7+ ♔e8 24 ♗h5+ ♔d7 25 ♖xd6+ and White is winning.

19	**♗f1**	**♖a7!?**

Again the premature **19...f5?!** 20 ef gf 21 ♘xf5 ♗c8 22 g4 gives no compensation for the lost pawn.

Now this move already threatens, for example, **20 g3** f5! 21 ef gf 22 ♘xf5 e4 23 ♕g4 ♖xf5 24 ♕xf5 ♗c8, and the queen has unexpectedly fallen into a trap.

20 b4 *(D)*



B

20 ... ♘e6?!

20...♘a4 21 c4 ♘b2 was better, after which it would not be easy for White to maintain the balance. He gets a difficult position after:

a) **22 ♖d2** ♘xc4 23 ♘xc4 bc 24 ♖dd1 ♗xd5 25 ♖xd5 ♖c7.

b) **22 ♖dc1** f5! 23 cb fe 24 ♕xe4 ab 25 ♗xb5 ♗xd5 26 ♕xd5 ♖af7.

c) **22 ♖db1 ♘xc4** and now:

c1) **23 ♘xc4** ♗xd5 24 ♘xd6 ♕xd6 25 ♖d1.

c2) **23 ♗xc4** bc 24 ♘xc4 ♗xd5 25 ed e4! 26 ♕xe4 ♗f6 27 ♘b2 ♖e8.

d) Therefore the only acceptable possibility was to continue **22 ♖e1!**, after which 22...♘xc4 23 ♗xc4 bc 24 ♘xc4 ♗xd5 25 ed f5 26 ♘a5 would have led to a complex position with roughly even chances.

21 a4 ba
22 ♖xa4 f5
23 ♖a5

An interesting variation arises after **23 ♖da1 ♗f4 24 ef gf 25 ♗xa6? ♖xa6 26 ♖xa6 ♗xe3 27 fe ♘g5 28 ♕d1 ♘h3+!!** and now:

a) **29 gh** ♖g8+ 30 ♔h1 (30 ♔f1 will be examined below) 30...♕g5 31 ♕f3 ♕xe3!! –+.

b) **29 ♔f1** ♕h4 30 gh (30 ♖6a2 ♗a6+ and 30 ♕d2 ♗xd5 win for Black) 30...♖g8 31 ♖6a2 (31 ♕f3 ♗xa6+ 32 ♖xa6 ♕c4+ 33 ♕e2 ♕xd5 –+) 31...♕e4! –+.

Instead of the text move, **23 ♗c4** was also possible, strengthening the important d5-square.

23 ♗h4!

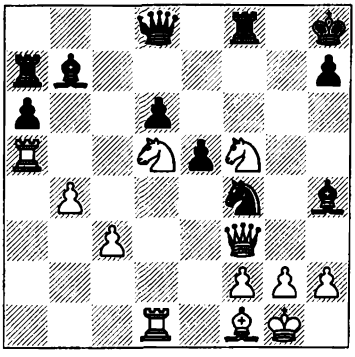
Shirov unambiguously demonstrates his aggressive intentions on the kingside.

24 ef gf
25 ♘xf5 ♘f4 *(D)*

A critical position.

26 ♘xh4?

Tiviakov has underestimated the danger posed by Black's threats. He should have continued **26 ♕e3!** ♖xf5 27 ♕xa7 ♘h3+! (not 27...♗xd5? 28 g3 +–) 28 gh ♕g8+ (28...♗xf2+? 29 ♕xf2 ♖xf2 30 ♔xf2 +–) 29 ♗g2 (29 ♔h1? ♗xf2)



W

29...♖g5 30 ♕xb7 ♖xg2+ 31 ♔h1 ♗xf2 32 ♕b8! ♕xb8 33 ♔xg2 ♗h4, although Black's chances are still somewhat preferable.

26 ... ♘xd5!
27 ♕h5

If **27 ♕g3**, then 27...♘f4, and no defence is visible to 28...♖g8.

27 ... ♘f4
28 ♕h6 ♖f6
29 ♕g5 ♗xg2!

The conclusive blow, based on the fact that the a7-rook unexpectedly comes into the game from the ambush.

30 ♗xg2 ♖g7
31 ♕xg7

The white queen has nevertheless fallen into a trap. If White now tries **31 ♕xe5** then Black replies 31...♘h3+ 32 ♔f1 (32 ♔h1 ♘xf2+ 33 ♔g1 ♘xd1 and Black wins) 33...♖xf2+ 34 ♔e1 ♕xh4, and there is no defence to the deadly discovered check.

31 ... ♔xg7
32 ♖xe5 ♕c8!

Shirov very accurately realizes his material advantage. From c8 the queen poses threats in every direction.

33 ♖e7+

Nor can White be saved by **33 ♖g5+** ♔h6 34 ♘f3 ♕xc3, and now he cannot avoid fresh material losses.

33 ... ♖f7
34 ♖xf7+ ♔xf7
35 ♗d5+ ♔f8
36 ♘g2 ♕g4
37 ♖d2 ♕g5
0-1

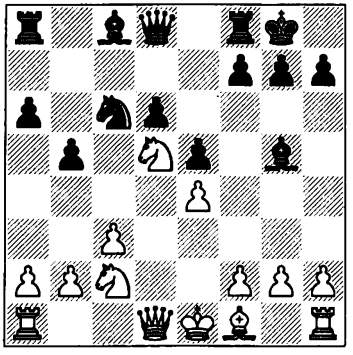
The continuation 12...♗g5 also allows White to begin play immediately on the queenside by means of 13 a4. Black, as a rule, prepares a counterattack on the kingside.

Game 4
Petrushin – Belikov
Podolsk 1992

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♘d5 ♗e7 10 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 11 c3 0-0 12 ♘c2

12 ... ♗g5 *(D)*
13 a4

A principled continuation, with which White quickly begins play against Black's weak pawns on the queenside.



W

It's also worth looking at the line **13 h4** ♗h6 14 g4 ♗f4! 15 ♕f3 ♖e8 (15...♗e6 is possible) 16 ♗e2 ♘e7 17 ♘xf4 ef 18 0-0-0 ♗b7 19 ♕xf4 ♘g6 20 ♕g3 ♗xe4 21 ♗f3 ♗xf3 22 ♕xf3 with a small advantage to White, Marusenko-Keehner, Norwich 1994.

13 ♗e2 is rather toothless, for instance, **13...♗e6** 14 0-0 ♘e7 15 a4 ba 16 ♖xa4 ♗xd5 17 ed a5 18 ♘a3 f5 19 ♘c4 e4 = Serper-Chekhov, Frunze 1988, or **13...♗b7** 14 0-0 ♘b8 15 c4 (15 ♗g4 was better) 15...bc 16 ♗xc4 ♘d7 17 ♘ce3 ♘c5 18 f3 g6 19 ♕e1 ♘e6 20 ♕f2 ♘d4 ∓ Lukianov-Cherniaev, Arkhangelsk 1993.

13 ... ba

After **13...♖b8** the weakness of the b5-pawn makes itself felt. This theoretical conclusion was once more underlined in the duel Krivets-Koglin, Bled 1994: 14 ab ab 15 ♗d3 ♗e6 16 ♕e2 ♗xd5 17 ed ♘e7 18 ♘b4 f5 19 ♗xb5, and Black's counterplay scarcely made up for the loss of the pawn.

14 ♖xa4 a5

After the move **14...♖b8**, Tiviakov-Degraeve, Oakham 1992 saw **15 ♕a1** a5 16 ♗c4 ♔h8 17 0-0 f5 18 ef ♗xf5 19 ♘ce3 ♗g6 20 ♖d1 e4 21 ♗f1 ♘e5 22 ♖d2 with a small but solid advantage to White, while Shmuter, against Cherniaev at Sochi 1993, preferred **15 b4**, but Black equalized easily: 15...a5 16 ♗c4 ♗d7 17 ♖a3 ♗e6 18 ♖b3 ♔h8 19 0-0 ♕d7 20 ♕d3 ½-½.

After **14...♗b7** 15 ♗c4 ♘a5 16 ♗a2 ♗c6, Zagrebelny-Beshukov, Alushta 1994, tested the continuation **17 ♖a3** ♗b5 18 ♘de3 (the preliminary 18 h4! is better, and then 18...♗h6 19 ♘ce3 ♗xe3 20 ♘xe3 ♖c8 21 f3 ± Ljubojević-Salov, Barcelona 1989) 18...♖c8 19 b4 ♗xe3 20 ♘xe3 ♘c4 21 ♗xc4 ♗xc4 22 ♘xc4 ♖xc4 23 ♕d5 ♕c8 ½-½. Kiselev-Novik, St. Petersburg 1994, featured the interesting **17 ♖b4!?** ♘b7 18 h4! ♗h6 19 g4 ♗f4 20 ♘xf4 ef 21 f3 ♘c5 22 ♖d4 ♕e7 23 ♕d2 ♗a4! 24 ♘a1 ♖ab8 with an unclear game.

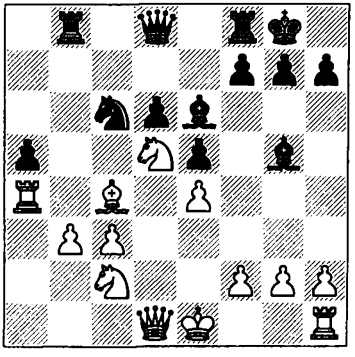
15 ♗c4 ♖b8

16 b3

With this move White strengthens the position of his bishop as well as defending his b-pawn.

16 ... ♗e6 *(D)*

A tense struggle arose after **16...♔h8** 17 0-0 g6 18 b4 ♗d7 19 ♖a3 ♗h6 20 ♕a1 ab 21 cb ♗g7 22 ♖a6 ♕h4 23 b5 ♘d4 24 ♘xd4 ed 25 ♕b1 in the game Zagrebelny-Rogozenko, Alushta 1994. Thanks to his outside passed pawn White's chances are preferable.



W

17 0-0 ♔h8

18 ♘a3!?

After **18 ♕e2** g6!? 19 ♖fa1 ♗d7! 20 ♗b5!? ♖xb5! 21 ♕xb5 ♘d4 22 ♕xa5 ♘xc2 23 ♖1a2 ♕b8 24 h4 ♗xh4 25 ♖xc2 ♗xa4 26 ♕xa4, Semeniuk-Belikov, Orel 1992, the situation on the board is quite tense in spite of the limited number of pieces remaining. White has a passed pawn, and Black has counterplay on the kingside.

18 ... g6

19 ♘b5 ♕d7

19...♘e7 20 ♘bc7! ♗d7 21 ♖a2 ♘xd5 22 ♘xd5 f5 23 ef gf 24 f4! is worse, with an advantage to White. However, **19...♖b7** deserves attention.

20 ♘dc7

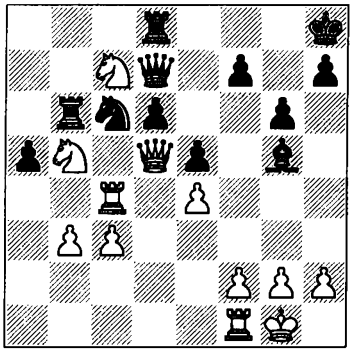
An unclear game follows **20 ♕e2** f5 21 ef gf 22 ♖d1. Here from the two possible knight moves, one most likely should make the other choice, **20 ♘bc7**.

20 ... ♗xc4

21 ♖xc4 ♖fd8

22 ♕d5 ♖b6 *(D)*

Black should not be seduced by the tempting **22...♘e7?** in view of 23 ♕xf7 ♖xb5 24 ♘e6 ♘g8 25 ♘xg5.



W

23 f4!

If White tries to execute f2-f4 under more favourable conditions, Black has time to prepare, viz. **23 g3** ♔g8! 24 f4 ♗f6 25 fe ♗xe5, and the f7-pawn is defended.

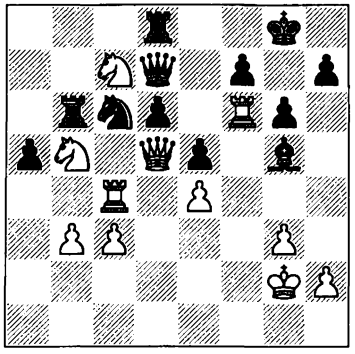
23 ... ♗xf4

24 g3 ♗e3+

25 ♔g2 ♔g8
26 ♖f6

White should have developed the initiative by means of **26 ♕d3** ♗g5 27 h4 ♗e7 28 ♘d5! ♖xb5 29 ♖xc6 ♖b7 30 ♕c4, for example, 30...♖f8 31 b4 ab 32 cb ♔g7 33 b5 ♗d8 34 b6 f5 35 ♖c8 f4 36 ♕c6!, and it is not easy for Black to defend himself.

26 ♗g5 *(D)*



W

27 ♖xd6 ♕g4
28 ♖xd8+

The following line would have led to a draw: **28 ♕d3** ♖xd6 29 ♘xd6 ♖xb3 30 ♕c2! ♘d4! 31 ♖xd4 (31 cd ♕f3+ 32 ♔h3 ♕h5+; 31 ♕f2 ♖b2! 32 ♕xb2 ♕f3+) 31...ed 32 ♕xb3 ♕e2+ 33 ♔h3 ♕h5+.

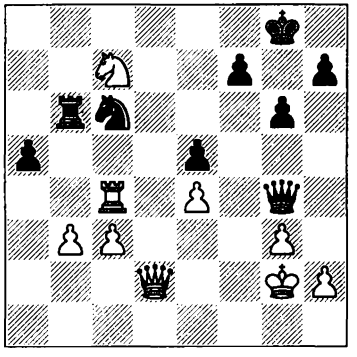
28 ... ♗xd8
29 ♕d2

Black has an interesting defensive resource after **29 ♔f2** ♗xc7 30 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 31 ♕xc6 ♕d1!!. Now taking the bishop leads to a perpetual check: 32 ♘xc7 ♕d2+ 33 ♔f3 ♕d3+ 34 ♔g4 ♕d1+ 35 ♔g5 ♕d8+, and not 36 ♕f6 because of 36...h6+. Petrushin should have resigned himself to a drawish outcome and gone into this variation or a repetition of moves with 29 ♕d3 ♕c8 30 ♕d5 ♕g4.

29 ... ♗xc7

After **29...♕c8** 30 ♕d5 ♕g4 the position is repeated. But now Belikov rejects a peaceful outcome.

30 ♘xc7 *(D)*



B

30 ♘d4!

A spectacular piece sacrifice, which, although it doesn't change the assessment of the position, presents White with several tricky problems.

31 cd ♕xe4+
32 ♔g1 ♖xb3
33 ♖c1!

33 ♘e8 loses to 33...♖b1+ 34 ♔f2 ♕f5+ 35 ♔e3 ed+ 36 ♖xd4 ♖b3+ 37 ♖d3 ♕e6+.

33	**...**	**ed**
34	**♖e1**	**♖b1**
35	**♖xb1**	**♕xb1+**
36	**♔f2**	**a4**
37	**♕xd4**	

White should perhaps not have parted company with his knight. The continuation **37** ♘**a6!** ♕h1 38 ♕xd4 ♕xh2+ 39 ♔f3, with a perpetual check, doesn't look so bad.

37	**...**	**♕c2+**
38	**♔g1**	**♕xc7**
39	**♕xa4**	**♕c1+**
40	**♔g2**	**♕d2+**
41	**♔f3**	**♕b2**

Capturing on h2 gives nothing, as now White can give a perpetual check, for example **41...♕xh2** 42 ♕e8+ ♔g7 43 ♕e5+ f6 44 ♕c7+ ♔h6 45 ♕f4+.

42	**♕e4**	**♔g7**
43	**h4**	**♕a1**
44	**♔g2**	**♕a2+**
45	**♔g1**	**♕e6**
46	**♕d4+**	**♕f6**
47	**♕d5**	**♕f5**
48	**♕d4+**	**♕f6**
49	**♕d5**	**♕b2**
50	**h5!**	**♕b1+**
51	**♔g2**	**♕c2+**
52	**♔g1**	**♕c3**

½-½

Conclusion

In the games in this first chapter, White's hopes are linked with play on the queenside (in many cases this is accounted for by the fact that Black does not hinder a2-a4) and in the centre. Black prepares an assault on the kingside. But in general this means that play is spread over the whole board. As we can see, the engagement turns into a full-blooded battle, and he who is the more inventive and resourceful will be the victor.

2 9...♗e7 10 ♗xf6; 12...♖b8

Quite often Black does not allow his opponent to play the automatic a2-a4 so easily, by adopting the precautionary ...♖a8-b8. In this case White must devote more attention to the centre and kingside.

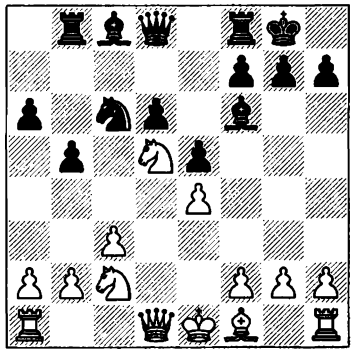
In a tense battle Black's chances aren't too bad (as Black's chances go). The light-squared bishop does not play its previous role (as in Game 3, for instance), which often turns out better for his opponent. Kamsky demonstrates this plan by exchanging this bishop even at the price of apparently strengthening Black's pawn centre. The American Grandmaster's play is more profound, not using the particular weakness of d5, but of the pawn centre as a whole.

Game 5
Kamsky – Lputian
Biel IZ 1993

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 e5 5 ♘b5 d6 6 ♘1c3 a6 7 ♘a3 b5 8 ♘d5 ♘f6 9 ♗g5 ♗e7 10 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 11 c3 0-0 12 ♘c2

12 ... ♖b8 *(D)*

A prophylactic move, directed against 13 a4.



W

13 ♗e2

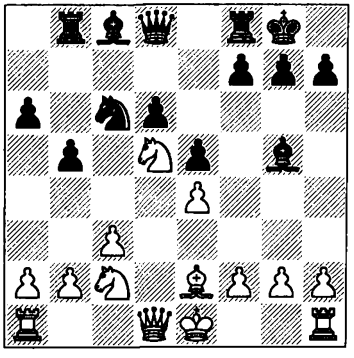
This plan, linked with immediate pressure on the d6-pawn, was conceived in A.Sokolov-Vaiser, Reunion 1991: **13 ♕d3** ♗g5 14 ♖d1 f5 (if 14...♗e6 then 15 ♘cb4 ♘xb4 16 ♘xb4 ♖b6 17 ♗e2 ±) 15 ♘de3 f4 (it is a mistake to swap prematurely on e3: 15...♗xe3 16 ♘xe3 f4 17 ♘f5 ±) 16 ♘f5 and now **16...♗xf5** 17 ef ♕b6 18 ♗e2 ♖bd8 19 ♗f3 ♘e7 20 h4 ♗h6 21 ♘b4 ♘f5 22 ♘d5! ♕a7 23 ♗e4 g6 24 h5, and here 24...♔g7 25 ♕h3 ♖h8 26 ♗xf5 gf 27 ♕xf5 ♖hf8 would have left Black with good defensive possibilities.

With a different move order, the position after 16 ♘f5 arose in the game Ioseliani-Cholushkina,

Manila wom OL 1992. Here the Ukrainian player moved more energetically with **16...d5**. After 17 h4 de 18 ♕xe4 ♗xf5 19 ♕xc6, she could by means of 19...♕e8 have seized the initiative.

White may try **13 ♗d3**, for example **13...♗g5** 14 0-0 ♗e6 15 a4 ba 16 ♘db4 ♘e7 17 ♗xa6 f5 18 ef ♖xf5 19 ♗d3 ♖f6 20 ♖xa4 d5 with compensation for the pawn, Nikolenko-Dolmatov, Moscow 1992, or **13...♗e6** 14 ♘ce3 ♗g5 15 0-0 ♘e7 16 ♗c2 ♗xe3 17 ♘xe3 b4 with equality, Aseev-Yakovich, St. Petersburg 1993.

13 ♗g5 *(D)*



W

14 0-0

In this situation it is again not necessary to hurry into castling, for example, **14 ♕d3** a5 15 ♖d1 ♗e6 **16 ♘ce3** ♗xe3 17 ♘xe3 ♗xa2 18 ♕xd6 ♕xd6 19 ♖xd6 ♘e7 20 0-0 Lanka-Koivisto, Cappelle la Grande 1992. After 20...♗b3 21 ♖d7! ♘g6 22 g3 White's chances are preferable. Also **16 a3** ♘e7 17 ♘ce3 ♘xd5 18 ♘xd5 g6 19 b4 f5 20 ♗f3 ♔h8 in Brodsky-Beshukov, Helsinki 1992, led only to equality.

14 ... a5

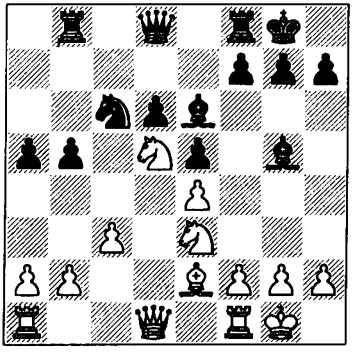
Taking the b4-square away from the knight and preparing ...b5-b4.

15 ♘ce3

15 ♕d3 is still an alternative. Mikhalets-Titov, Alushta 1994, developed thus: 15...♗e6 16 ♘ce3 g6 17 ♖fd1 ♕d7 18 b4 f5 19 a4 ba 20 b5 fe 21 ♕xe4 ♕f7 22 ♗c4 ♕xf2+ 23 ♔h1 ♘d8 24 ♖a2 ♕f7 and Black gained a material advantage, although the position is quite tense.

15 ... ♗e6 *(D)*

15...♘e7 16 ♕d3 ♗xe3 17 ♘xe3 ♕b6 18 ♖fd1 ♖d8 19 a4 ba 20 ♘c4 is not bad, and in this position from Oll-Yakovich, Moscow 1992, the players agreed a draw.



W

16 ♕d3 ♗xe3

After **16...♘e7** a position arises from the game Ki.Georgiev-V.Spasov, Sofia 1992. This continued 17 ♖fd1 ♘xd5 18 ♘xd5 ♕d7 19 ♕g3 ♗d8 20 b3! ♔h8 (20...♖c8!?) 21 c4 bc 22 ♗xc4 g6 (22...a4!?) 23 f4!? ef 24 ♕xf4 f5! with chances for both sides.

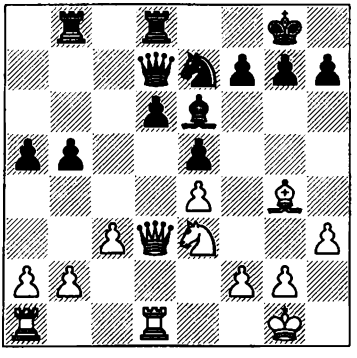
17 ♘xe3 ♕d7

A more precise move in comparison with the quickplay game Kamsky-Ivanchuk, Tilburg 1992, where Black continued **17...♕c7**, which was followed by 18 ♖fd1 ♖fd8 19 ♗g4 ♘e7 20 ♕e2 d5 21 ♗xe6 fe 22 ♕g4 ♖b6 23 ♕g3 ♖c6 with a sharp game.

18 h3

Preparing to exchange the light-squared bishop.

18 ... ♖fd8
19 ♗g4 ♘e7
20 ♖fd1 *(D)*



B

A position of dynamic equilibrium has arisen. Lputian should now have continued **20...♕c7**, for example 21 ♗xe6 fe 22 a4 b4 (better than 22...ba 23 ♕c4 ♕xc4 24 ♘xc4 d5 25 ed ed 26 ♘xe5 ♖xb2 27 ♖xa4, when the endgame is somewhat better for White) 23 c4 ♕c5 24 ♖d2 ♘c6, and everything is in order for Black.

20 ♖bc8?!

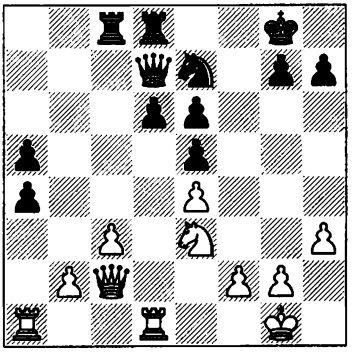
This move allows White to realize his strategic plan with great energy.

21 ♗xe6 fe
22 a4!

Now if **22...b4**, then 23 cb ab 24 ♘c4 and Black is in a truly sorry state.

22 ... ba
23 ♕c2 *(D)*

Of course not **23 ♘c4** ♕b5 24 ♘xd6 ♕xb2, with a good game for Black.



B

23 ... ♖b8?

A terrible mistake, after which Black's game goes quickly downhill. He should have continued **23...♕b5**, and after 24 ♖d2 d5 25 ♕xa4 ♕xa4 26 ♖xa4 ♖c5 he could still have held on.

24 ♘c4 ♕b5

25 ♕xa4

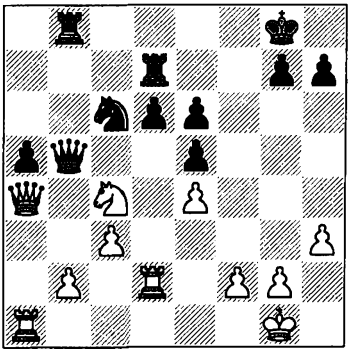
There are too many weaknesses in Black's camp: on a5, d6 and e5.

25 ... ♘c6

26 ♖d2!

A precise precautionary move. It would be easy to let go of one's advantage after **26 ♘xd6** ♕xa4 27 ♖xa4 ♖xb2, or **26 ♕a2** d5 27 ed ed 28 ♘xa5 ♘xa5 29 ♕xa5 ♕xb2 30 ♖xd5 ♕xa1+ 31 ♕xa1 ♖xd5.

26 ♖d7 *(D)*

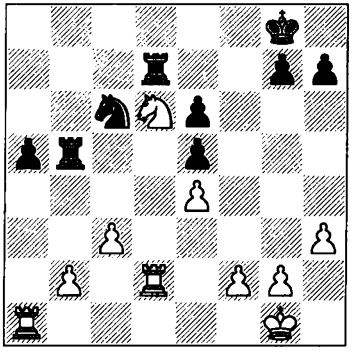


W

It is not possible to escape losses with other continuations either, for example, **26...d5** 27 ♘xa5, or **26...♕c5** 27 ♘xa5 ♖a8 28 b4!, and now not 28...♕xc3 because of 29 ♖c2.

27 ♕xb5 ♖xb5

28 ♘xd6 *(D)*



B

Besides the fact that White has an extra pawn, the weaknesses in Black's position are maintained. However, in order to win Kamsky must overcome definite technical complications.

28 ... ♖b8

29 ♖ad1 ♔f8

30 ♘c4

In time trouble, Kamsky aims for simplification. 30 ♔f1 was more exact, moving his king towards the centre.

30 ... ♖xd2

31 ♖xd2 ♔e7

32 h4

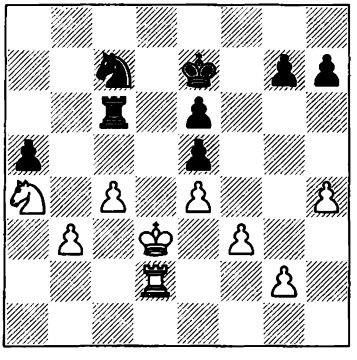
Again 32 ♔f1 would have been better, because he could then meet the manoeuvre ...♖b8-b5-c5 with ♔e2-d3, defending the knight.

32	**...**	**♖b5**
33	**♔f1**	**♖c5**
34	**♘b6?!**	

The knight is a little more comfortable on e3.

34	**...**	**♘b8**
35	**f3**	**♖c6**
36	**♘a4**	**♘d7**
37	**♔e2**	**♘f6**
38	**b3**	**♘e8**
39	**c4**	**♘c7**
40	**♔d3?!** *(D)*	

As so often happens, a time-control move is a mistake. He should have continued with **40 ♖a2**, and if 40...♘a6, then 41 ♘b2 ♖b6 42 ♖xa5 ♖xb3 43 ♘d3 ♘b4 44 ♘xe5 winning.



B

40	**...**	**♘a6**
41	**♔c3**	**♖c7**

Of course not **41...♘c7**, because of 42 c5, followed by ♔c3-c4.

42	**♘b2**	**♘b4**
43	**♘d3**	**♘c6**
44	**♖a2**	

44 g3 followed by f3-f4 deserves attention.

44	**...**	**h6!**
45	**♖a4**	**g5**
46	**hg**	**hg**
47	**c5**	**g4**

Black's only chance lies in resisting his opponent's attack on the queenside. However, this too seems insufficient.

48	**fg!**	**♔f6**
49	**b4**	**ab+**

It was worth trying for a happier outcome with **49...♘xb4** 50 ♖xa5 (50 ♘xb4 ♖xc5+ leads quickly to a draw) 50...♘c6 51 ♖a6, although here as well White preserves winning chances.

50	**♘xb4**	**♘a7**
51	**♘d3**	**♘c8**
52	**♖a6**	**♖g7**
53	**♖a8**	**♖c7**
54	**♔b4**	**♔g5**
55	**♘xe5**	**♔f4**
56	**♘c4!**	**♔xg4**

Unfortunately for Black, the reponse **56...♔xe4** is impossible because White would play 57 ♖xc8 ♖xc8 58 ♘d6+.

57	**♘d6**	**♘e7**
58	**♔b5**	**♔f4**
59	**♖a6**	**e5?**

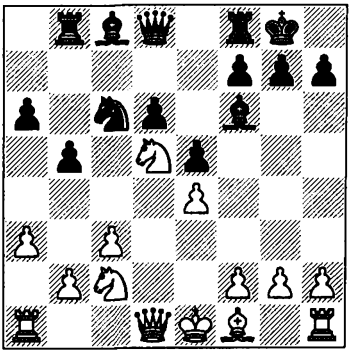
The final error. Only **59...♔e5** would have prolonged the contest.

60	**♖a3!**	**♘g6**
61	**♔b6**	**1-0**

In the following battle the Latvian Grandmaster Shirov directs the white pieces with great success. Moreover, in contrast to the 'black' Shirov, a scandalously composed troublemaker, here he plays in strictly positional mode. Complex prophylactic measures (13 a3 and 14 h4) lead quickly to success.

Game 6
Shirov – Illescas
Linares 1994

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 e5 5 ♘b5 d6 6 ♘1c3 a6 7 ♘a3 b5 8 ♘d5 ♘f6 9 ♗g5 ♗e7 10 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 11 c3 0-0 12 ♘c2 ♖b8
13 a3 *(D)*



B

A logical new plan, restricting Black's activity on both flanks.

13 a5

In the game Lanka-Laduguie, Cannes 1993, Black decided to move his bishop quickly to the c1-h6 diagonal. This is how it turned out: **13...♗g5** 14 h4 ♗h6 15 g3 ♗e6 16 ♘cb4 ♗xd5 17 ♘xd5 a5 18 b4 a4 19 ♗h3 g6 20 0-0 with a big positional advantage to White.

14 h4

Not allowing the black bishop the possibility of occupying an active position on g5. Naturally, the pawn is unassailable: 14...♗xh4?? 15 ♕h5.

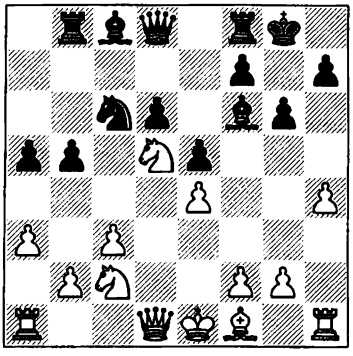
Bologan treated this position in a different way against Redona, France 1994: **14 ♗d3** ♗e6 15 ♕e2 ♗xd5 16 ed ♘e7 17 0-0-0 and then after **17...♕b6** 18 ♔b1 g6 19 h4! ♗g7 20 h5 f5 21 hg hg 22 g4! White's threats on the kingside were very serious indeed. All this draws attention to some riskiness in White's play. Why can Black not make use of this? In our opinion, the bold **17...b4!?** leads to a sharp game, where Black's prospects are by no means so bad.

14 ... g6 *(D)*

14...♗e6 brings Black no joy. The game Stripunsky-Kandybko, Alushta 1994 continued: 15 ♘ce3 b4 16 ab ab 17 g3 bc 18 bc ♘a5 (an unsuccessful manoeuvre, but Black's position inspires serious fears) 19 ♗g2 ♘b3 20 ♖a6, and White has a winning position.

Vladimir Kramnik defended the black position more successfully

in the PCA quickplay event against Garry Kasparov, Moscow 1994: **14...♘e7** 15 ♘ce3 ♘xd5 16 ♘xd5 ♗e6 17 g3 ♕d7 18 ♗g2 ♗d8! (a standard transfer of the bishop to an active position) 19 0-0 ♗b6 20 ♕d2 ♖fc8 21 ♖fd1 ♗xd5 22 ♕xd5 b4 23 ab ab 24 ♕xd6 ♕g4 25 ♕d3 bc 26 bc g6 27 ♖ab1 ♖d8 28 ♕f3 ♖xd1+ 29 ♖xd1 ♕xf3 30 ♗xf3 ♖c8 ½-½.



W

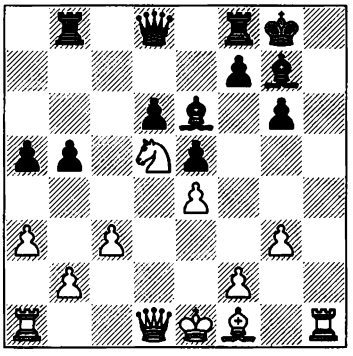
15 g3 ♗g7
16 h5

In this situation this move is quite opportune. The h4-pawn's role as a watchman has been fulfilled and he is now being used as a battering ram.

16 ♘e7

Illescas is trying to defuse his opponent's pressure through exchanges, but his lack of any kind of counterplay predetermines Shirov's stable advantage.

17 hg hg
18 ♘ce3 ♘xd5
19 ♘xd5 ♗e6 *(D)*



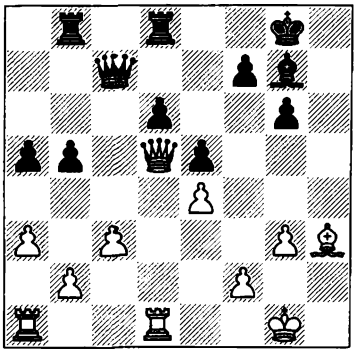
W

20 ♗h3!

Now Black must decide whether to exchange his bishop or leave it on e6. If he swaps on h3, the 'permanent' knight on d5 will dominate, as it has no opposition; if he leaves the bishop, Black's pawn weaknesses (after ♗xe6 fxe6) will be too tangible. Most likely he should choose **20...♖b7** 21 ♗xe6 fe 22 ♘e3 ♖bf7, while **20...♕d7** and **20...♕g5** are also possible. After taking on d5, of the four minor pieces, Black's remain the most passive.

20 ... ♗xd5
21 ♕xd5 ♕c7
22 0-0 ♖fd8
23 ♖fd1 *(D)*

Precisely this rook. The other one is excellently placed on a1.



B

23 ... ♗h6
24 ♗f1

Beginning to take a close look at Black's weaknesses.

24 ... ♕b7?!

24...♕b6 would have been more exact; now Illescas's position is collapsing like a house of cards.

25 ♕xb7 ♖xb7
26 ♖d5 b4
27 cb ab
28 a4!

White's a-pawn cannot be restrained.

28 ... ♔f8
29 a5 ♗g5
30 a6 ♖b6
31 ♖b5 1-0

Yet another magnificent chess masterpiece. In the 13 h4 variation the sharpest of struggles arose immediately, with sacrifices and counter-sacrifices, but also mistakes on both sides...

Game 7
Kasparov – Kramnik
Novgorod 1994

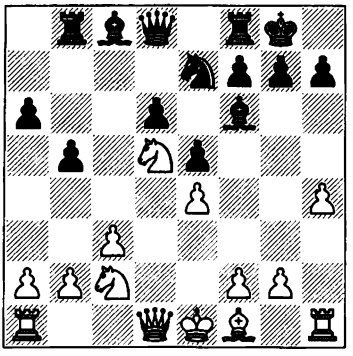
1 e4 c5 2 ♘c3 ♘c6 3 ♘ge2 ♘f6 4 d4 cd 5 ♘xd4 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♘d5 ♗e7 10 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 11 c3 0-0 12 ♘c2 ♖b8
13 h4

Judit Polgar's attempt to resurrect the old continuation **13 b4** was not starred with success. Her game against Kramnik, New York Intel rpd 1994 continued thus: 13...♘e7 14 ♘ce3 ♗g5 15 ♘xe7+ ♕xe7 16 ♘d5 ♕b7 17 a4 ♗e6 18 g3 ♖fc8 19 ♖a3 ♗xd5 20 ed e4 21 ♗e2 ♗f6 22 0-0 ♗xc3, and White had got nowhere.

13 ... ♘e7 *(D)*

After **13...g6** Berelovich-Kandybko, Alushta 1994, developed thus: **14 h5** (an illogical move allowing the black bishop to occupy g5) 14...♗g5 15 ♕f3 ♗e6 16 ♖d1 ♖b7 17 ♗e2 f5 with good counter-chances for Black. Shmuter played more accurately against Beshukov, Sochi 1993: **14 ♕d2** ♗g7 15 h5 ♗e6 16 ♘ce3 ♘e7 17 g3 ♘xd5 18 ♘xd5 ♖c8 19 ♖d1 ±.

After **13...♗e6** as well, in Yurtaev-Holsten, Helsinki 1992, White managed to seize the initiative: 14 ♘ce3 a5 15 ♕f3 b4?! (15...♗g5!?) 16 ♗c4 bc 17 bc ♖b2 18 g3 a4 19 0-0 ♗e7 20 ♖ab1.



W

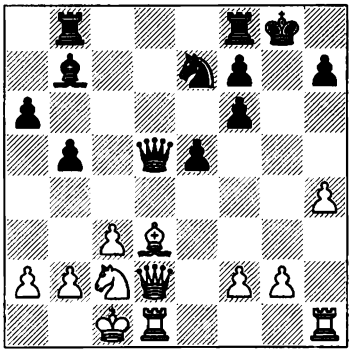
14 ♘xf6+

Typically, Kasparov chooses the route which leads to a dramatic aggravation of the game. Another quieter possibility was **14 ♘ce3**, as played in Stripunsky-Volke, Pardubice 1994, when White managed to gain victory without recourse to surgical methods: 14...♘xd5 15 ♘xd5 ♗b7 16 g3 ♗xd5? (of course, shooting oneself in the foot by exchanging this important bishop was not strictly necessary; 16...♖c8 followed by ...♖c8-c5, or 16...g6 and ...♗f6-g7 deserved attention) 17 ♕xd5 b4 18 ♗xa6 bc 19 bc ♕b6 20 ♗c4 ♕b2 21 0-0 ♕xc3 22 ♖ac1 ♕f3 23 ♖ce1 ♖b2 24 ♖e3 ♕h5 25 a4 ♗d8 26 a5 g5 27 hg ♕xg5 28 ♖f3 ♖d2 29 ♕b7 1-0.

14	**...**	**gf**
15	**♕d2**	**♗b7**
16	**♗d3**	**d5**

Black begins active counterplay in the centre, since otherwise his position might become critical. However, **16...♔h8** with the idea of ...♖f8-g8, was an alternative.

17	**ed**	**♕xd5**
18	**0-0-0!** *(D)*	



B

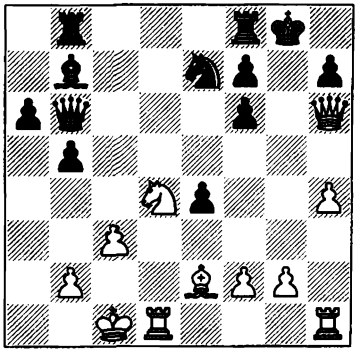
A very promising pawn sacrifice for the initiative. The knight on c2 is beautifully placed. He not only reliably shields the king, but is also ready to take part in an attack at any moment.

18	**...**	**e4**

18...♕xa2 19 ♕h6 e4 changes nothing.

19	**♗e2**	**♕xa2**
20	**♕h6**	**♕e6**
21	**♘d4**	**♕b6** *(D)*
22	**♖h3?!**	

A tempting move, which nevertheless reduces the tempo of the attack and gives Black the possibility of seizing the initiative. **22 g4!** with the threats of ♘d4-f5 and g4-g5 was very strong. In that case



W

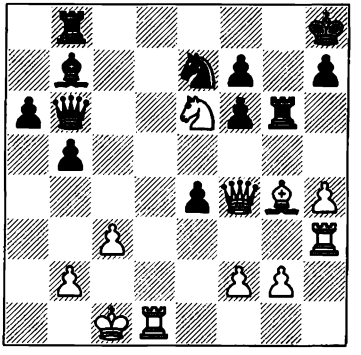
Kramnik would have faced some very difficult problems.

22 ... ♔h8
23 ♗g4 ♖g8
24 ♘e6

Many publications have given this move two exclamation marks. Kasparov is carrying out his attack very resourcefully, but the position after his error on move 22 gives him no basis for relying even on equality, let alone an advantage.

24 ... ♖g6
25 ♕f4 *(D)*
25 ♖e8??

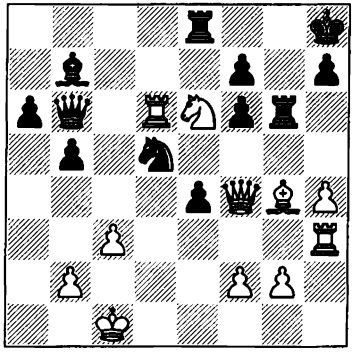
In a sharp position the value of every move is unbelievably high. A single mistake is capable of turning the best position into a lost one. If Kramnik had played **25...♗d5**, White would have had to sound a retreat, as after **26 h5** Black has 26...♖xg4 27 ♕xg4 ♗xe6. The only possibility that does not lose material is **26 ♘d4**. At Kramnik's



B

fatal text move, Kasparov conducts the concluding part of this battle with great strength.

26 ♖d6 ♘d5 *(D)*



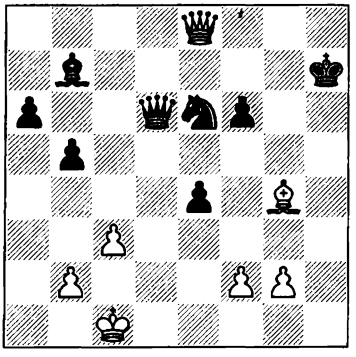
W

27 h5!!

This sudden blow undoubtedly deserves the highest praise. In this position, where practically all the white pieces are under attack, and the pressure seems to have reached its limit, Kasparov finds a possibility to add more fuel to the fire.

Now in just a few moves the h-pawn's career reaches the dizzying heights about which a rook's pawn can usually only dream – queening in the centre.

27	**...**	**♘xf4**
28	**hg**	**♕xd6**
29	**♖xh7+**	**♔g8**
30	**gf+**	**♔xh7**
31	**fe♕**	**♘xe6** *(D)*



W

It is as though a tornado has been raging above the board for the last five moves, but the little strength remaining to White is quite enough for him to organize a conclusive assault.

32 ♗f5+!

An important intervening move.

32	**...**	**♔g7**
33	**♕g6+**	**♔f8**
34	**♕xf6+**	**♔e8**
35	**♗xe6**	**♕f8?**

35...♗c6 would have prolonged the battle, but would not have saved the game. Not waiting for 36 ♗d7+, Black resigned.

1-0

Conclusion

In the 12...♖b8 variation Black experiences definite difficulties, but they are fully surmountable in the future. However in the games we have examined, White has wielded the initiative. Moreover, his arsenal is quite varied: play against the pawn centre, seizure of d5, and a direct attack on the king. Black, meanwhile, has not managed to arrange any counterplay. Good luck to him!

3 9...♗e7 10 ♘xe7

In this variation White weakens control over d5, stressing the free development of his pieces. Insofar as the capture on e7 enjoys relatively less popularity than other variations, choosing it leaves more scope for creative play.

Game 8
Anand – Ivanchuk
Linares (4) 1992

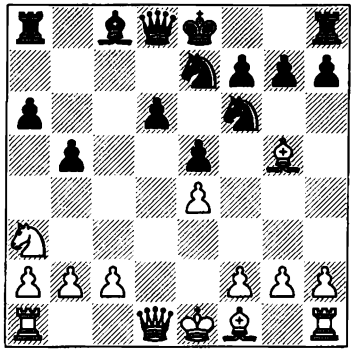
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♘d5 ♗e7

10 ♘xe7

White's idea consists of freely developing his pieces. Besides, in some cases he preserves the advantage of the bishop pair. This is thought to give Black sufficient counterchances for equality.

10 ... ♘xe7 *(D)*

11 ♗d3



W

Other possibilities:

a) **11 ♗xf6 gf** and then:

a1) **12 c4!?** ♗b7 13 cb ♗xe4 14 ba! d5 (14...♕a5+ 15 ♕d2 ♕xd2+ 16 ♔xd2; 14...0-0 15 ♗e2 ±) 15 ♗b5+ ♔f8 16 0-0 ♕b6 17 ♔h1 ♘f5 (17...d4!?) 18 f3!? ♘e3 19 ♕d2 (19 ♕b3!?) 19...♗f5 (19...♘xf1 20 ♖xf1 ♗f5 21 ♕xd5) 20 ♖fe1 d4 21 ♖ac1 ± Nadanian-Zontakh, Kiev 1992.

a2) **12 ♕f3** f5 13 ef d5 14 f6 ♘g6 15 ♖d1 ♗e6 16 g3 ♖c8 17 c3 e4 17 ♕e3 ♕f6 18 ♗g2 b4! 19 ♘b1 ♘e5 20 0-0 0-0 21 f3 ♘c4 22 ♕e2 e3! 23 b3 bc!! 24 bc d4 25 ♘a3 ♖fd8 ∓ Unni-Prasad, Indian Ch 1991.

b) **11 ♕f3** and now:

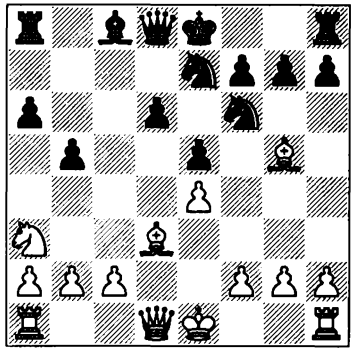
b1) **11...♗g4?!** 12 ♕g3 ♗e6 (12...d5!?) 13 ♗d3 ♘g6 and now **14 0-0** 0-0 15 c4! h6 16 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 17 cb ab 18 ♘xb5 ♗xa2 19 ♖fc1 ± was Kupreichik-Dreev, Podolsk 1990, while the game Yudasin-Yagupov, Moscow 1992 quickly moved into an ending: **14 ♕f3!?** d5 15 c3! h6 16 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 17

♕xf6 gf 18 g3 de 19 ♗xe4 ♖b8 20 ♘c2 f5 with an unclear game.

b2) **11...♘d7** 12 b4! f6 (12...h6 is worse: 13 ♗d2 ♗b7 14 c4 bc 15 ♘xc4 ♘f6! 16 ♗d3 d5 17 ed ♗xd5 18 ♕g3! although rather than the faulty 18...e4?! 19 ♗e2 0-0 20 ♘e3 ♗e6 21 ♗c3 of Yudasin-Chekhov, Moscow 1991, there is 18...♗xc4! 19 ♗xc4 ♘e4 20 ♕e3 ♕xd2+, and White's advantage is not that great) 13 ♗d2 ♘b6 (13...♗b7!? 14 c4 f5 15 cb ♗xe4 16 ♕g3!? 0-0 17 ba f4 18 ♕b3+; 13...0-0 14 c4 ♘c6 15 ♘c2 ♖b8 16 ♕c3 ♘e7 17 ♘e3 ♔h8 18 cb ab = Fishbein-Vaiser, Tel Aviv 1992) 14 c4 bc 15 ♘xc4 ♗e6 16 ♘a5! 0-0 17 ♗d3 ♕d7 18 ♕e2 ♘c6 19 ♘xc6 ♕xc6 20 0-0 ♕b7 21 ♖fc1 f5!? 22 ef ♗xf5 23 ♗xf5 ♖xf5 24 b5 d5! 25 g4!? ♖f6 26 ba ♕d7 was unclear in Yudasin-Chekhov, USSR Ch 1991.

c) **11 f3** d5?! (11...♘g6!? or 11...h6!?) 12 ed ♕xd5 13 c4 ♕c5 14 cb e4 15 ♕c1 ♕e5 16 ♗f4 ♕f5 17 ♘c4 0-0 18 ♘d6 ♕e6 19 ♗c4 ♘ed5 20 0-0 e3 21 ♖e1 ♕e7 22 ♗g3 ♖d8 23 ♗xd5 ♘xd5 24 ♕c6 ♗e6 25 b6 ± Galdunts-Jelen, Groningen 1993.

Now we return to the main line after 11 ♗d3 *(D)*:



B

11 ♗b7

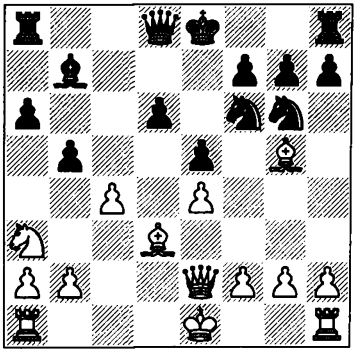
Black can also attempt to make a rapid breakthrough in the centre with **11...d5 12 exd5** :

a) In the game Aseev-Vyzhmanavin, USSR 1990 White managed to gain a small advantage after **12...♕xd5** 13 ♕d2 ♗f5 (it's dangerous to accept the pawn sacrifice after 13...♕xg2 14 0-0-0; White also gets the better chances upon 13...♘e4 14 ♕e3 ♘xg5 15 ♕xg5) 14 ♗xf5 ♕xd2+ 15 ♗xd2 ♘xf5 16 c4 0-0! 17 0-0 ♖fb8 18 ♖ae1 ♖e8 19 ♗c3 ♘d7 20 cb f6! 21 ♖a1 ♘b6 22 ba ±.

b) However, taking the pawn with the knight in Yudasin-Yakovich, Moscow 1992, led after **12...♘fxd5** 13 c4 bc 14 ♘xc4 f6 15 ♗d2 0-0 16 0-0 ♗f5 17 ♗xf5 ♘xf5 18 ♗a5 ♕d7 19 ♕g4 ♖a7 20 ♖fd1 ♘d4 21 ♕xd7 ♖xd7 to a level ending.

12 ♕e2 0-0

A new move. **12...♘g6** deserves attention, for example **13 c4** (13 ♗xf6 gf! is also interesting, with an unclear game) and now *(D)*:



B

a) **13...h6!** 14 ♗d2 (Black is handed the initiative after 14 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 15 cb ♘f4 16 ♕f3 ♕g6 with pressure on e4) 14...bc 15 ♘xc4 0-0 16 ♘a5?! (16 0-0 would have allowed White to maintain the balance) 16...♗c8 17 0-0 ♘f4! 18 ♗xf4 ef! 19 ♘c4 ♖b8, and the pressure on e4 predetermines Black's superiority, A.Bach-Gagarin, Turnu-Severin 1992.

b) **13...b4** was tested in Wolff-Kuijf, Wijk aan Zee 1992: 14 ♘c2 a5 (a pawn sacrifice for the initiative deserves attention: 14...h6 15 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 16 ♘xb4 ♘f4 16 ♕f3 ♕g6) 15 f3 h6 16 ♗e3 ♘d7 17 0-0 0-0 18 ♕d2 ♕c7 19 ♖fd1 ♘c5 20 ♗f1 ♖ad8 21 ♕f2! ♘e7 22 g4 ♕c6 23 b3 ♖b8 24 ♖d2, and Wolff managed to wrap up the victory quickly.

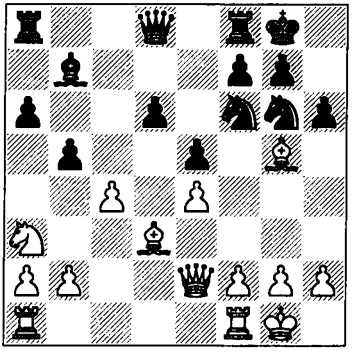
13 0-0

13 ♖d1 is also quite acceptable. Wolff-Shaked, New York 1994, continued 13...♘g6 14 0-0 h6 15 ♗c1 ♖e8 16 c4 bc 17 ♘xc4 ♘f4 18 ♗xf4 ef 19 ♕f3 ♗xe4 20 ♗xe4 ♘xe4 21 ♕xf4 d5 22 ♘e3 ♘f6 23 ♘f5 with a clear plus for White.

13 ... ♘g6

If **13...d5**, then 14 ♖ad1 is unpleasant.

14 c4 h6! *(D)*



W

A typical pawn sacrifice. Black remains at the mercy of fate on the queenside, but manages to organize counterplay on the kingside. Besides this, after the file has been opened, the a2- and b2-pawns are constantly needed for defence.

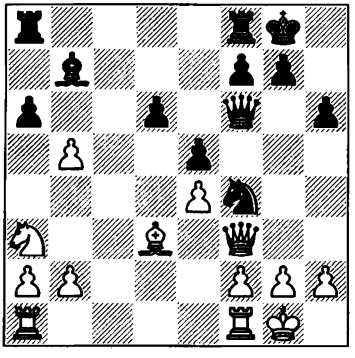
15 ♗xf6

It was perhaps worth fighting for an advantage by refusing to exchange: **15 ♗d2** (15 ♗e3 ♘xe4) 15...b4 16 ♘c2 (16 ♗xb4 ♘f4 17 ♕f3 ♘xd3 18 ♕xd3 ♘xe4 gives nothing) 16...a5 17 ♖fd1 ♕c7 18 f3.

15 ... ♕xf6
16 cb

Now White must think about precautionary measures to prevent the knight invading on f4, for example, **16 g3** ♕g5 17 ♔h1 f5 18 f3, and although the position remains quite confused, White may preserve some hopes for success. The text move quickly leads the game into calmer waters.

16 ... ♘f4
17 ♕f3 *(D)*



B

17 ab

Now Ivanchuk may in his turn try for an advantage: **17...♘xd3!?** 18 ♕xd3 ♕g6 19 ♖fe1 (if 19 f3, then 19...d5 is very strong) 19...f5 (19...d5 is not very good yet because of 20 ♕g3 ♕xg3 21 hg de 22 ba ♖xa6 23 ♘c4, and White has a small advantage) 20 ♕g3 (20 ♕b3+ ♔h8 21 ba ♗xe4 22 f3 ♖fb8 is worse, as is 20 f3 fe 21 fe ♖f4 in both cases with initiative to Black) 20...♕xg3 21 hg ♗xe4 (21...fe is also quite possible) 22 ♘c4 ♖f6.

18 ♘xb5 ♕g6
19 ♖fd1

Anand must observe caution. **19 ♖fe1** d5 20 ♗f1 de is dangerous for White.

19 ... ♘xd3
20 ♕xd3 ♗xe4
21 ♕g3 ♖fb8!

After this the position is totally level.

22 ♘xd6 ♖xb2
23 ♘c4 ½-½

A short game, but one rich in content!

Conclusion

In this variation Black has no difficulties.

4 9...♕a5+

In this variation Black presents his opponent with a cunning psychological problem. Indeed, it's as if he is silently offering a draw. In fact, in reply to 10 ♗d2 Black has nothing better to do than 10...♕d8. True, after 11 ♗g5 he can rethink and transpose into a 'normal' variation. In the majority of instances White prefers to play for the win, and then in this variation as well, an interesting and tense struggle, characteristic of the system as a whole, arises.

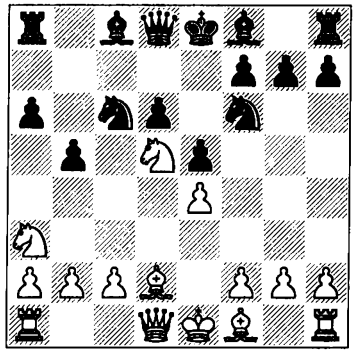
Game 8
Kupreichik – N.Nikčević
Cattolica 1992

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♘c3 ♘f6 4 d4 cd 5 ♘xd4 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♘d5

9 ... ♕a5+

Black does not hide his peace-loving intentions. He is prepared for a repetition of moves. However, an unpleasant surprise awaits him...

10 ♗d2 ♕d8 *(D)*



W

11 c4!

This is not the only important move to avoid the repetition:

a) **11 ♗d3** is a move that has been played by Evgeny Sveshnikov, the main expert in this line:

a1) **11...♗e6 12 c4** and now:

a11) The game Sveshnikov-Lputian, Helsinki 1992 continued **12...♘d4!?** 13 0-0 bc 14 ♘xf6+ ♕xf6 15 ♘xc4 ♗e7 16 f4 0-0! 17 f5 ♗xc4 18 ♗xc4 ♕h4 19 ♗d5 ♖ab8 20 ♗e3 ♗g5! 21 ♕d3 and White was forced to make do with a draw.

a12) In the game Thompson-Gulbis, corr 1991, Black continued **12...bc**, followed by 13 ♕a4 ♗d7 14 ♘xc4 ♘d4 15 ♕a3 ♘xd5 16 ed ♗b5 (16...e4 17 ♗xe4 ♗b5 18 ♕e3 ±) 17 0-0 ♗xc4 18 ♗xc4 ♗e7 19 ♗xa6 0-0 20 ♕d3 ♕b6 21 ♗c4 ♕xb2 22 ♖fc1 e4 with an unclear game.

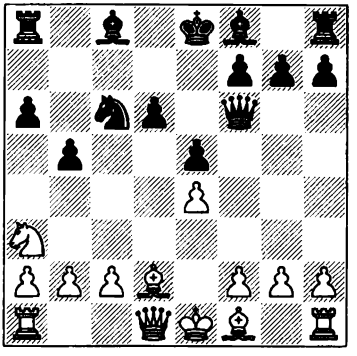
a2) **11...♗e7** is worse. White achieved a big advantage after 12 c4 ♘xd5 13 ed ♘d4 14 cb 0-0 15 0-0 ♗b7 16 ba ♗xd5 17 ♗e3! ♘e6 18 ♗xh7+ ♔xh7 19 ♕xd5 in Arakhamia-Jakob, Bern 1991.

a3) **11...♘xd5** 12 ed ♘e7 13 c4 g6 14 cb ♗g7 15 ♗c4 0-0 16 0-0 is also possible, e.g., **16...♗b7** 17 ♗g5 f6 18 ♗e3 ♘f5 19 ba ♗xa6 ± as in Kudrin-Fishbein, New York 1989, and here Kudrin had the excellent possibility 20 ♕e2!, or **16...e4** 17 ♖b1 ♘f5 18 ♗f4 ♖e8 19 ♘c2 ♕h4 20 g3 ♕f6 ± Sanden-Marković, Stockholm 1990; 21 a4! would then have strengthened White's advantage.

b) White has one more possibility, **11 ♘xf6+**. We will examine this in detail:

b1) **11...gf** had been discredited, but was rehabilitated in Herrera-Barros, Havana 1990: 12 c4 b4 13 ♘c2 ♖b8 14 b3 f5 15 ♗d3 f4 16 g3 ♕f6 17 ♕f3 ♗h6 18 0-0-0 ♖g8 19 h3 ♗e6 20 ♗e2 ♔e7 21 ♔b1 a5 with a very tense game in which Black's chances are probably no worse.

b2) **11...♕xf6** *(D)* and then:



W

b21) **12 c4** and now:

b211) **12...b4!?** 13 ♘c2 ♕g6 14 ♕f3 ♖b8 15 ♗d3 ♗e7 16 0-0 (16 ♘e3 ♗g5 17 ♕g3 0-0 18 0-0 ♗e6 19 ♖fc1 ♖fd8 20 ♗f1 a5 21 b3 ♔f8 22 h4 ♗h6 23 ♕xg6 hg with a complex game, Stefansson-Thorhallsson, Reykjavik 1992; 16 ♕g3!?) 16...0-0 17 b3 a5 ± Yudasin-Dvoirys, USSR Ch 1991; 18 ♔h1 followed by ♕f3-e2 and f2-f4 then deserved attention.

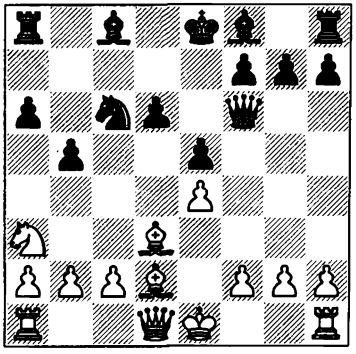
b212) **12...♕g6 13 f3** (13 cb?! ♕xe4+ 14 ♗e3 ♘d4 15 ♕d2 ♗e7 16 ba 0-0 17 ♕d3 d5! 18 ♕xe4 de 19 0-0-0 ♗e6 20 ♘c4 ♖fc8 21 b3 ♗a3+ 22 ♔d2 ♖xa6 ∓ Meyers-Poliakov, USSR 1990) **13...♗e7** and now:

b2121) **14 ♔f2** 0-0 (14...f5 15 ef ♗xf5 16 cb ♘d4 17 ♗e3 0-0 and Black has a dangerous initiative for the sacrificed pawn, Magem-Espinosa, Novi Sad OL 1990) 15 cb ♘d4 16 ♘c2 d5 17 ♘xd4 ♗c5 18 ♗e3 ed 19 ♗xd4 ♕b6 20 ♔e3 de 21 ♗xc5 ♕xc5+ 22 ♕d4 ♕e7 with compensation for Black, Yudasin-San Segundo, Madrid 1992.

b2122) **14 cb** ♗h4+ 15 g3 ♗xg3+ 16 hg ♕xg3+ 17 ♔e2 ♗g4

18 ♔e3 f5 19 bc fe 20 ♗e2 0-0 21 ♔xe4! was played in Beikhardt-Conquest, Baden-Baden 1993, and in a complex position White has all the chances.

b22) **12 ♗d3** *(D)* and now:

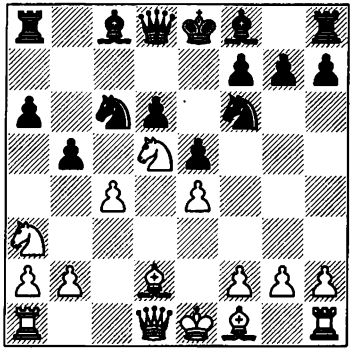


B

b221) **12...d5** 13 ed ♘b4 14 ♗e4 (14 0-0 ♘xd3 15 cd ♗d6 16 ♕b3 0-0 17 ♘c2 ♗d7 18 ♗b4 a5 19 ♗xd6 ♕xd6 20 d4 e4 21 f3 ♖ae8 with compensation for Black, de Firmian-San Segundo, New York 1990) 14...♕h4 15 ♕f3 ♗g4 (15...♗c5 16 0-0 f5?! 17 ♗xf5 0-0 18 ♕e4! ♕xe4 19 ♗xe4 ♗b7 20 c4 bc 21 ♘xc4 +– Kaiumov-Mechinsky, Gdynia 1991) 16 ♕b3 ♗h5 17 ♗f3 ♗xf3 18 ♕xf3 ♕d4 19 d6 e4 20 d7+! ♔xd7 21 ♕xf7+ ♔c6 22 ♕b3 ♕d5 23 ♗xb4 ♕xb3 24 ab ♗xb4+ 25 c3 ♗c5 26 b4 ± Wolff-Manninen, Maringo 1991.

b222) **12...♕g6** 13 0-0 (13 ♕f3 ♗e7 14 c3 0-0 15 ♘c2 ♖b8 16 0-0) 13...♗e7 14 c3 (14 ♘b1 0-0 15 ♘c3 f5 16 ef ♗xf5 17 ♗xf5 ♖xf5 18 ♗e3 ♖c8 19 a4 b4 20 ♘e4 ♕e6 21 ♕d3 d5 22 ♘g3 ♖f7 23 ♕xa6 ♘d4 24 ♕xe6 ♘xe6 25 ♖ac1 ± Shulman-Poliakov, USSR 1990; 14 f4 ef 15 e5 ♗f5 16 ♕f3 ♖c8 17 ♗xf5 ♕xf5 18 ed ♗xd6 19 ♖ae1+ ♗e7 20 ♕xf4 = I.Gurevich-Granda, New York 1992) 14...0-0 15 ♘c2 d5 16 ♕e2 ♗g4 17 f3 de 18 ♕xe4 ♖ad8! 19 fg ♖xd3 20 ♕xg6 hg 21 ♗e3 f5 22 gf gf ∓ Miranović-Marković, Novi Sad 1989.

Now we return to the main line after 11 c4 *(D)*:



B

11 ♘xe4

Other continuations lead to a difficult game for Black:

a) **11...bc** 12 ♘xc4 ♘xe4 13 ♘cb6 ♖b8 (13...♘xd2 14 ♘xa8 +–) 14 ♕a4 ±.

b) **11...b4** 12 ♘c2 ♘xe4 13 ♘cxb4 ♘xb4 14 ♗xb4 a5 15 ♗a3

♘c5 16 ♕e2 ♘e6 17 ♖d1 ♖b8 18 g3 ♘c7 19 c5 +–.

c) **11...♘xd5** 12 ed ♘d4!? (or 12...♘e7 13 cb ♘xd5 14 ♕f3! ±) 13 cb ♗e7 14 ba 0-0 15 b4! ♗xa6 16 ♗xa6 ♖xa6 17 ♘c2 ♕a8 18 ♘xd4 ed 19 a4! ♕xd5 20 0-0 ♗f6 21 b5 ♖aa8 22 ♕f3! ± Plachetka-Kostić, Austria 1990.

12 cb ♗e6

White gains a clear advantage after both 12...♘e7 13 ♗e3 ♖b8 14 ♗c4, and 12...♘d4 13 ♖c1 ♘c5 14 b6 with a distinct White advantage in the game Fernandez Casoria-Fernandez, Spanish Ch (Madrid) 1992.

13 ♗c4 *(D)*

13 ♘c3 ♘xd2 14 ♕xd2 ♘d4 15 ba d5 16 ♘cb5 ♘c6 17 ♘c2 ♗e7 18 ♗e2 0-0 19 0-0 ♖xa6 20 ♘bd4 ♖b6 21 ♘xc6 ♖xc6 ∓ Radovanović-N.Nikčević, Yugoslav Ch (Kladovo) 1992.

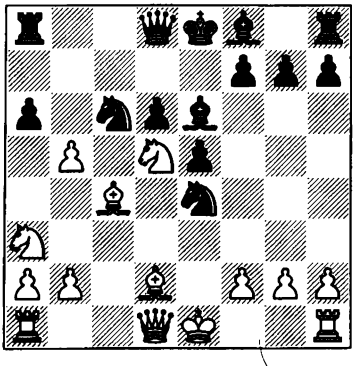
13 ... ♘e7 *(D)*

As is well known, **13...ab?** is an error because of 14 ♘xb5.

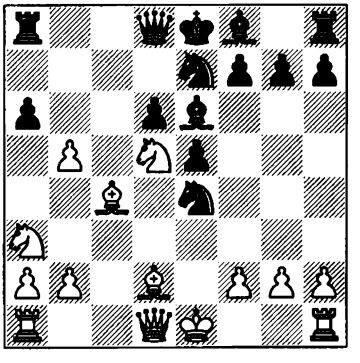
However, **13...♘a5!?** is interesting, for example:

a) **14 b6** ♘xc4 15 ♘c7+ ♔e7 16 ♘xc4 ♗xc4 17 ♖c1 ♗e6 18 b7 ♖b8 19 ♗a5 d5 20 b4 ♕d6 is unclear, or **14 ♕a4** ♘xc4 15 ♕xc4 ♗xd5 16 ♕xd5 ♘xd2 17 ♔xd2 ♗e7 18 ♔e2 0-0 19 ba ♖xa6 20 ♘b5 ♕b6 21 ♖hc1 e4 22 a4 ♗f6 23 ♖a2 ± Brodsky-Serper, Riga 1987.

b) **14 ♗e3!** is more promising for White; after 14...♘xc4 15 ♘xc4 ab 16 ♗b6 Black has three moves at his disposal, but they all lose: **16...♕b8** 17 ♘c7+ ♔e7 18 ♘e3 ♖a4 19 ♘ed5+ ±; **16...♕d7** 17 ♘c7+ ♔e7 18 ♘e3 ♖c8 19 ♘ed5+ ♗xd5 20 ♘xd5+ ±; **16...♕g5** 17 ♘ce3 ♖c8 18 0-0 ♗e7 19 ♕d3 ♘c5 20 ♕xb5+ ♗d7 21 ♕e2 0-0 22 ♗xc5 ±.



B



W

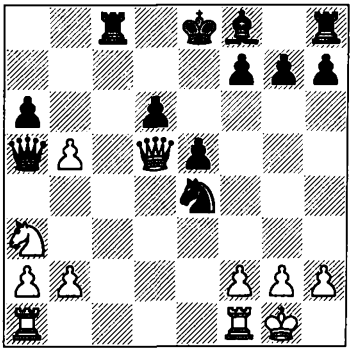
14 0-0!?

A brilliant novelty, fully in Viktor Kupreichik's style as an inexhaustibly inventive chess player. After **14 ♗b3**, 14...♖c8! would have maintained the balance.

14 ... ♘xd5

If **14...♗xd5,** then 15 ♗a5 ♕xa5 16 ♗xd5 ♖d8 17 ♗xe4 ab 18 ♗d3 ♖b8 19 ♗xb5+ ♖xb5 20 ♘c4 ♕a6 21 ♘xd6+ and White wins.

15 ♗xd5 ♗xd5
16 ♗a5 ♕xa5
17 ♕xd5 ♖c8 *(D)*



W

18 ♕xe4 ♗e7

The sequence of exchanges has ended, and it has become clear that Kupreichik's advantage is quite sufficient for the win. In particular, Black does not have time to take the pawn: **18...ab** 19 ♕b7 ♕c7 20 ♕xb5+ ♕c6 21 ♖fc1, and the endgame is hopeless.

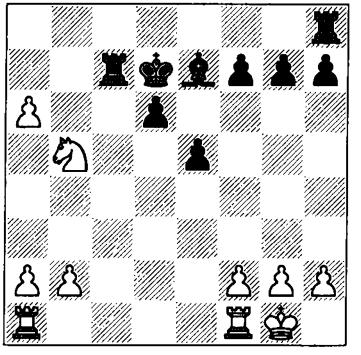
19 ♕b7 ♕c7
20 ♕xc7!

In this situation as well exchanging queens decides everything quickest of all.

20 ... ♖xc7
21 ba ♔d7

If **21...♖a7**, then White replies 22 ♘b5!.

22 ♘b5 *(D)*



B

22 ♖c2

It is interesting that in Fernandez Garcia-San Segundo, Spanish Ch (Madrid) 1992, a serious attempt to improve Black's play was tried: **22...♖c6!?**, but after 23 a7 d5 24 ♖fc1 ♗g5! 25 ♖xc6 ♔xc6 26 a4 d4 27 ♖d1 ♖d8 28 g3 ♔b7 29 h4 ♗h6 White, by means of 30 f4 ef 31 g4!, could have presented his opponent with insoluble problems.

23 ♖fc1!

The finale. If 23...♖hc8, then 24 ♖xc2 ♖xc2 25 a7 ♖c8 26 ♖d1 with an easy win.

23	**...**	**♖xb2**
24	**♖c7+**	**♔e6**
25	**♖b7**	**♔f6**
26	**♘c7**	**♖c8**
27	**♘d5+**	**♔e6**
28	**♖xb2**	**1-0**

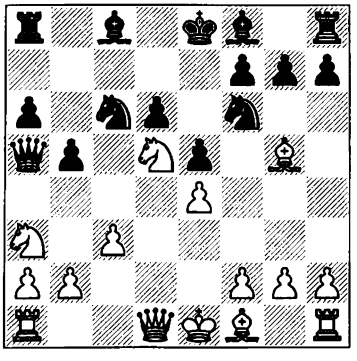
Short but sweet!

Alongside 10 ♗d2 there is another way of fighting for the initiative, 10 c3.

Game 10
Blodshtein – Savko
Vilnius 1993

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♘d5 ♕a5+

10 c3!? *(D)*



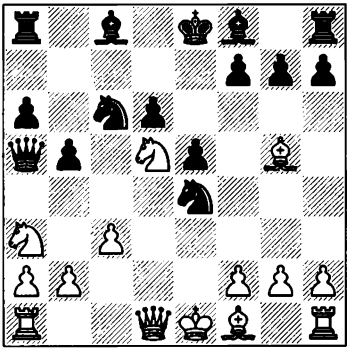
B

This move is rarely seen, although it also presents Black with some tricky problems.

10 ... ♘xd5

10...♗e7?? is a terrible mistake because of 11 ♗xf6 gf 12 ♘xf6+ and it's time for Black to resign.

10...♘xe4 *(D)* is a sharp alternative to the text move:



W

a) **11 ♕f3?** f5! 12 ♗d3 (in *Informator 57* Blodshtein demonstrates the following line: 12 b4! {Blodshtein's symbol} 12...♕xa3 13 ♗c1 ♕a4 14 ♘c7+ and White is winning; however, we may continue: 14...♔d8 15 ♘xa8 ♘d4 16 cd ♕b4+ 17 ♔e2 ♕xd4 with a very strong initiative for the sacrificed material) 12...♘xg5 13 ♘f6+ ♔d8! 14 ♕xc6 ♖b8 15 ♕e8+ ♔c7 16 ♘d5+ ♔b7 17 ♘e7 ♕c7 18 ♘xc8 e4 ∓.

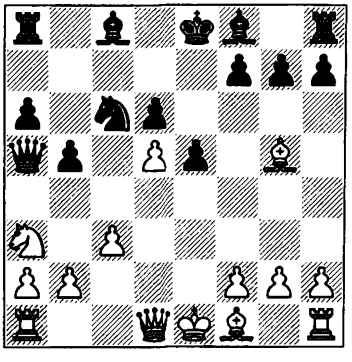
b) Alternatively, **11 ♗e3** ♖b8 12 ♘c2 ♕d8 13 a4 ♘f6 14 ♘xf6+ gf 15 ab ab 16 ♕d5 ♗d7 17 ♗xb5! ♖xb5 18 ♕xb5 ♘d4 19 ♘xd4 ♗xb5 20 ♘xb5 ♗e7 (20...♔d7 21 ♖a7+ ♔e6 22 ♘c7+ ♔f5 23 0-0 is

unclear) 21 ♖a8! ♕xa8 22 ♘c7+ ♔d7 23 ♘xa8 ♖xa8 24 ♔d2 d5 25 ♔c2 ♔c6 = Akhn-Munos, Buenos Aires 1992.

c) **11 b4** ♕xa3 12 ♗c1 ♕a4 (or 12...♘xc3 13 ♕d2! ♘e4 14 ♕c2 ♘d4 15 ♕xe4 ♕a4 16 ♗d3 ♖a7 17 0-0 ♗f5 18 ♕e3 ♗xd3 19 ♕xd3 ♕c2 20 ♕xc2 ♘xc2 21 ♗e3! and the position of the knight on d5, as well as the advantage in development are more than enough compensation for a single pawn, although in Blodshtein-Al.Karpov, Tashkent 1994, Black managed to save the ending) 13 ♘c7+ ♔d8 14 ♕xa4 ba 15 ♘xa8 ♘xc3 16 ♗d2 ♘b5?! (16...♘d5!? 17 b5 =) 17 ♘b6 ♗f5 (Blodshtein-Marsalek, Ceske Budejovice 1993) 18 ♖c1 ♘cd4 19 ♗c4! ±.

11 ed *(D)*

11 ♕xd5 ♗b7 12 ♘c2 ♕c7 13 ♕d3 = gives nothing.



B

11 ... ♘e7

If **11...♘d4**, then 12 ♗d2 ±, and if **11...♘b8**, then 12 ♘c2 ♘d7 13 a4 ba 14 b4 ±.

12 ♘c2 h6

12...♗b7?! is worse: 13 a4 ba 14 ♘b4 with a better game for White. **12...♕c7!?** and **12...f6** are more promising moves.

13 ♗d2! ♕c7

14 a4! ba

Naturally Black does not want to leave himself with the permanent weakness on b5 which would arise after **14...♖b8** 15 ab ab 16 ♘b4.

15 ♘b4 ♗d7

15...a5 is a mistake due to 16 ♕xa4+ ♗d7 17 ♗b5 ±.

16 ♗xa6

It would have been quite possible to take the knight, for example, **16 ♘xa6** ♕c8 17 ♖xa4! ♘xd5 18 ♖a5 ♗c6 19 ♗c4 (19 ♕a1 is not bad either) 19...♘b6 20 ♕b3 with a very complex position.

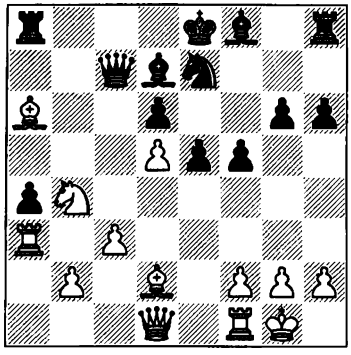
16 ... f5?!

A premature thrust. He should have continued his development with **16...g6**.

17 0-0 g6

18 ♖a3 *(D)*

There was also a more active plan linked with exchanging the bishop and playing against the a4-pawn: **18 ♕e2** ♗g7 19 ♗b5 0-0 20 ♖a3 ±.



B

18 ... ♗g7
19 ♗d3 0-0
20 ♗c2

It would have been worth returning to the plan with **20 ♕e2**; now Black has an ingenious idea at his disposal...

20 ♕c4?!

...but he misses it. He should have continued **20...♗b5!** 21 ♖e1 ♕d7 =.

21 ♕a1 ♔h7

Black would have found himself in difficulties had he taken the pawn: **21...♘xd5** 22 ♗d3 ♕c5 23 ♕a2! ♗e6 24 ♗c4 ♖a5 25 ♗b3 ±.

22 ♖d1 f4

22...♘xd5 was also possible: 23 ♘xd5 (23 b3? ♘xb4! 24 bc ♘xc2 25 ♕a2 ♘xa3 26 ♕xa3 ♗e6 and Black has sufficient compensation for the queen) 23...♕xd5 24 ♗xh6 ♕c6 25 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 26 ♕a2 with a minimal advantage to White. But the text move is even stronger.

23 ♗d3 ♕c5
24 ♗e4 f3
25 g3

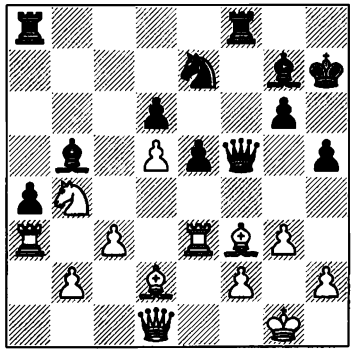
It would have been very dangerous to accept the sacrifice, for example, **25 ♗xf3** ♖xf3! 26 gf ♗b5 with numerous threats linked to ...♕c5-c8, ...♗b5-e2, ...♘e7-f5 and an attack on the king.

25 ... ♕c4?

An unforgivable waste of time. The swift **25...♕c8** would have given Black excellent possibilities for counterplay.

26 ♖e1 ♕c8
27 ♕d1 ♗b5
28 ♗xf3 ♕f5
29 ♖e3 h5 *(D)*

To activate Black's dark-squared bishop.



W

30 c4!

By returning the pawn, White consolidates his position. This is better than **30 ♗e1** ♗h6 31 ♗e4

♕g4 32 ♕xg4 hg 33 ♖d3 ♗xd3 34 ♗xd3 ♗c1 with rough equality.

30	**...**	**♗xc4**
31	**♗e1**	**♗h6**
32	**♗e4**	**♕h3**
33	**♗g2**	**♕d7**
34	**♖ec3**	**♗b3**
35	**♕d3**	**♘f5**
36	**♘c6**	

White has determined a clear advantage, linked with his better-placed pieces, his opponent's lack of counterplay, and with Black's pawn weaknesses, which sooner or later will make their presence felt.

36		**♘d4**

An attempt to create complications.

37	**♗e4**	**♕f7**
38	**♘xd4**	**ed**
39	**♖c6**	**♕f6**

The natural **39...♗xd5** meets with a simple but elegant refutation: 40 ♗xg6+ ♕xg6 41 ♕xg6+ ♔xg6 42 ♖xd6+.

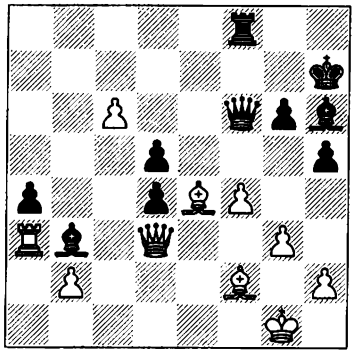
40	**f4!**	

Re-blocking the h6-bishop's diagonal and simultaneously freeing his bishop from its unfortunate role as guard for the f2 pawn.

40	**...**	**♖ac8**
41	**♗f2**	**♖xc6**
42	**dc**	**d5** *(D)*

After **42...♗g7** White can prevent this thrust by means of 43 ♕f3.

43	**♖xb3**	



W

The rook, so long held in captivity, enters the game with decisive effect.

43	**...**	**ab**

43...de loses to 44 ♖b7+.

44	**♗xd5**	**♗g7**
45	**♕xb3**	**d3**
46	**♕xd3**	**♕xb2**
47	**♗e4**	**♕f6**

The rest is a matter of technique.

48	**♕d5**	**♔h8**
49	**c7**	**♕a6**
50	**♕c6**	**♕xc6**
51	**♗xc6**	**♖c8**
52	**♗b6**	**♔h7**
53	**♗b7**	

And Black is forced to part with his bishop.

53	**...**	**♗d4+**
54	**♗xd4**	**♖xc7**
55	**♗f3**	**♖c2**
56	**♗f2**	**♔h6**
57	**♔g2**	**♖a2**
58	**♗d5**	**♖d2**
59	**♗e4**	**♖e2**

60	**♔f3**	**♖a2**
61	**h3**	**g5**
62	**♗e3**	**1-0**

Recently it has become difficult for Black to maintain equality in this variation; Kupreichik's novelty has dealt quite a serious blow to it. As regards 10 c3, Black must be on full alert to maintain the balance. However, from the point of view of the logic of chess, Black's difficulties are not so surprising – indeed he's giving his opponent a whole tempo.

5 10...♗g7 11 ♗d3

In this chapter we will begin to examine the whole stratum of variations beginning with 9 ♗xf6. With this move White actively starts the fight for d5, and moreover doubles Black's pawns. However, in return Black gains the bishop pair and the open g-file. Even his doubled pawns actively influence the centre. As a rule, this preordains an extremely complex strategic and tactical battle over the whole of the board.

Game 11
Dolmatov – Topalov
Groningen 1993

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gf 10 ♘d5 ♗g7

11 ♗d3

Castling long is too dangerous, for example, **11 ♕h5** ♘e7 12 ♘e3 f5 13 ef e4! 14 0-0-0 0-0 15 g4!? d5 16 c3 b4! 17 cb d4 18 ♔b1 ♕d6 19 ♘ec4 ♕f4! 20 ♗g2 ♗b7 21 ♖he1 ♘d5 22 ♘a5? ♘f6 23 ♕h3 ♗d5 24 ♖xd4 ♕xf2 25 ♖ed1 e3! ∓ Timoshenko-Ikonnikov, USSR 1990. The central tandem of black pawns is always quite terrifying, especially when the white king is sheltering on the queenside, and in reply to ...b5-b4, White must strike on b4, opening the way for the d-pawn. As a counterbalance, Timoshenko should have tried to play his trump card: 22 ♕h3! ♖ad8 23 g5! ♖fe8 24 f6 ♗f8 25 ♕g3 ♗xb4 with an unclear position.

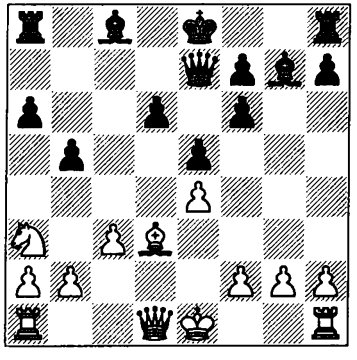
11 ... ♘e7

Black's idea is to exchange or drive back the mighty d5-knight without delay, before White has supported his pieces.

12 ♘xe7 ♕xe7

13 c3 *(D)*

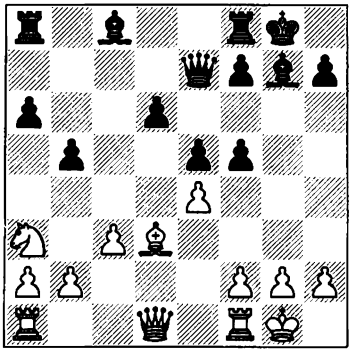
Another idea, linked with c2-c4, will be examined in the next game.



B

13 ... f5
14 ♘c2

If **14 0-0 0-0** *(D)* is included, it's no surprise that a different type of game arises. This is because after castling, White has defended the g2-pawn, and Black has to find another possibility instead of ...♕e7-b7. In this position White may try:



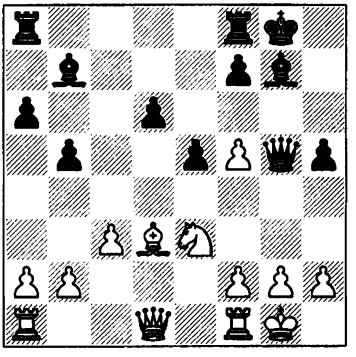
W

a) **15 ef** e4 16 ♗e2 ♗xf5 17 ♘c2 ♕e5 18 a4 ♗e6 19 ♕d2 f5 20 ab ab 21 ♘d4 b4 ½-½ A.Sokolov-Dolmatov, Moscow 1994.

b) **15 ♘c2**:

b1) **15...♖b8** (a passive move, but one which features in many plans) 16 ef e4 17 ♖e1 ♗xf5 18 ♘d4 and now, rather than **18...♗g6?** 19 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 20 f3 d5 21 fe de 22 ♕g4 ♕c5 23 ♔h1 ♖b6 24 ♘f5 ♖g6 26 ♕xe4 ± Kramnik-Nunn, Monaco 1994, **18...♗xd4** is better: 19 cd d5 20 ♕d2 ♖b6 21 ♕f4?! (21 ♗f1 ±) 21...♗g6 22 ♗e2 ♕b4 23 h4 f6 25 h5 ♗f7? 26 ♕g3+ ♔h8 27 h6 ♖g8 28 ♕c7 +– Magem-San Segundo, Madrid 1994.

b2) **15...♗b7 16 ef ♕g5 17 ♘e3 h5** (17...d5? 18 f4! ♕h6 {or 18...ef 19 ♕g4! ±} 19 f6 ♕xf6 20 fe ♕b6 21 ♖e1! ♖fe8 22 ♔h1 ♖xe5 23 ♘f5 ♖ae8 24 ♖xe5 ♖xe5 25 ♘xg7 ♔xg7 26 ♕g4+ ±, Mitrakanth-Prasad, India 1992) and now *(D)*:



W

b21) **18 a4** d5 19 ♕b3 d4 20 cd ed 21 f4 ♕h4 22 ♘d5 ♖ad8 23 ♗e4 ♖fe8 24 ♗f3 ♗xd5 25 ♗xd5 ♕f6 26 ab ♕xf5 is level.

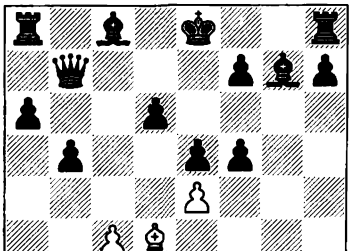
b21) **18 ♗e2** d5 19 ♗f3 ♖ad8 20 ♕b3 with a small advantage to White, although Black has definite counterplay after 20...e4 with the idea of ...♗g7-e5 and ...♖d8-d6, threatening ...♗e5xh2, Topalov-Vaiser, Metz 1992.

b23) Nisipianu-Genescu, Romanian Ch 1994, developed more sharply with **18 ♕e2!?**, which was

met by **18...d5!?** 19 f6! ♗xf6 20 f4 ef 21 ♘f5 (intending h2-h4 +–) 21...h4 (21...♖fe8 22 ♕f3 ♗e5 23 h4 ♕f6 24 ♕xh5 ♗c8 25 ♘h6+! ♔g7 26 ♖ae1! ♕xh6 27 ♖xe5 ±) 22 ♖xf4! ♕xf4 23 ♕h5 (intending 24 ♘e7+!) 23...♖fe8 24 ♖f1! with a decisive attack. The sacrifice f5-f6 has many merits; it frees f5 for the knight, and opens the diagonal for White's bishop; therefore the move **18...♗f6!** deserves attention.

b3) Chekhov's recommendation **15...f4!?** deserves attention: 16 a4 ♗b7 17 ab ab leads to a complex but fairly standard type of position.

14 ♕b7!? *(D)*



W

The queen restrains the pawn, as mentioned in the previous note. Okhotnik's idea of giving up g2 – 15 ef ♕xg2 16 ♖f1 ♗b7 17 ♘e3 has not yet found any takers.

The natural **14...♗b7** is also possible, for example, 15 ♘e3 fe 16 ♘f5 ♕f6 17 ♗xe4 d5! 18 ♗d5 ♖d8 19 ♕g4 ♖xd5 20 ♕xg7 ♕xg7 21 ♘xg7+ ♔e7 22 ♘f5+ ♔e6 23 ♘e3 ♖d7 24 ♔e2 f5, and in spite of White's extra pawn in the endgame, Black has the advantage, Anand-Kramnik, Moscow 1994.

15 ♕f3 0-0

15...f4 16 g3 h5 17 gf ♗g4 18 ♕g2 ♗h6 19 f3 ♗d7 20 fe de 21 ♕f2 ♗e6 22 ♘b4 ♖g8 occurred in Konguval-Antonio, Calcutta op 1994.

16 ♘e3

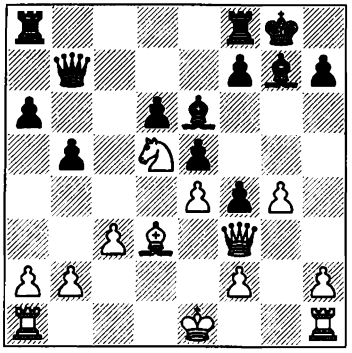
Putting a knight on d5 again is no good: **16 ♘b4** a5 17 ♘d5 ♗e6 18 ♘e3 (forced) 18...f4 19 ♘f1 f5 20 ♘d2 d5, and the centre sweeps away all obstacles.

16 ... f4
17 ♘d5 ♗e6
18 g4 *(D)*

18 ♗e2?! is worse: 18...♗xd5 19 ed f5 20 g4 fg 21 hg e4 22 ♕h5 h6 **23 0-0-0?** b4 24 c4 b3 25 ab a5 26 g4 a4 ∓ Qi-Vyzhmanavin, Beijing 1991. Of course, he should have continued **23 g4!?** or **23 0-0** – why castle into the attack?

18 b4!

In the game Dolmatov-Ma.Tseitlin, Beersheba 1991, Black did not have time to expose the possibilities of his pieces. He tried one of the possible ideas but executed it



B

weakly: **18...♖fe8?!** (18...♖ae8!? 19 ♔f1 f5 20 gf ♖xf5 is possible, but 18...f5? immediately is wrong due to 19 gf ♖xf5 20 ♘e7+! +–) 19 ♔f1 ♖ac8 20 a3! ♖c5 21 ♖d1 ♔f8 22 ♗b1 a5 23 g5 ♕d7? (23...♗xd5 24 ed b4 25 ab ab 28 ♗xh7 with a complex game) 24 ♖g1 ♗xd5 25 ed e4 26 ♗xe4 b4 27 ab ab 28 ♗xh7 bc 29 bc ♖xc3 30 ♖d3 ♖c4 31 h4 and now White has a clear advantage.

19 c4

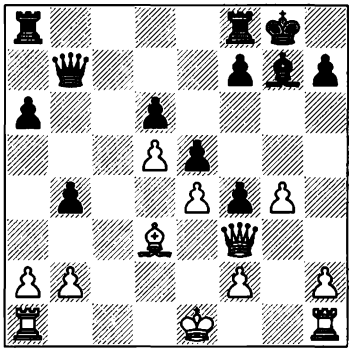
19 ♖b1 and 19 ♔f1 are interesting, preserving the knight on d5, as in both cases its exchange opens the route b1-h7 straight to the black king. True, Black could have gained counterplay on the b-file after 19...bc. 19 cb is wrong because of 19...♗xd5, as is 19 ♘xb4 because of 19...a5.

19 ♗xd5!

Just in time!

20 cd *(D)*

After 20 ed e4!? 21 ♗xe4 ♗xb2 22 ♖b1 ♗e5 23 c5! ♕b5 24 c6 ♗c3+ 25 ♔d1 ♖fe8 the game intensifies, which Dolmatov was apparently trying to avoid by making the precautionary move 18 g4.



B

20 ♗f6

Otherwise, after g4-g5 the bishop will be excluded from the game.

21 g5 ♗d8

22 ♗f1!? ♔h8?!

It would have been better first to move the rook to c8.

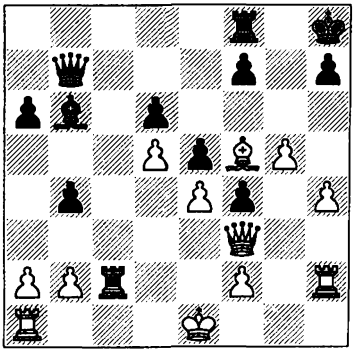
23 h4?!

Dolmatov misses his chance to play a pawn sacrifice: 23 ♗h3 ♖g8 (of course, it is very dangerous to take it immediately: 23...♗xg5 24 ♗f5 followed by ♕f3-h5, ♖h1-g1, ♖a1-c1 and a decisive attack) 24 ♖g1 ♖xg5 25 ♖xg5 ♗xg5 26 ♗f5 and the initiative is on White's side.

23 ... ♖c8

Topalov does not let such possibilities go by a second time. Now the initiative passes to him.

24	**♗h3**	**♖c2**
25	**♗f5**	**♗b6**
26	**♖h2** *(D)*	



B

26	**...**	**f6?!**

Why not **26...♖xb2**? Black probably did not want to give up the c-file, which, in combination with ♕f3-h5 and the opening of the g-file after the unavoidable ...f7-f6, could have had decisive significance. But as regards the initiative, Black on the queenside turns out to be the more important, and his position is quite defensively sound. After 27 ♖c1 ♖xa2 the b-pawn becomes dangerous, threatening in particular 28...b3, when 29 ♕xb3 fails in view of 29...♗xf2+. The real threat on the kingside after 28 ♕h5 f6 is not visible.

27	**♔f1**	**♗d8**

It's already too late to play 27...♖xb2 28 ♖c1 ♖xa2 29 ♖c6! ♗c5 30 ♕h5 b3 31 ♕h6 ♕g7 32 ♖c7 ♕xh6 33 gh and White has at least a perpetual check. (*Typesetter's note*: in this line 31...♖f7 appears to win for Black.)

28	**♔g1**	**♖g8**
29	**♔h1**	**♕c7**
30	**♖g1**	**♖c1**
31	**♖hg2**	**♖xg1+**
32	**♔xg1**	**fg**
33	**♕h5**	**g4!**

Of course, Black will not allow the h-file to be opened up, and the position is level.

½-½

14 c4 quickly leads to a lively game and a skirmish in the centre. Immense complications frequently arise on the board. In this encounter, White turned out to be very well prepared from the opening, but then lost the thread of events and suffered a defeat.

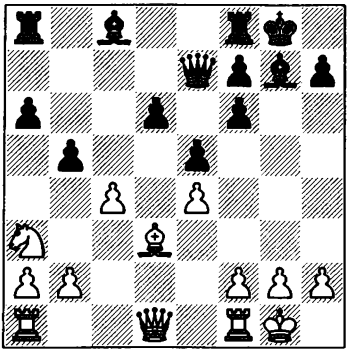
Game 12

I. Gurevich – Illescas

Biel IZ 1993

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gf 10 ♘d5 ♗g7 11 ♗d3 ♘e7 12 ♘xe7 ♕xe7

13	**0-0**	**0-0**
14	**c4** *(D)*	



B

In Sveshnikov positions with doubled f-pawns, White sooner or later runs into the problem of the c-pawn. Indeed the knight on a3 most frequently enters the struggle via c2. Therefore a choice arises as to whether to move the c-pawn one square or two. c2-c3 looks slightly more solid. In the event of c2-c4 White is gaining time, but it also has an essential disadvantage: exchanging the more central c-pawn for its black colleague on the b-file in many cases opens the way for the black infantryman on d6. Indeed Black himself tries (when the white pawn is on c3) to divert this pawn from the centre with ...b5-b4. In this case, White, foregoing static considerations, tries to bring the knight into the fray more quickly and attack the light squares.

14 ... f5

15 ♕f3

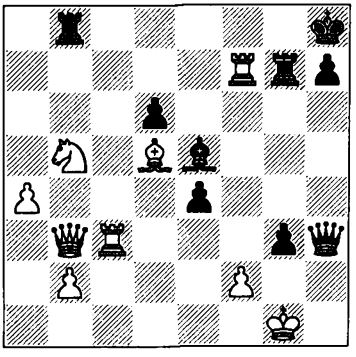
Other continuations are:

a) **15 ♕e2** ♗b7 16 ♖ad1 ♖ad8! 17 f3 fe 18 fe f5 (this is Black's fundamental idea; clearing the way for the central pawns by exchanging the peripheral b- and f-pawns) 19 ♘c2 bc (a sound idea, but inexactly executed; 19...fe 20 ♗xe4 ♖xf1 21 ♖xf1 bc is better) 20 ♗xc4 d5 21 ed ♕c5+ 22 ♔h1 ♔h8 23 ♘e3 f4 24 ♘g4 ♗xd5 25 ♘xe5 ♗xg2+ 26 ♔xg2 ½-½ Timoshenko-Gagarin, Bucharest 1993.

b) **15 ef?!** e4 16 f6 (if 16 ♖fe1, then the simple 16...♗xf5 with the idea of 17...♖fe8; in this situation yet another disadvantage of c2-c4 is evident – after ...e5-e4 the g7-bishop gains additional strength) 16...♗xf6 17 ♖e1 d5! 18 cd ♗xb2 19 ♗xe4 ♕xa3 20 ♖e3 ♕d6 21 ♗xh7+ ♔xh7 22 ♕c2+ ♕g6! 23 ♕xb2 ♖g8 24 ♖g3 ♕e4, and having repulsed the attacks, Black retains his extra material, Van der Wiel-Nunn, Wijk aan Zee 1992; 17...d5! has a witty idea – it closes the h1-a8 diagonal and opens up another, a3-f8, for the queen.

c) **15 ♖e1** fe 16 ♗xe4 ♖b8 17 cb ab 18 ♕d3 f5 19 ♗d5+ ♔h8 20 ♘xb5 e4 21 ♕b3 ♗e5!? (21...♕e5 23 a4 ♗d7 24 ♖e2 ± Nunn-Kosten, Leeds 1990) 22 a4 ♗d7 23 ♖ac1 ♕e8 24 ♗c4 ♕h5 ∓ Kosten-Chandler, Hastings 1990/1. We will follow this interesting game to the end: 25 h3? (25 g3) 25...♕g6 26

♗d5 ♖g8! 27 g3 (27 ♗xg8 ♖xg8 28 g3 f4 ∓) 27...♖g7 28 ♖c7 ♕h5 29 ♖ec1 ♕xh3 30 ♖1c3 (nothing is gained by 30 ♘xd6 ♖xg3+ 31 fg ♗d4+ −+) 30...f4 31 ♖xd7 fg 32 ♖f7 *(D)*



B

32...♕h1+! 33 ♔xh1 g2+ 34 ♔g1 ♗h2+ 0-1. Chandler's brilliant onslaught shows the many ways of attacking the king.

d) **15 ♕h5** is quite a popular continuation, e.g. **15...♖b8 16 ef e4 17 ♖ae1 ♗b7** and now:

d1) **18 b3** bc 19 bc ♔h8 20 ♘b1?! (20 ♘c2!?) 20...♖g8? (Black should play 20...♗e5! 21 ♗c2 ♖bc8 22 ♘d2 d5 23 ♖b1 ♗a8 with an unclear game) 21 g3 ♖be8 22 ♘d2 ♗c3 23 ♖xe4 ♗xe4 24 ♘xe4 ♗f6 25 ♕h6 with good compensation for the exchange, Dvoirys-Ikonnikov, USSR 1991.

d2) **18 ♘c2** bc 19 ♗xc4 d5 20 ♗xd5 ♗xd5 21 f6 ♕xf6 22 ♕xd5 ♖xb2 23 ♘e3 ♕e6 24 a4 ♕xd5 25 ♘xd5 f5 26 g4 ♖b7 = Short-Illescas, Linares 1992.

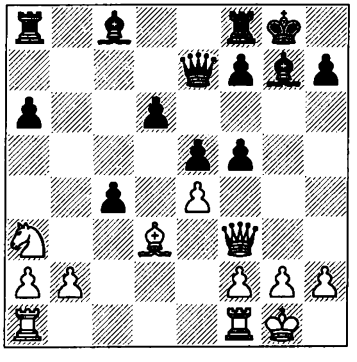
d3) **18 ♕g4 ♖fe8 19 f3 h5 20 ♕xh5 ♗d4+ 21 ♔h1 ef 22 gf ♕xe1** and then:

d31) **23 f6!?** ♕xf1+ 24 ♗xf1 ♗xf6 25 ♘c2 ♗g7! 26 ♗d3 ♖e5 27 ♕g4 ♖be8 28 cb ab 29 ♘d4 ♖e3 30 ♗xb5? (30 ♔g1!? ♗xf3 31 ♘xf3 ♖xd3 32 ♘g5 ♖d2 33 ♔f1 =) 30...♖8e4 −+ Howell-Y.Ivanov, Le Touquet 1990.

d32) **23 ♕g4+** ♔f8 24 ♘c2 ♗xf3+ 25 ♕xf3 ♕h4 26 ♘xd4 ♕xd4 27 f6 ♕h4 28 cb ab 29 ♕g2 ♕h6 30 ♖g1 ♕h8! 31 ♕f2 ♖e6 32 ♖g7 ♖c8 33 ♕f4 ♖xf6 34 ♕xf6 ♕xg7, seizing the initiative after a difficult defence, Dvoirys-Yakovich, Leeuwarden 1993.

15 ... bc *(D)*

15 ♕f3 forces Black to fix his position.



W

16 ♘xc4 d5
17 ed e4
18 ♕e3!?

18 ♕e2 is worse: 18...♗b7 19 ♗c2 ♗xd5 20 ♘b6 ♖ad8 21 ♘xd5 ♖xd5 22 ♖ad1 ♖b5! with a small advantage to Black, Vlad-Gagarin, Romania 1992.

Giving back the d5-pawn is not the best solution, but after 19 d6 ♕e6 with the idea of ...f5-f4 Black again remains the more active. On the third rank the white queen has greater freedom to manoeuvre, and for the time being hinders ...f5-f4.

18 ... ♗b7
19 d6! ♕f6

19...♕e6 does not assist the advance ...f5-f4, and after 20 ♗e2 ♗d5 21 ♘b6 ♖ad8 22 ♘xd5 ♕xd5 23 ♖fd1, it leads to a big advantage for White.

20 ♗c2

Obviously not **20 ♗e2?**, which would have given the black f-pawn the chance to carry out a destructive incursion into the white camp with ...f5-f4-f3.

20 ... f4

20...♖ac8 deserves attention.

21 ♕h3 ♖ac8

Attempting to win the pawn with **21...♗d5** leads Black to disaster after 22 ♘b6 ♗e6 23 ♕h5.

22 b3!

A precise move, after which White gains a small advantage. If **22 ♗b3**, then 22...♖c5! 23 ♖ad1 ♖g5 24 ♖d2 ♕g6 with initiative to Black.

22 ... ♕g5

Now **22...♖c5** would be a mistake. After 23 ♖ad1 ♕g6 24 d7 ♖h5 25 ♕xh5 ♕xh5 26 d8♕ ♖xd8 27 ♖xd8+ ♗f8 28 ♘d6 Black falls into a difficult position.

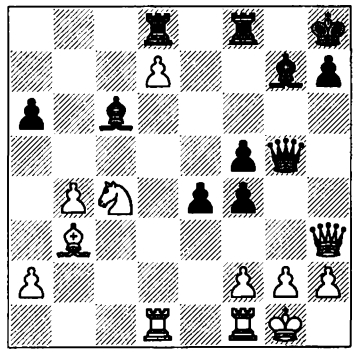
23 ♖ad1 f5
24 b4?!

White should have played the slightly more active **24 d7!** ♖cd8 25 ♖d6 ±.

24 ... ♔h8
25 ♗b3 ♗c6
26 d7

26 ♖fe1 would have been more careful.

26 ♖cd8 *(D)*



W

27 ♖d6?!

An unclear game arises after the continuation **27 ♘d6!** ♕g6! 28 ♘e8 ♗xd7 (28...♗e5 29 ♖d6!!

♗xd6 30 ♕c3+ ♖f6 31 ♘xf6 ♗xb4 32 ♕xc6 ♗e7 33 ♕xa6 f3 34 g3 ♗xf6 35 ♕e6) 29 ♘xg7 ♕xg7.

27 ... ♗xd7
28 ♖fd1 ♕e7!
29 ♘b6?

Gurevich probably overlooked Black's next reply. Some chances for a successful defence remain after **29 ♖xa6** ♗b5 30 ♖ad6 ♖c8! 31 ♘b6 ♖c3 32 ♕h5 e3 33 ♖e6 ♕xb4 34 fe ♗c6 35 ♘d5 ♗xd5 36 ♗xd5 fe ∓.

29 ♗e6!

Unexpectedly showing up the weakness of White's back rank.

30 ♖xd8 ♖xd8
31 ♘d5 ♗xd5
32 ♗xd5

32 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 33 ♗xd5 ♕xb4 34 g3 f3 35 ♕f1 was more stubborn, even though after 35...♗d4 White's situation remains critical.

32 ... e3
33 fe

33 ♕f3 loses to 33...e2 34 ♖e1 ♕xb4.

33 ... fe
34 ♕f3 e2
35 ♖e1 ♕xb4

It's still not too late to make mistakes. After **35...♗d4+** 36 ♔h1 ♕xb4 37 ♕xe2 ♖xd5?? 38 ♕e8+ ♔g7 39 ♖e7+ White would even have won.

36 ♖xe2 ♗d4+
0-1

Or 37 ♔f1 ♕b1+ 38 ♖e1 ♕b5+ 39 ♖e2 ♖xd5 and Black has an extra bishop.

Conclusion

The continuation 11 ♗d3 ♘e7 gives Black the foundations to rely on gaining a position with good counterchances. If in the variation with 13 c3, play is relatively quiet and marked by manoeuvring, then 14 c4 frequently leads to rapid conflict.

6 10...♗g7 without 11 ♗d3 – White fianchettoes

In general the Sveshnikov falls quite easily into the classification of variations, but there is one bottleneck, when White plays 9 ♗xf6, and Black then plays ...f7-f5 and ...♗f8-g7. He can do this in any order. And most often of all White reacts to this with a set of standard moves: c2-c3, ♘a3-c2, g2-g3, ♗f1-g2, which can also be made at any time. We have tried to clear up the nuances of one or another move order in the notes to actual games. Therefore the next two chapters (which are closely bound together) are divided under different headings depending on whether the bishop is fianchettoes on g2 or not. Both are supposedly transpositional, between the chapter on 10...♗g7 and the one on 10...f5.

Game 13
Adams – Salov
Dortmund 1992

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gf 10 ♘d5 ♗g7

11 c3

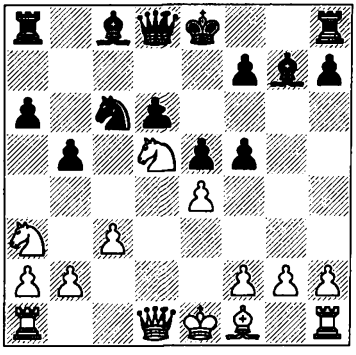
In Beliavsky-Dolmatov, Yugoslavia 1992, White seized the initiative after **11 c4** f5 (11...b4 12 ♘c2 a5 13 ♗d3 is significantly worse, after which it is difficult to carry out ...f6-f5) 12 cb ♘d4 13 ♗d3 0-0 14 ♘c2 ♘**xc2** 15 ♕xc2 ♗b7 16 0-0 ♗xd5 17 ed.

However, in the game Herrera-A.Diaz, Havana 1993, Black found a better reply: **14...fe** 15 ♗xe4 ♖b8 16 0-0 (16 ♘d4 ed 17 ♕h5? f5 18 ♗f3 ♖xb5 ∓) 16...♖xb5 (16...ab?! 17 ♘xd4 ed 18 ♖c1 ±) 17 ♘xd4 ed 18 ♖c1 ♗b7 19 ♕f3 ♕g5 20 a4! ♖xb2 (20...♖xd5 21 ♖c7 ♗a8 22 ♖a7 ♗c6 23 ♖xa6 ♗b7 24 ♖a7 leads to a draw) 21 ♖c7 ♗xd5 22 ♗xd5 ♕f6 23 ♕d3 ♖b6 =.

11 ... f5 *(D)*

12 ef

A distinctive idea in the spirit of the Benko Gambit was used in Trapl-Volke, Ustye 1994: **12 g4** fg 13 ♘c2 ♗e6 14 ♘ce3 ♘e7 15 h3 g3 16 fg ♘xd5 17 ed ♕g5 18 ♔f2 ♗d7 19 h4 ♕f6+ 20 ♔g2 ♗h6 21 ♘g4 ♕g7 22 ♘xh6 ♕xh6 23 ♕c1! ♕g6 24 ♕e3 ♖g8 25 ♗d3 f5 26

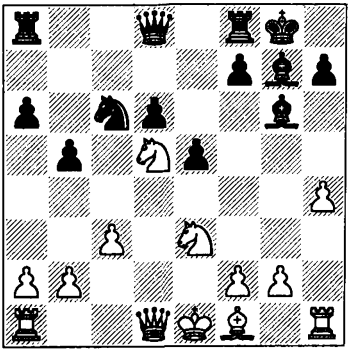


W

♖hf1 0-0-0 27 c4, and White held on to the initiative.

12	**...**	**♗xf5**
13	**♘c2**	**0-0**
14	**♘ce3**	**♗e6**

14...♗g6 also deserves serious attention. After **15 h4** *(D)* the following variations are possible:



B

a) **15...f5!?** 16 h5 ♗e8 17 g4! ♗d7! (17...fg? 18 h6 +–; 17...f4 18 ♘f5 ±) 18 gf ♔h8! 19 h6! ♗f6 20 ♗g2 ♖b8 (20...♖c8!? 21 a3 ♗g5 with counterplay for Black) 21 a3 ♗g5 22 ♗e4 ♘e7 with an unclear game, Korneev-N.Nikčević, Cattolica 1992.

b) **15...h6** and now:

b1) **16 h5** ♗h7 17 ♗d3 f5 18 g4 e4 19 ♗e2 (19 ♗c2 fg 20 ♘xg4 ♕g5 ∓ is worse) 19...f4 20 ♘xf4 ♖xf4 21 ♕d5+ ♔h8 22 ♕xc6 ♕f8, and Black has some initiative for the sacrificed pawn.

b2) **16 g4** ♘e7! 17 ♗d3 (17 ♗g2 ♖a7 18 ♕d2 f5 and the black pieces are harmoniously placed) 17...♘xd5 18 ♘xd5 e4 19 ♗c2 ♖b8 20 ♕d2 b4!, and problems could arise for the white king.

15	**g3**	**♘e7**

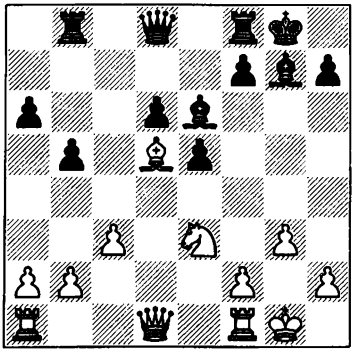
An attempt to attack the c3-pawn immediately was unsuccessful in Geller-Arakhamia, Aruba 1992: **15...b4** 16 ♗g2 bc 17 bc ♖c8 18 0-0 f5 19 ♕h5 ♔h8 20 ♖ad1 ♘e7 21 ♖d2 e4 (21...♘xd5 22 ♘xd5 ♗xd5 23 ♖xd5 ♖xc3 24 ♖fd1 ♖c6 25 ♖xe5 ±) 22 ♖fd1 ♗e5 23 ♘f4!? ♗f7 24 ♕h6 ♖c6 25 ♘e6 ♗xe6 26 ♕xe6 ♕e8 27 ♘c4 ♖f6! 28 ♘xd6 ♖xe6 29 ♘xe8 ♔g8! 30 ♖d8 ♔f7 31 ♖1d7 ♖g6? 32 ♗f1, and Geller achieved a permanent advantage. True, 31...♖xc3 32 ♘d6+ ♔g6 33 ♗h3 ♖c6 would have allowed Arakhamia to maintain the balance, but even after this she would have had to defend with a series of forced moves.

The preliminary **15...♖b8** was seen in the game Shamkovich-Maguiera, Las Vegas 1994, which continued 16 ♗g2 f5 17 ♕h5! b4 18 0-0 bc 19 bc ♕d7 20 f4! ♕a7 (20...♖b5!?) 21 ♔h1 ♕c5 22 ♖ad1 ♖b2 23 fe! de 24 ♖xf5! ♗xf5 25 ♘xf5 ♕f2 26 ♘de7+ ♘xe7 27 ♘xe7+ ♔h8 28 ♘g6+ ♔g8 29 ♗d5+, and White won.

16 ♗g2 ♖b8
17 0-0 ♘xd5

Salov would probably have been better off allowing White the possibility of exchanging knights himself: **17...f5** 18 ♘xe7+ ♕xe7 19 ♘d5 ♕d7 (this continuation is more exact than 19...♕f7 20 ♘b4 ♖b6 21 a4 with a small advantage to White) 20 ♕d2 with chances for both sides.

18 ♗xd5! *(D)*



B

A very principled move, the aim of which is to maintain a knight on d5 against Black's dark-squared bishop.

18 ... ♔h8
19 a4 ♗h6!

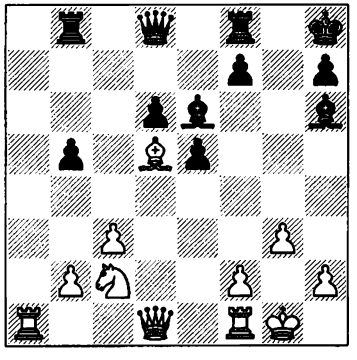
Black, of course, is better off exchanging his passive bishop.

20 ab ab?

Black's only chance of not falling into a difficult situation was a swift exchange on e3, for example, **20...♗xe3** 21 fe ♗xd5 (or 21...ab 22 ♖a6 ♖b6 23 ♖a7 ±) 22 ♕xd5 ♖xb5 23 ♕d2 a5 with a defensible position.

21 ♘c2! *(D)*

We think the reader can understand why Adams rapidly removes his knight from attack.



B

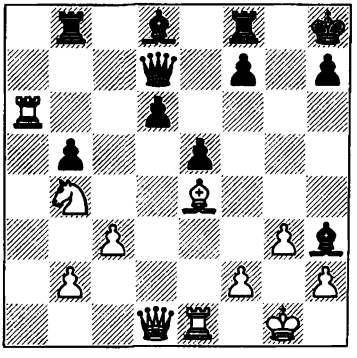
21 ... ♕d7
22 ♖a6 ♗h3
23 ♖e1

Trying to swap bishops would be very careless: **23 ♗g2??** ♗xg2 24 ♔xg2 ♕b7+, losing the rook.

23 ... ♗g5
24 ♘b4 ♗d8

Salov wishes to play ...♖b8-b6, in order to exchange the a6-rook or force it into a less active position. Alas, his idea was not fated to be carried out.

25 ♗e4! *(D)*



B

White's threats arise unexpectedly from every quarter, and apart from anything else, the black king could also be in danger.

25 ♗b6!

The planned **25...♖b6** does not work because of 26 ♕h5 f6 27 ♕h6 ♖f7 (27...♖g8 28 ♖xb6 ♗xb6 29 ♕xf6+) 28 ♖xb6 ♗xb6 29 ♗xh7!, and White wins.

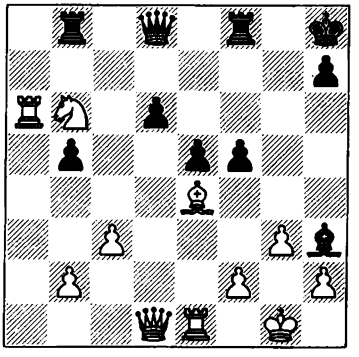
26 ♘d5

Probably the most exact. Also possible: **26 ♕h5** f5 27 ♖xb6 (but not 28 ♕xh3?? ♗xf2+ 28 ♔xf2 fe+ 29 ♔g2 ♖f2+, and Black is already winning; 27 ♗c6 does not win because of 27...♗g4) 27...fe 28 ♖xb8 ♖xb8 29 ♖xe4 with an extra pawn.

26 ... f5

The only move. If the bishop retreats to d8, then 27 ♕h5 is decisive, and if 26...♗a7 or 26...♗c5, then 27 ♘f6!.

27 ♘xb6 ♕d8 *(D)*



W

28 ♘d7

Again Adams had a choice. The continuation 28 ♕h5 ♗g4 29 ♕h6 ♖f6 30 ♕h4 fe 31 ♕xg4 (31 ♖a7 is worse: 31...♗f5 32 ♘d5 ♖e6 with an unclear game) 30...♖xb6 31 ♖a7 would also have led to a clear advantage for White.

28 ... ♕xd7
29 ♖xd6 ♕e7
30 ♖d7 ♕g5
31 ♗c2

There's absolutely no point in giving Black counterchances after 31 ♗g2 ♗xg2 32 ♔xg2 f4.

31 ... e4?

Leading to a forced loss, and although 31...♖be8 is better, after 32 f4 few chances for salvation remain for Black.

32 ♕d4+ ♕f6
33 ♕a7 ♕h6
34 ♖a1 b4
35 ♕d4+ ♕f6
36 ♖aa7 ♕xd4
37 cd 1-0

In the next game Black quickly manages to exchange the knight, and moreover, in distinction from the previous game, White is forced to strike against the d5-knight. This is a model of how Black should play against indecisive action by his opponent.

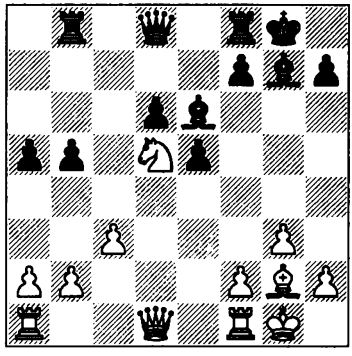
Game 14
Arakhamia – Nunn
London 1993

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gf 10 ♘d5 ♗g7 11 c3 f5 12 ef ♗xf5 13 ♘c2 ♗e6 14 ♘ce3 ♘e7 15 g3

15 ... ♘xd5

Now White has the additional possibility of hitting d5 with the bishop, which is in principle desirable.

16 ♘xd5 0-0
17 ♗g2 ♖b8
18 0-0 a5 *(D)*



W

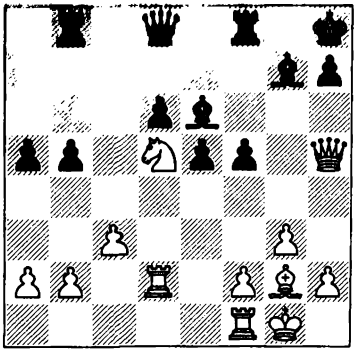
A distinctive picture of this variation. White's problems are to bring pressure on the d6-pawn and create active play on the kingside; the black pieces are ready to attack the weak queenside pawns, but in this case can also show aggression against the white king. This preordains a tense struggle over the whole board.

19 ♕d2

Too indecisive. In a way it assists the attack on the d6 pawn and impedes the move ...b5-b4, but in fact it turns out that there is no time for an effective attack on the pawn, and indeed d2 is not a very happy position for the queen.

a) **19 ♕h5** is a much more energetic continuation, e.g. 19...♔h8 20 ♖ad1 f5 21 ♖d2 *(D)* with the possibilities:

a1) **21...♗f7** (best) and now:



B

a11) **22 ♕h3** ♕d7 (it's interesting to note that the game Arakhamia-Nunn, Hastings 1993/4, went on 22...♗g6, and here the players agreed a draw) 23 ♖fd1 ♖bd8 24 ♕h4 ♕e6 25 ♘e3! (25 ♘c7 ♕xa2 26 ♘xb5 d5 27 ♕e7 ♗h5 28 ♗xd5 ♗xd1 29 ♗xa2 ♖xd2 30 f4 = Dochev-Rogozenko, Plovdiv 1992) 25...♕g6 (25...e4 26 ♖d5 ±) **26 ♗h3** f4. Here, in Szekely-Rogozenko, Eforie 1993, Szekely naively used his opponent's recommendation, published in *Informator 54*, and played 27 ♗f5, but after 27...♕h5 he certainly could not avoid a material loss. Now Rogozenko recommends **26 ♕e7**, but who knows whether or not the trusting reader is awaiting a standard dirty trick? In any case, after 26...♗f6!? (26...f4 27 ♖xd6 ♖xd6 28 ♖xd6 ♕b1+ 29 ♖d1 ♕xb2 30 ♘f5 ±) 27 ♕b7 (27 ♕c7 f4 28 ♘d5 ♗xd5 29 ♖xd5 e4 gives Black a dangerous initiative) 27...♗g5 28 ♕xb5 f4 the game is far from clear.

a12) Kotronias chose **22 ♕d1** against Illescas, Khalkidhiki 1992. After 22...♕d7 23 a3?! e4! 24 ♘f4? (24 ♖e1 =) 24...♗e5 Black seized the initiative. White should have continued 23 f4 (a standard move fixing Black's central pawns), for example, 23...e4 24 ♔h1 b4 25 c4 a4 26 ♘e3 ♖bd8 27 ♕e2 ♕c8 28 h3 ♕c5 29 g4 with an advantage to White, Schäfer-Loew, Germany 1994. The manoeuvre ♕d1-h5, ♖a1-d1-d2 and then ♕h5-d1 is very interesting.

a13) The continuation **22 ♕e2** was tested in Kozakov-Rogozenko, 1993, which went: 22...♕e8 23 ♘e3?! (23 a3 e4! was better, with the idea of ...♗g7-h6, ...♗f7-h5) 23...♗xa2 24 ♖a1 ♗b3 25 ♖xa5? (25 ♖xd6!? a4 ∓) 25...f4 26 ♘f1 ∓.

a2) Instead **21...♕d7** is worse after **22 ♖fd1**. Here are two examples on this theme:

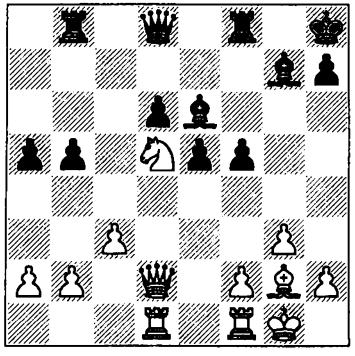
a21) **22...♕f7** 23 ♕h4! e4 24 ♘f4 ♗e5 25 ♖xd6 ♗xd6 26 ♖xd6 ♖fe8 27 g4, and White, at the price of a small material loss, has ripped apart his opponent's mighty pawn centre, Geller-Fedorowicz, New York 1990.

a22) **22...♖g8** 23 ♘e3 ♗f8 24 ♗d5 f4 25 ♗xe6 ♕xe6 26 ♘f5, and by now White has seized the

commanding heights, Kruppa-Shuraev, Alushta 1994.

b) We should add that **19 a3** is too sluggish, for instance 19...f5 20 ♕d2 ♔h8 21 ♖fd1 e4 22 f3 ♗xd5 23 ♕xd5 ef 24 ♗xf3 ♗e5, and Black's chances are somewhat better, Kovačević-Kramnik, USSR-Yugoslavia 1991.

19 ... f5
20 ♖ad1 ♔h8 *(D)*



W

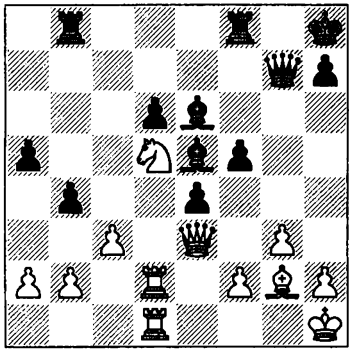
21 ♖fe1

Again a move which from general considerations seems to lose a tempo; the real place for the rook is on the d-file. There's nothing more dangerous in the Sveshnikov than playing with general considerations in mind. Concrete thinking and purposefulness are demanded from the players, and Dr. Nunn demonstrates precisely these qualities in this very game.

21 ... ♕d7
22 ♕g5 ♕f7
23 ♖d2 e4
24 ♖ed1

A tardy return to the correct plan, but time has already slipped by, and Black has deployed his forces harmoniously. Now Arakhamia faces a difficult fight for equality.

24 ... ♗e5
25 ♕e3 ♕g7
26 ♔h1 b4 *(D)*



W

Preparations for the attack are over. The time has arrived for decisive action.

27 f4?

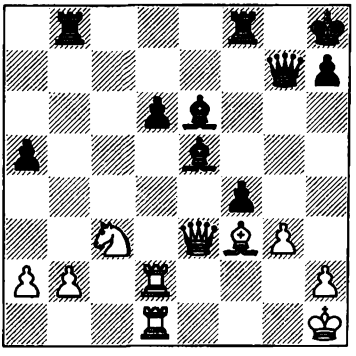
Of course, it is not easy to cope with Black's pressure, but now the white king might be in danger. The English Grandmaster's bishop pair becomes quite savage.

27 ... ef
28 ♗xf3 bc
29 ♘xc3

29 bc is no good because of 29...♗xd5 30 ♖xd5 f4 31 gf ♗xf4 32 ♕d4 ♗e5, winning.

29 ... f4! *(D)*

A very telling blow, destroying White's bastions.



W

30	**gf**	**♗xf4**
31	**♕xe6**	**♗xd2**
32	**♗e4**	**♗xc3**
33	**bc**	

Black has an extra exchange as well as an attack.

33	**...**	**♖be8**
34	**♕d5**	**♖e5**
35	**♕d3**	**♕e7**
36	**♗d5**	**♖e1+**
37	**♖xe1**	**♕xe1+**
38	**♔g2**	**♖f2+**
39	**♔h3**	**♕e5**
40	**♗g2**	**♖e2**

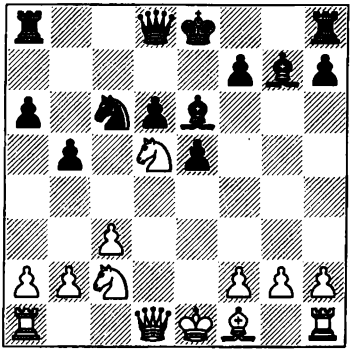
0-1

In contrast to the previous game, Black this time decides to keep the two knights, which led to a more tense situation. The similarity with Game 14 lies in the fact that White here again plays somewhat indecisively, and Black makes excellent use of this.

Game 15
Short – Kramnik
Novgorod 1994

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gf 10 ♘d5 ♗g7 11 c3 f5 12 ef ♗xf5 13 ♘c2

13 ♗e6 *(D)*



W

Arriving in the world chess elite, Grandmaster Vladimir Kramnik is an ardent admirer of the Sveshnikov, and because of this, one can judge the development of the system as a whole from the variations he chooses to use. Kramnik has introduced many new ideas, often

experimenting. But along with this, despite serious home analysis, he has to be ready for the unexpected, and even for disappointment. And in such (alas, unavoidable) circumstances, one must use the aid of old, tested continuations.

So, in this very tournament, Ivanchuk managed to demonstrate the insufficiencies of 13...♘e7, having placed the move in question under some doubt (we hope this is temporary – see Game 18). And Kramnik returns to the path of 'official' theory. Precisely this universal approach to opening problems distinguishes the strongest chessplayers in the world.

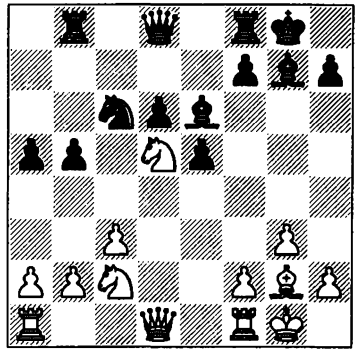
14 g3 0-0

If **14...♗xd5** 15 ♕xd5 ♘e7, then after 16 ♕b7! 0-0 (16...♕c8 17 ♕xc8 ♖xc8 18 a4! ±) 17 ♗g2 d5 18 ♖d1 (18 0-0? ♕d6) 18...♖b8 19 ♕xa6 ♖a8 20 ♕b7! (20 ♕xb5?! ♖b8 21 ♕c5 ♖xb2 22 ♘e3 d4 with an unclear game) 20...♖b8 21 ♕a7 ♖a8 22 ♕c5 White is a pawn up.

15 ♗g2 a5

Beshukov-Vasilievich, Alushta 1994, ended in a disastrous attempt by Black to begin to play over the whole board (by ...b5-b4, ...f7-f5, ...e5-e4), without first preparing himself: **15...♖b8** 16 ♘ce3 f5 17 0-0 ♕d7 18 f4 b4? 19 ♕a4 e4?? 20 ♕xc6! 1-0.

16 0-0 ♖b8 *(D)*



W

17 ♖e1?!

A stereotyped move, which loses time. In the future Short will return to the normal plan of doubling rooks on the d-file, but Black manages to bring about the position he has in mind.

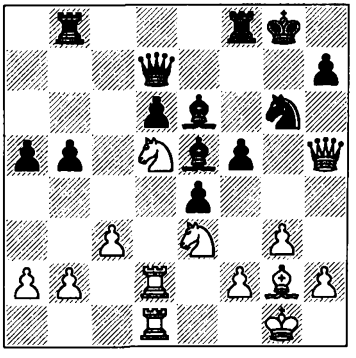
17 ♕h5 was better: 17...♕d7 (17...b4? 18 ♘ce3 with the idea of ♖a1-d1, ♘e3-c4 ±) 18 ♖ad1 f5 19 ♘ce3 (19 ♖d2 e4 20 ♖fd1 ♘e5 21 ♘ce3 ♘g6 22 a4!? ba 23 ♘c4 ♗e5 and despite the extra tempo in comparison with the game, the position is difficult to assess in anyone's favour) 19...e4 (19...f4? 20 ♗e4) 20 ♘f4! with the idea of ♗g2-h3, attacking the f5-pawn, after which definite difficulties might arise for Black.

17 ... ♕d7
18 ♕h5 f5
19 ♖ad1 e4

Black carries on his fundamental role with the central pawns,

whilst play with ...♖a8-b8 and ...a6-a5 serves precautionary aims: hindering the breakthrough a2-a4 and the appearance of the white knight on b4. For a long time Black did not manage to do this, but now he usually manages to prepare play in the centre.

20 ♘ce3 ♘e5
21 ♖e2 ♘g6!
22 ♖ed2 ♗e5! *(D)*



W

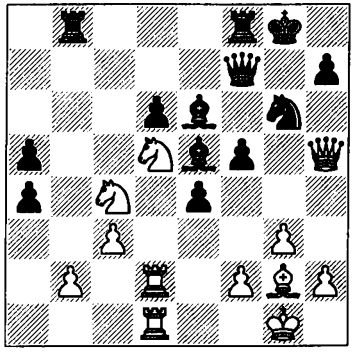
Every move by Black is underlined by one aim; the creation of a mighty central grouping of pieces and preparation of an attack. The pressure of the struggle is intensifying all the time. At this point White cannot find a use for his beautifully distributed pieces; normal ideas are no longer sufficient, and finding a way to defuse the situation is not at all easy. Nevertheless, from common sense one might come to the conclusion that White has not yet done anything which might lead him to defeat, and that therefore there is still enough in his position to maintain the balance. White should possibly have played 23 ♗h3!? or even 23 ♔h1!? and ... wait!

As regards the assessment of the position, the dynamic strength of the black pieces counterbalances White's structural superiority.

23 a4?!

Maybe the former World Championship contender Short realizes that in the Sveshnikov it is difficult to seek common sense, and therefore strives for the initiative no matter what. Furthermore, waiting passively is not in Short's character. In any case, White's 23rd move is not so much interesting, but risky.

23 ... ba
24 ♘c4 ♕f7! *(D)*



W

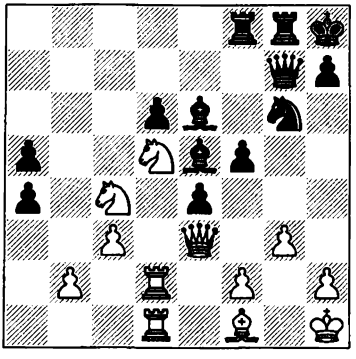
The d5-knight is rooted to the spot.

25 ♕g5

If it is consistent to try to put into practice the idea of the move 23 a4, then one should continue **25 ♘xe5** de 26 ♕g5 ♔h8 27 c4 with some compensation for the pawn. Another route, involving exerting pressure on the d6 pawn leads one on a wild goose chase after **25 ♗f1** ♕g7! 26 ♘de3 f4.

25	**...**	**♔h8**
26	**♔h1**	**♖g8**
27	**♕e3**	**♕g7**
28	**♗f1**	**♖bf8** *(D)*

Black has completely seized the initiative. The attack is not far over the hills.



W

29 ♗e2

In the event of **29 ♘db6** f4 30 ♕xe4 ♗g4! 31 ♗e2 ♗f5 32 ♕c6 fg 33 fg ♗xg3! 34 hg ♕h6+ 35 ♔g1 ♘f4 36 ♕f3 ♗e4 Black would have won. Therefore, White's next move should be directed against 30...♗g4.

29 ♖e8!

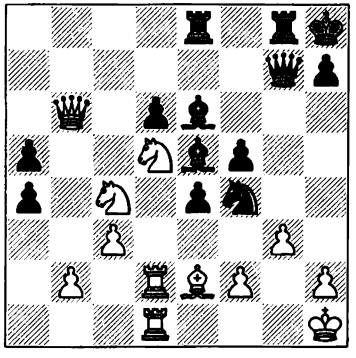
In spite of his time trouble, Kramnik still understands the situation which has arisen. Now he once more creates the threat of ...f5-f4.

30 ♕b6

If **30 ♘db6**, then 30...♗xc4 31 ♗xc4 (31 ♘xc4) 31...f4 32 ♕xe4 ♗xc3.

30 ... ♘f4! *(D)*

With the move 30 ♕b6 White has averted Black's breakthrough **30...f4**, which would be met by 31 ♘xe5 de 32 ♘c7. But the knight invades on f4 with no less effect.



W

31 ♘xf4?

31 ♘c7 is a more stubborn defence: 31...♖e7 (31...♘xe2 32 ♘xe8 ♕g4 33 ♘xe5 de 34 ♕e3 doesn't work) 32 ♘xe6 ♖xe6 33 ♘xe5 de

34 ♕e3 (34 ♕xa5 ♘xe2 35 ♖xe2 ♕g4 36 ♖de1 f4 is dangerous for White).

31 ... ♗xf4
32 ♖d4 d5

White gives back the exchange in the hope of diminishing his opponent's pressure.

33 ♖xd5

If **33 ♘e3**, then 33...♗e5 (or 33...♗c7) with the idea of 34...f4 and 35...e3, and White faces insurmountable problems.

33 ... ♗xd5
34 ♖xd5 ♗c7
35 ♕c6 f4

Kramnik persistently carries out his plan, which is typical of the variation. Regrouping his forces at the rear has brought him success.

36 ♘d6 ♖e6
37 ♗c4 ♕e7
38 ♖e5

A final stunt in time trouble.

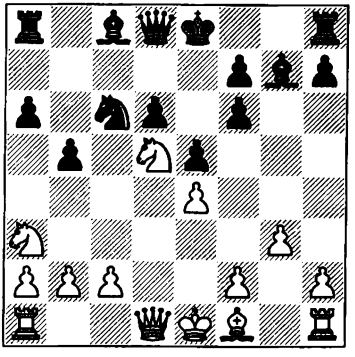
38 ... ♖xd6
39 ♖xe7 ♖xc6
40 ♗xg8 ♔xg8
41 ♖xe4 a3
0-1

Now we will examine the variation in which White prepares to fianchetto his bishop on move 11 (11 g3). The game often in this case leads into variations we have already examined, but sometimes has independent significance.

Game 16
Savon – Agamanaliev
Moscow 1991

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gf 10 ♘d5 ♗g7

11 g3 *(D)*



B

The idea is to develop the bishop onto the long diagonal, as the knight on a3 might be out of the game for a long time.

11 ... f5
12 ef *(D)*

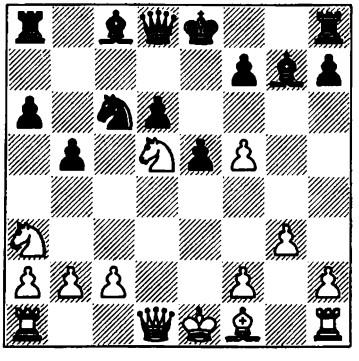
12 ♗g2 is also possible, for example, **12...fe 13 ♗xe4 ♗e6!** and now:

a) **14 ♘f6+** ♗xf6 15 ♗xc6+ ♔e7 16 ♗xa8 ♕xa8 17 ♖g1! (17 f3? h5! 18 ♕e2 h4 19 0-0-0 ♕c6! 20 ♕d2 hg 21 hg ♖xh1 22 ♖xh1 ♕xf3 ∓ Solomon-Spasov, Novi Sad OL 1990) 17...h5 18 c3 ♗g4 19

♕d3 ♗f3 20 ♘c2 and Black has compensation for the sacrificed exchange.

b) Romero, playing against Salov at Wijk aan Zee 1992, did not accept the sacrifice: **14 ♕h5** ♖c8 15 c3 ♘e7 16 ♖d1 ♖c5!? 17 ♘b4 ♕b6 18 ♕g5! ♔f8 19 ♕e3 h5 20 ♘d3 (20 ♘xa6 is a tempting idea, intending 20...♕xa6 21 ♕xc5 dc 28 ♖d8#; however the mate does not work because of 20...♗h6, but 21 0-0 deserves attention) 20...♖c6 21 ♗xc6 ♕xc6 22 f3 ♗h6 23 ♕f2 a5 24 0-0 h4, and again Black's activity is worth the exchange.

c) Matters turned out better for White in Tolnai-Ikonnikov, Budapest 1991: **14 c3** 0-0 15 0-0 ♖b8 16 ♘c2 ♕d7 17 ♗g2 f5 18 ♖e1 ♔h8 19 ♕d2 e4 20 ♘f4 d5 21 ♘d4 ♗g8 22 ♖ad1 a5 23 ♗f1 b4, and Tolnai proved to be the better prepared for the ensuing complications.



B

12 ♗xf5

Here the pawn sacrifice is very interesting: **12...e4!?** 13 c3 ♘e5 14 ♕h5 and now **14...♘f3+** 15 ♔e2 ♗b7 16 ♖d1 0-0! 17 ♗h3 ♖b8 gave Black a good game in Alzate-Ochoa, Bayamo 1984. Arakhamia's attempt to improve with **14...♗b7** did not lead to any benefits: 15 ♖d1 b4 16 ♘c4 ♘f3+ 17 ♔e2 bc 18 f6 ♗xf6 19 ♘xf6+ ♕xf6 20 ♘xd6+ ♔f8 21 bc ♖b8 22 ♕c5 ♔g8 23 ♘xb7 +– Madl-Arakhamia, Belgrade 1994.

13 ♗g2 ♖c8?

Now Savon realizes his plan without obstacle, by occupying d5. **13...e4** 14 c3 ♘e5 15 0-0 ♗g4 16 ♕d2 ♘f3+ 17 ♗xf3 ♗xf3 18 ♘c2 leads to a complex game.

Black demonstrated model play in Savon-Kharlov, Alushta 1992: **13...♗e6** (allowing the exchange sacrifice examined above) 14 c3 0-0 15 ♘c2 a5! 16 0-0 ♔h8 17 a4 ♖b8 18 ♘a3 ba 19 ♘c4 ♖b5 20 ♖xa4 f5 21 ♕d2 ♗xd5 22 ♗xd5 ♘e7 23 ♗g2 (if 23 ♘e3, then the reply 23...♗h6 is very unpleasant) 23...d5 24 ♘a3 ♖b8 25 c4 d4 26 ♘b5 e4 27 ♖a5 d3. In the graphic expression of Grandmaster Savon, 'the cart has begun rolling downhill'. Black has an undoubted advantage.

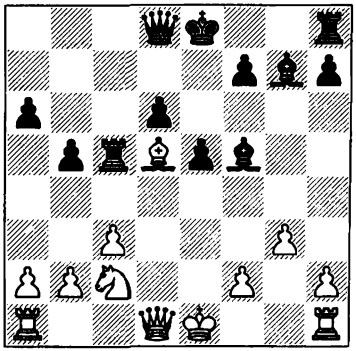
14 c3 ♘e7

15 ♘c2 ♘xd5

16 ♗xd5

Black's biggest misfortune is his total lack of counterplay.

16 ♖c5 *(D)*



W

17 ♘e3 ♗e6
18 0-0 0-0
19 a4

A typical blow, which can be seen more than once in the pages of this book.

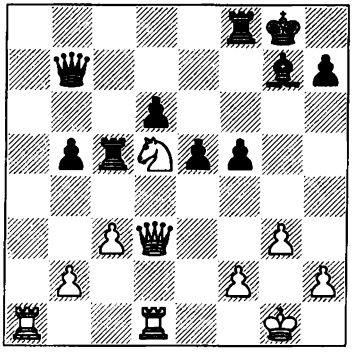
19 ... ♕b6

Aiming to exchange the g7-bishop for the knight fails after **19...♗h6?** 20 ♗xe6 fe 21 ♕g4+.

20 ab ab
21 ♕d3 ♗xd5

If Black had played **21...♗h6**, then 22 b4 ♖c7 23 ♘f5 ♗xf5 24 ♕xf5 would have made 24...♖xc3 impossible because of 25 ♗e4. Even the presence of opposite-coloured bishops would only serve to strengthen White's attacking possibilities.

22 ♘xd5 ♕b7
23 ♖fd1 f5 *(D)*



W

A typical position, in which the d5-knight is clearly superior to the g7-bishop.

24 ♘b4

24 ♘e3 is weaker: 24...f4 25 ♘f5 (25 ♕xd6? fe 26 ♕xc5 ef+) 25...e4 (or 25...d5) 26 ♘xd6 ed 27 ♘xb7 ♖d5 with compensation.

24 ... ♖f6
25 ♖a6 ♗f8
26 ♖c6

26 ♖da1! is more exact.

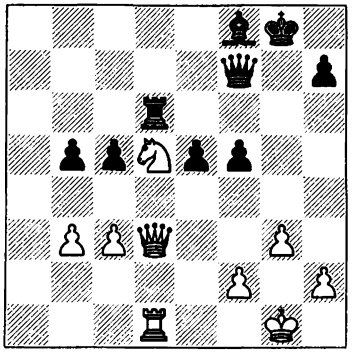
26 ... ♕f7

Or **26...♖xc6** 27 ♕d5+ ♔g7 28 ♘xc6, again favouring White.

27 ♖xc5 dc

Black is saved from the weakness on d6, but is not far from difficulties. The knight on d5 will dominate.

28 ♘d5 ♖d6
29 b3! *(D)*



B

Of course, the knight must be supported by the pawn from c4.

29	**...**	**e4**
30	**♕d2**	**♕h5**

Black would be glad to play **30...c4** himself, but it does not work: 31 bc bc 32 ♕d4 ♖c6 33 ♖a1, and White is winning.

31	**c4**	**♕f3**
32	**♖a1!**	**h6**

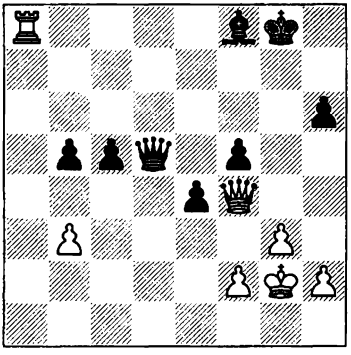
If **32...♕xb3**, then White must seek retribution against the black king: 33 ♕g5+ ♖g6 34 ♘e7+ ♗xe7 35 ♕xe7.

33	**♖a8**	**♕d3**

Once again taking the pawn, **33...♕xb3**, does not work because of 34 ♘e7+.

34	**♕f4**	**♕d1+**
35	**♔g2**	**♖xd5**
36	**cd**	**♕xd5** *(D)*
37	**♖e8**	

A mistake in time trouble. **37 ♕b8** e3+ 38 f3 ♕f7 39 ♕xb5 was simpler.



W

37		**♕f7**

A generous reply. **37...♕xb3** was a more stubborn defence: 38 ♕xf5 ♕f7 (the endgame arising after 38...♕f3+ 39 ♕xf3 ef+ 40 ♔xf3 is lost for Black) 39 ♕xe4 b4, although after 40 ♖e5 things are nevertheless pretty bad for Agamanaliev.

38	**♕e5**	**♕h5**
39	**♕d5+**	**♔g7**

And here exchanging queens after **39...♕f7** 40 ♖b5 is hopeless for Black.

40	**♖e5**	**♕f3+**
41	**♔g1**	**♔g6**
42	**♕e6+**	**♔g5**
43	**h4+**	**♔g4**
44	**♕g6+**	**♔h3**
45	**♕xf5+**	**♕xf5**
46	**♖xf5**	**♗d6**
47	**♖d5**	**♗f8**
48	**♖e5**	**b4**
49	**♖xe4**	**♗g7**
50	**♔f1**	**1-0**

Conclusion

In the variations in which White employs a king's fianchetto and transfers the a3 knight to the centre, Black experiences no particular difficulties. Decisive and very purposeful play is demanded from both sides, and moves made on the basis of so-called 'general considerations' are often mistakes. Most frequently of all White's attenttion moves to the centre, and Black's hopes lie on the flanks (either as an attack on the king or as a blow to White's pawn chain by means of ...b5-b4).

7 10...♗g7 without 11 ♗d3 – White does not fianchetto

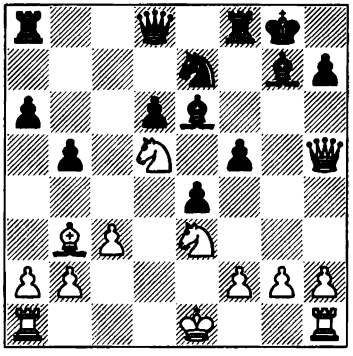
The games in this chapter are closely bound up with the duels of the previous chapter. However, at some point White prefers not to fianchetto his bishop.

Game 17
Adams – Beliavsky
Debrecen Echt 1992

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gf 10 ♘d5 ♗g7

11	**c3**	**f5**
12	**ef**	**♗xf5**
13	**♘c2**	**0-0**
14	**♘ce3**	**♗e6**
15	**♗d3**	**f5**
16	**♕h5**	**e4**
17	**♗c2**	**♘e7**
18	**♗b3** *(D)*	
18	**...**	**♘xd5**

A novelty. Previously one saw **18...♔h8** 19 ♘f4 ♗xb3 20 ab ♕d7 21 ♖d1 ♖f6 22 ♕e2 ♖b8 23 0-0 ♖h6 24 f3! ♘g6 25 ♘xg6+ ♖xg6 26 f4 ♗h6 27 b4 with a big advantage to White, Ghinda-Boersma, Lucerne 1985. Note that White



B

threatens to play 19 ♘xe7+ ♕xe7 20 ♘xf5, and neither 18...♕d7 nor 18...♖c8 offers a defence to this threat.

19 ♘xd5

19 ♗xd5!? ♗xd5 20 ♘xd5 a5 21 0-0 b4 22 f3 bc 23 bc e3 24 f4 deserves attention, with good prospects for White.

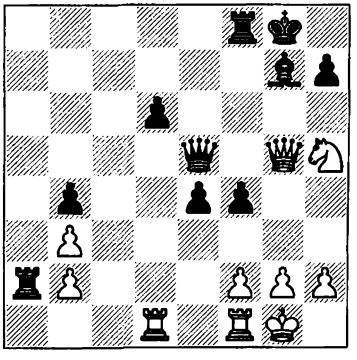
19	**...**	**a5**
20	**♘f4**	**♗xb3**
21	**ab**	**♕e7**
22	**0-0**	**b4**

A standard plan. Black begins a minority attack, which noticeably heightens his bishop's influence.

23	**cb**	**♕e5**
24	**♕g5**	

After **24 ♘h3** the attempt to encroach on the enemy camp by means of **24...ab?** 25 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 26 ♘g5 h6 27 ♕f7+ ♔h8 28 ♕b7 ♕e8 29 ♘f7+ ♔g8 30 ♘xd6 +– is not successful, but sacrificing two pawns with **24...f4!** 25 ♕xe5 ♗xe5 26 ba ♖fb8 27 ♘g5 e3 would give Black better chances.

24	**...**	**ab**
25	**♖ad1**	**♖a2**
26	**♘h5**	**f4** *(D)*



W

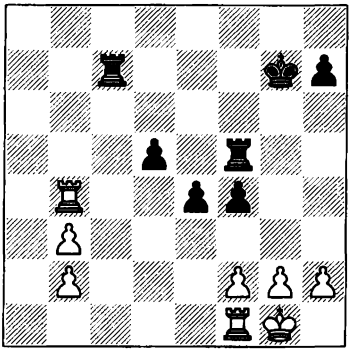
27 ♕g4?

The desire to achieve victory no matter what the cost in this case did Adams no favours. He should have resigned himself to the fact that the position was level. After **27 ♕xg7+** ♕xg7 28 ♘xg7 ♔xg7 29 ♖xd6 ♖xb2 30 ♖d4 f3 31 g3 ♖xb3 32 ♖xe4 ♖b8 a drawn four rooks ending would have arisen.

27	**...**	**♖a7!**
28	**♖c1**	**♕f5**
29	**♕xf5**	**♖xf5**
30	**♘xg7**	**♔xg7**

Now White must apply his not insignificant forces in order to maintain the equilibrium.

31	**♖c4**	**d5**
32	**♖xb4**	**♖c7** *(D)*

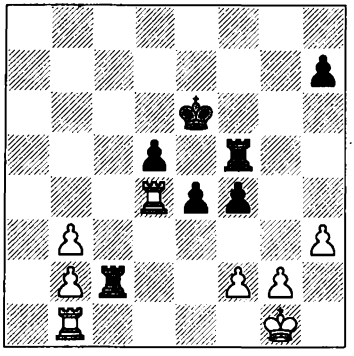


W

33 ♖d1?!

Such passive tactics could have led White into serious unpleasantness. He should have quickly provoked a crisis: **33 g4!** fg (or 33...♖g5 34 f3 ♖c2 35 h4 ♖g6 36 g5 h6 37 ♖b7+ =) 34 hg ♖c2 35 ♖d4 ♔f6 36 f3! ♔e5 (36...ef 37 g4! =) 37 ♖fd1 ♖xf3 38 ♖xd5+ ♔e6 39 ♖5d2 ♖xg3+ 40 ♔f1, with good chances to save the game.

33	**...**	**♖c2**
34	**♖bd4**	**♔f6**
35	**h3**	**♔e6**
36	**♖b1**	**♔e5**
37	**♖bd1**	**♔e6**
38	**♖b1** *(D)*	



B

38 ... ♔d6?!

And Black lets slip a generous reply. He should have played more decisively: **38...f3!** 39 gf (if 39 g4, then 39...♖g5 40 b4 h5, winning) 39...♖xf3 40 ♖bd1 ♖f5 41 ♖4d2 ♖xd2 42 ♖xd2 ♖f3 43 ♔g2 ♖xb3 –+.

39 b4 e3

Beliavsky's last chance for success lay in the move 39...f3. Now with exact play Adams achieves a peaceful outcome.

40 fe fe
41 ♖d3 ♖ff2
42 ♖xe3 ♖xg2+
43 ♔h1 ♖xb2
44 ♖d1 ♖g5
45 ♖d4 ♖e5
46 ♖g3! ♖e1+
47 ♖g1 ♖e4
48 ♖xe4 de
49 ♖g4 ♔e5
50 ♔g1 ♖xb4
51 ♖h4 ♖b7
52 ♔f2 ♔d4
53 ♔e2 ♖b2+
54 ♔f1 ½-½

In the next game (in which we shall discuss some move-order nuances) Kramnik hoped to achieve a comfortable game by making use of 13...♘e7, but a nasty surprise awaited him...

Game 18
Ivanchuk – Kramnik
Novgorod 1994

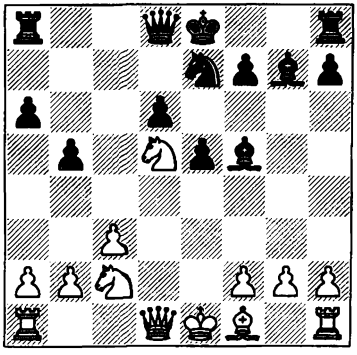
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gf 10 ♘d5 f5 11 ef ♗xf5 12 c3

12 ... ♗g7
13 ♘c2 ♘e7 *(D)*

As regards the nuances of the position, the most precise move in our opinion is **13...0-0**, and if 14 g3, then 14...♗e4. There remains 14 ♘ce3 and then g2-g3, and other plans which are less popular at the present time.

14 ♗d3!

White may try **14 ♘xe7**, for example, **14...♔xe7** (14...♕xe7 15 ♕f3) 15 ♘b4 ♔f8 16 ♕f3 ♕c8 17 ♕d5 ♕b8 18 ♗d3 ♗d7 19 ♕f3 a5 20 ♗e4 ♖a7 21 ♗d5 f5 22 ♘c6 1-0 Adams-Sandström, London 1993. Black played better in Adams-Shirov, Khalkidhiki 1993: **14...♗xc2**



W

15 ♕xc2 ♕xe7 16 ♗e2 (16 a4 0-0!) 16...0-0 17 0-0 d5 18 ♖fd1 ♖fd8 19 ♕b3 ♕c5 20 a4 ba 21 ♖xa4 a5 22 g3, and White had only a minimal advantage.

Before this game White usually reacted to Black's transposition (13...♘e7 instead of 13...♗e6) by means of the standard **14 ♘ce3**, which led to a normal position from this variation: 14...♗e6 15 g3 ♘xd5 16 ♘xd5 0-0 17 ♗g2. Of course, this narrows down his possibilities. After 13...♗e6 White can for the time being manage without 14 ♘ce3 and straight away develop his kingside with g2-g3 and ♗f1-g2.

Ivanchuk finds a tactical route and seemingly places Black's 14th move in doubt.

14 ♘xd5?!

Of course, if **14...♗e6?!**, then 15 ♗e4, and white controls the central light squares.

(*Typesetter's note:* It is worth mentioning that **14...e4** is bad after 15 ♘xe7 ♕xe7 16 ♗xb5+ axb5 17 ♕d5 and White wins a pawn.)

15 ♗xf5 ♘e7

15...♘f6 is not promising, as it allows White to consolidate conclusively his hold on f5, which has no less (if not more) significance than d5, as it is closer to the enemy king.

16 ♕g4 0-0
17 ♖d1 d5
18 ♘e3

An unexpected question arises: how should Black carry on? There is the simple threat of 19 ♗e4, and **18...♖a7** solves not a single problem in view of 19 0-0 followed by ♖d1-d2 and ♖f1-d1. Therefore the following queen sacrifice is practically forced.

18 ... d4
19 ♗e4

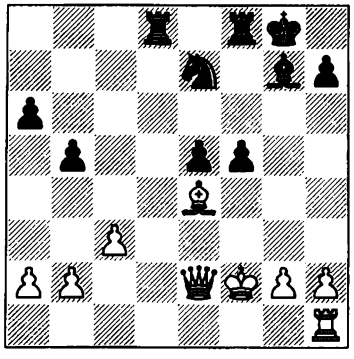
Threatening the terrible 20 ♘f5.

19 ... de
20 ♖xd8 ef+
21 ♔xf2 ♖axd8
22 ♕e2 f5 *(D)*

Black seems to have compensation, but Ivanchuk precisely and boldly plays to extinguish the initiative, and is left with a big material advantage. Now for Kramnik there remains only the hope of a mistake by his opponent in the complications, and if he hadn't

decided upon the sacrifice then he would have ended up in a strategically worse position with no prospects.

By continuing instead **22...♖d6** 23 ♖d1 ♖fd8 24 ♖xd6 ♖xd6, he could have saved the queenside, but not the game.



W

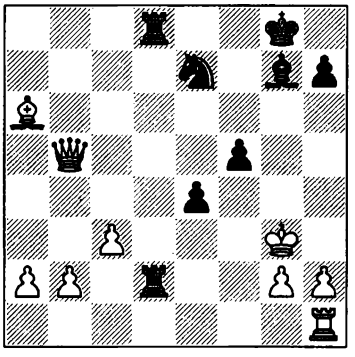
23 ♗b7! ♖d7

After **23...♘g6** Black is deprived of counterplay on the d-file, for example 24 ♖d1 ♘f4 25 ♕c2 and his position becomes absolutely hopeless.

24 ♗xa6 ♖fd8
25 ♕xb5 ♖d2+
26 ♔g3 e4 *(D)*

Black is not helped by **26...♘g6** 27 ♖f1, e.g. **27...♘f4** 28 ♖xf4 ef+ 29 ♔h3 with the idea of ♗a6-b7-f3, or **27...e4** 28 ♕b3+! ♔h8 29 ♖xf5 ♗e5+ 30 ♖xe5 ♘xe5 31 ♕e6 +–.

27 ♖e1! ♘g6



W

Why not continue **27...♖8d3+**? White can reply 28 ♕xd3! ed (or 28...♗e5+ 29 ♔h3 +–) 29 ♖xe7 ♖xb2 30 ♗xd3, and the endgame, despite the presence of opposite-coloured bishops, is quite hopeless for Black. Strictly speaking, 28 ♕xd3 also maintains all White's defences, but this had to be foreseen eight moves previously in order to evaluate the consequences of the apparently threatening queen sacrifice!

28 ♖e2

Now all becomes clear.

28 ... ♗e5+
29 ♔f2 ♖d1
30 ♖e1!

A final precise move to a virtuoso defence.

30 ... ♖8d2+
31 ♔f1 ♖xe1+
32 ♔xe1 ♖xg2
33 ♗c8

It's time for White to attack...

33	**...**	**f4**
34	**♗f5**	**♗f6**
35	**♗xe4**	**♖xh2**
36	**a4**	**♘e5**
37	**a5**	**f3**
38	**a6**	**♖h1+**
39	**♔d2**	**♖h2+**

1-0

In fact Kramnik lost on time (this was the 40th move in the game, which started with the ...e6 move order).

Conclusion

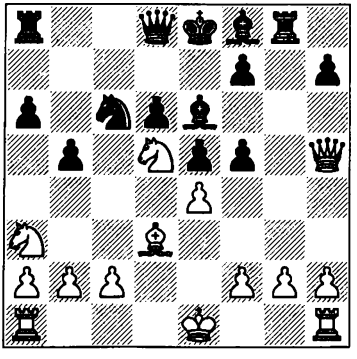
Here as well, by choosing a precise move order, Black can look optimistically to the future. Ivanchuk's novelty is very interesting and inflicts a powerful blow on one branch of this variation.

8 10...f5 11 ♗d3

Game 19
Beliavsky – Shirov
Groningen 1993

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gf 10 ♘d5 f5
11 ♗d3 ♗e6
12 ♕h5 ♖g8 *(D)*

The latest novelty in this position, although the theory is developing so quickly that this one is beginning to look quite old. Before this, the continuation 12...♗g7 underwent all-round tests. In the 1980s 12...f4 was also revived, having previously been considered unsuccessful because of 13 g3.



W

13 g3

Other moves will be examined in subsequent games.

13 ♘d4

In this position, which is rich with chances for both sides, the following variations are possible:

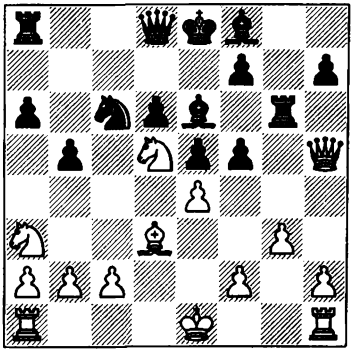
a) **13...♖g5!?** 14 ♕xh7 ♗xd5 15 ed ♘e7 (Timoshenko recommends 15...♕a5+ 16 c3 b4 17 dc! ♕d5 18 ♗c4 ♕e4+ 19 ♔d2 ♖g7 20 ♕h4 ±) 16 0-0-0 ♕b6!? (but not 16...e4?! 17 ♗e2 ♕b6 18 ♕h4! ♖g6 19 g4 f4 20 g5! f3 21 ♗f1 e3 22 ♖d3! e2 23 ♗h3 ± ♕a5 24 b4 ♕a4 25 ♖xf3 a5 26 ♖e1! ab 27 ♕f4 f6 28 ♘b1 ♕xa2 29 ♗e6 with a decisive advantage to White, Timoshenko-Rogozenko, Bucharest 1993) 17 ♖hf1!? (17 f4 ♖g6 18 ♕h3 e4 19 ♗e2 ♕e3+ 20 ♖d2 ♗g7 ∓ Pyda-Zeziulkin, Poland 1993) 17...♖g6 18 ♕h3 e4 19 ♗e2 ♗g7 20 ♗h5 ♖h6 21 g4 ♕c5 22 ♔b1 fg 23 ♕xg4 ♗xb2 24 ♔xb2 ♕b4+ 25 ♔a1 ♕xa3 with a draw, according to Zeziulkin's analysis. (*Typesetter's note:* 22....b4 wins a piece).

b) In the game Otsyko-Skrobek, Polanica 1992, Black played **13...♖c8** 14 c3 ♖g6!?, and following **15 ♕f3!** ♗xd5 16 ed e4 17 ♕xf5 ♖g5! 18 ♕f4! ed 19 dc ♖e5+

20 ♔f1 ♕b6 21 ♕f3 achieved a worse position. White found another route to the advantage in Kasparov-Salov, Linares 1992, which continued **15** ♘c2 ♖h6 16 ♕e2! ♗xd5 17 ed ♘e7 18 f3 ♗g7 19 ♘e3 f4 20 gf ♘g6 21 0-0-0? ± (21 fe ♘f4 22 ♕d2 ♕h4+ 23 ♔d1 ±).

But why should Black spend a tempo on the apparently superfluous move 13...♖c8?

c) After **13...♖g6!?** *(D)* White is at a cross-roads:



W

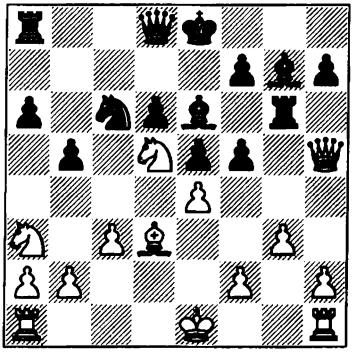
c1) **14 ef??** ♗xd5 15 fg hg and 16...♗xh1.

c2) **14 ♕xh7** ♖h6 15 ♕g8 ♖g6 with a perpetual attack on Black's queen.

c3) **14 0-0** f4!? (the queen on h5 turns out to be unoccupied, all the more so as Black can therefore develop an attack with a tempo: 14...♖h6!? 15 ♕d1 f4).

c4) **14 0-0-0** ♘d4 (this position could have arisen by transposition in Liong Zhinrang-Kindermann, USA 1983, the moves of which were 12...♘d4 13 0-0-0 ♖c8 {if 13...♖g6, then we find ourselves in our position} 14 ♔b1 fe 15 ♗xe4 b4! 16 ♘xb4 ♖g5 17 ♕xh7 d5 18 ♗xd5 ♗xd5 19 ♘xd5 ♕xd5 20 ♕d3 ♗xa3 21 ♕xa3 with an unclear game) 15 ♖d2 (Black threatened 15...♖h6), and Black has some quite dangerous continuations: **15...♗xd5** 16 ed and now 16...♗h6 or 16...♕a5 with the idea of ...b5-b4 and ...♕a5xd5; 15...♖c8 is also quite possible, in analogy with the game above. Thus for the time being moving the king to either flank is quite dangerous; his opponent's knight is concentrating on d4 with great effect.

c5) **14 c3 ♗g7!?** (14...♖a7 is worse) and now *(D)*:



W

c51) **15 ♘c2** ♖h6! 16 ♕e2 (16 ♕f3 ♗xd5 17 ed e4 18 ♕xf5 ed 19 dc dc –+) 16...♗xd5 17 ed ♘e7 with a good game for Black.

c52) **15 ♕f3** (forcing events, but Black is prepared) 15...♗xd5 16 ed ♘e7 (16...e4 17 ♕xf5 ed 18 dc ♕e7+ 19 ♔f1 ♕e2+ 20 ♔g2 ♖f6 21 ♕d7+ +–) 17 ♗xf5 ♖f6 (it is precisely because of this variation that 14...♗g7 is necessary; the rook on f6 must be defended from the threat of ♗f5-d7+ and ♕f3xf6 – otherwise, on general considerations one would prefer 14...♖a7, since it is unclear where the bishop would be best placed) 18 g4 ♘xf5 (18...♔f8!? 19 ♖g1 ♗h6 and only then ...♘e7xf5 and ...♕d8-d7 also deserves attention) 19 gf ♗h6 20 ♖g1 ♔e7 21 ♘c2 ♕d7 22 ♘b4 ♕xf5 23 ♘c6+ (23 ♕xf5 ♖xf5 24 ♘c6+ ♔f6) 23...♔f8! 24 ♕xf5 ♖xf5 25 a4 ♖e8 with the idea of ...e5-e4-e3.

In this way, here Black has wonderful chances, while the white knight remains on a3. The assessment of many lines in the Sveshnikov depends on these factors: the knight on a3, the d5-square, and the possibility of using the extra central pawn.

c53) **15 ♕xh7** (there's no point in losing two whole tempi for one single pawn) 15...♔f8 16 ♕h5 ♖h6 17 ♕e2 (17 ♕f3?? is no good: 17...♗xd5 18 ed e4 19 ♕xf5 ed 20 dc ♕e7+ 21 ♔f1 ♕e2+ 22 ♔g2 ♖f6, and Black wins) 17...♗xd5 18 ed ♘e7 with the idea of ...e5-e4.

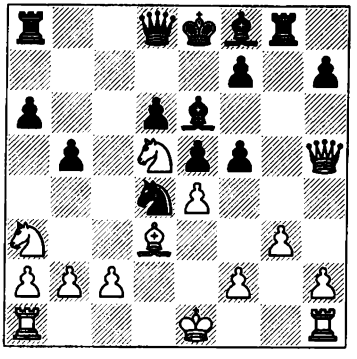
c54) **15 0-0** f4!? (the standard 15...♖h6 16 ♕e2/d1 ♗xd5 17 ed ♘e7 is also possible; this is distinguished from the similar position with pawns on f7, f5 and e5, which arises after other continuations, for example: 11...♖g8 12 c3 ♗xd5 13 ed ♘e7 14 g3 e4 15 ♗e2 h6 16 f4! with an active position for the rook, and as a consequence, the possibility of not hurrying with ...e5-e4, although in this case as well after 16...b4 17 cb ♕b6, Black has distinct counterplay; besides this line, 16...ef is worth looking at) 16 ♕e2 ♘e7!? (with the idea of 17...♗xd5 18 ed f5) 17 ♘xe7 ♔xe7!, and after ...♕d8-b6 and ...h7-h5 Black has a head start in developing an initiative.

c55) **15 0-0-0** ♖h6 16 ♕e2 (16 ♕f3 ♗xd5 17 ed ♕g5+!? 18 ♔b1 can be met by 18...e4 19 ♕e2 ♘e5, or alternatively 18...♘e7; the black knight is, of course, more active on e5, but from e7 it exerts pressure on the important d5-pawn) 16...♗xd5 (16...♔f8!?; 16...♖c8!?) 17 ed ♘e7, and, as we already know, Black has an excellent game; in the same manner, 13...♖g6!? is an interesting move, but unfortunately it has yet to undergo practical tests.

d) **13...♖g4** 14 f4 (14 h3 fe 15 hg ed 16 ♘e3 d5 17 cd ♕a5+ 18 ♔f1 ♕d2 ∓; 14 ♘e3 fe 15 ♘g4 ed 16 cd ♘d4! ∓; 14 f3 ♖g6 15 ♕h4 ♕xh4 16 gh ♗xd5 17 ed ♘e7 −+ Brustman-Kramnik, Groningen 1991) 14...ef (14...♗g7 15 c3 b4 16 ♘c2 bc 17 ♘xc3 ef 18 ef ♖g5 was unclear in Magem Badals-I.Sokolov, Barcelona 1992) 15 0-0-0!? (15 gf ♗g7 16 0-0-0 ♗xd5 17 ed ♕f6 with initiative to Black; 15 ♘xf4 ♖xf4!? 16 gf ♕f6 17 c3 b4 18 ♘c2 bc 19 b3 with a slight plus for White in Timoshenko-Krasenkov, Voskresensk 1992) 15...fg?! (15...♗xd5 16 ed ♘e5 17 ♖he1 ♗g7 with an unclear game; 15...fe!? 16 ♗xe4 fg 17 ♘f6+ ♕xf6 18 ♗xc6+ ♔d8 19 ♗xa8 ♖b4 20 c3 ♗h6+ 21 ♔b1 ♕xc3 with compensation for the missing material) 16 ef ♖h4 17 ♘c7+ ♔d7 18 fe+ ♔xc7 19 ♕xf7+ ♔b6! 20 hg ♕g5+ 21 ♔b1 ♖xh1?! (21...♕xg3 ±) 22 ♖xh1?! (22 ♕f2+ ♕c5 23 ♕xc5+ dc 24 ♖xh1 ±) 22...d5!? 23 ♖xh7 ♗e7 24 ♕f2+ ♗c5 25 ♕f1 ♗xa3 26 ba = Zontakh-Manik, Bratislava 1994.

The continuation in the actual game gives evidence to the fact that Shirov is trying to make use of the weakness of White's light squares. It is interesting that previously they were thought weak for Black. As subsequent events show, this was the correct assumption. Beliavsky, as Black, simply could not hold on to the means of using the weakness of the light squares.

Now we return to the position after 13...♘d4 *(D)*:



W

14 c3 fe
15 ♗xe4 ♗g4
16 ♕xh7

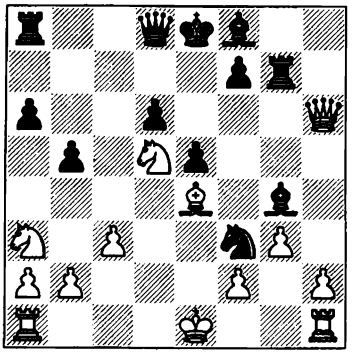
16 ♕h4? is certainly wrong after 16...♘f3+ 17 ♗xf3 ♕xh4 18 gh ♗xf3 19 ♘f6+ ♔d8 20 ♘xg8 ♗xh1 and Black has the better endgame.

16 ... ♖g7
17 ♕h6

17 ♕h8 ♘f3+ 18 ♔e2 ♘g5+ 19 f3 ♘xe4 20 fg is not clear. Beliavsky obviously paid attention to the paradoxical king move in this variation given by Klovans.

17 ... ♘f3+ *(D)*
18 ♔e2!

In the event of the natural continuation **18 ♔f1** ♖g5 (18...♖g6!?



W

19 ♕e3 ♗h6 20 ♕d3 ♘d2+ 21 ♔g2 ♘xe4 22 ♕xe4, and Black has compensation for the sacrificed pawn in view of his bishop pair and strong central pawns) 19 ♘f6+ ♔e7 (19...♕xf6? 20 ♗c6+! ♔e7 21 ♕xf6+ ♔xf6 22 ♗xa8 +– Klovans-Taborov, Kaluga 1985) 20 ♕h8 ♘d2+ 21 ♔g2 ♘xe4 22 ♘xe4 ♖g6 23 ♕h4+ ♔d7 24 ♕xd8+ ♖xd8 25 f3 ♗e6 26 ♖hd1 ♔c7 Black's position is also quite satisfactory, Magem-Zsu.Polgar, Madrid 1992.

18 ... ♘g5+

18...♖g6 19 ♕e3 ♗h6 20 ♕b6 is not the road to happiness.

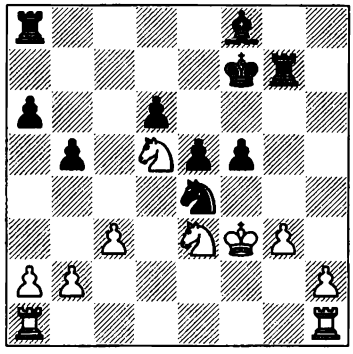
19 f3 ♘xe4
20 fg ♕c8!
21 ♕e3!

21 ♖af1 ♕xg4+ 22 ♔e1 is suspicious, as is **21 ♔d3** ♕xg4 22 ♖ae1 ♘f2+ 23 ♔d2 ♕f3 with a mighty attack.

21 ... ♕xg4+
22 ♕f3 ♕xf3+
23 ♔xf3 f5
24 ♘c2

24 c4!? is also interesting.

24 ... ♔f7
25 ♘ce3 *(D)*



B

25 ... ♔e6?

It is not clear whether Black has sacrificed a pawn or simply missed this. In any case **25...♘f6!** was more reliable, followed by 26 a4 ♘xd5 27 ♘xd5 ♔e6 28 ♖hd1 ♖b8 29 b4 a5! 30 ba ba 31 ♖xa4 ♖b2 with the idea after 32 a6? of continuing 32...♖xh2 33 a7 e4+ 34 ♔e3 ♔e5! with unavoidable mating threats, as analysed by Beliavsky.

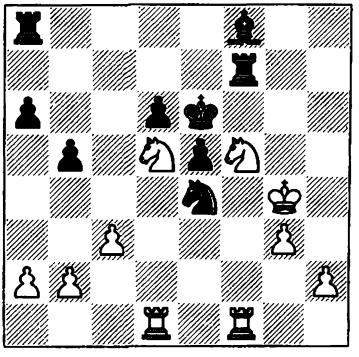
26 ♘xf5 ♘g5+
27 ♔g4 ♖f7
28 ♖hf1

Another, perhaps better, possibility was **28 ♘de3** ♘e4 29 ♖hf1.

28 ... ♘e4

29 ♖ad1?! *(D)*

It would have been better to unleash the knight a little more quickly first: **29 ♘fe3** ♖aa7 30 ♔h3 ♗h6 31 ♔g2 ±.



B

29 ... ♖aa7?

29...♖d8! would have been a more stubborn defence, with the idea after ♘d5-e3 of replying ...d6-d5 and ...♗f8-c5 – Shirov.

30 ♘de3 ♖ad7
31 ♔f3 d5
32 g4!

With the help of tactics White maintains the f5-knight in a very strong position.

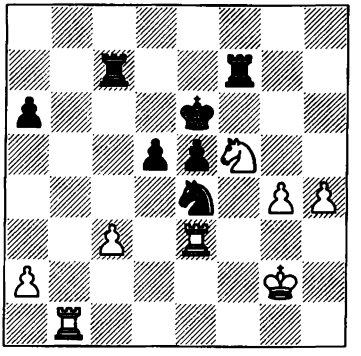
32 ... ♗c5
33 h4 ♘f6

Otherwise he cannot carry out ...d5-d4.

34 ♖fe1 b4
35 ♖e2 bc
36 bc ♗xe3
37 ♖xe3 ♘e4
38 ♔g2 ♖c7

It would have been worth returning to the b-file with 38...♖b7.

39 ♖b1! *(D)*



B

The rest is easy.

39 ... ♖b7
40 ♖b3 ♘d2
41 ♖xb7 ♖xb7
42 ♖e2 ♘b1
43 ♖c2 ♘a3
44 ♖f2 ♘b1
45 g5?!

45 h5 is stronger; 45...♘xc3 46 h6 d4 47 ♘g7+ ♔e7 48 h7 ♖b8 49 ♘f5+ ♔e6 50 g5 ♘e4 51 g6 +–.

45 ... ♘xc3
46 g6 ♖d7?

The final chance for salvation lay in 46...♖b8 47 g7 ♘e4 48 ♖f3 ♘f6 49 ♔h3 ♖b1 or 46...♘e4 47 g7 ♘f6! straight away.

47 g7 ♔f7
48 h5 ♔g8
49 h6 ♔h7

50 ♘e3! 1-0

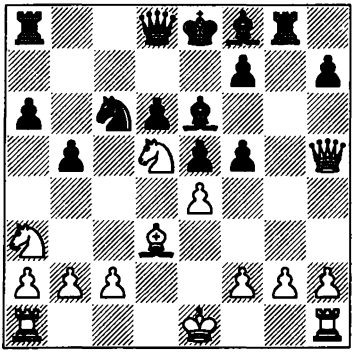
An important game for theory.

The following game became fundamental to the reappraisal of the value of the variation with 13 0-0-0. Black bravely takes the g2-pawn, and although White uses a very clever novelty, its refutation is indeed thunderous.

Game 20
Brodsky – Kramnik
Kherson 1991

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gf 10 ♘d5 f5 11 ♗d3 ♗e6 12 ♕h5 ♖g8 *(D)*

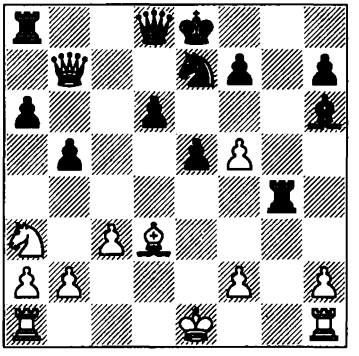
13 0-0-0



W

This move and 13 g3, examined above, are the main continuations. **13 f4** and **13 c4** have both gone out of fashion. The following alternatives have been tested:

a) **13 c3 ♖xg2 14 ♕f3 ♖g4 15 ef ♗xd5 16 ♕xd5 ♘e7 17 ♕b7 ♗h6** (17...♕c8!?) and then *(D)*:



W

a1) **18 ♘c2 ♔f8!** 19 ♖d1 (19 ♘e3! ♗xe3 20 fe ♘g8 21 f6! ♘xf6 22 ♖f1 ♖b8 23 ♕f3 e4 24 ♕xf6 ♕xf6 25 ♖xf6 ed 26 0-0-0) 19...♖b8! 20 ♕f3 ♖f4 21 ♕h3 ♗g5 22 ♘e3 e4 ∓ Luther-Shirov, Germany 1992.

a2) **18 f6** ♘g6 19 ♖d1 ♘h4 20 ♗e2 ♖g6 21 ♕c6+ ♔f8 22 ♖xd6 ♕e8 23 ♕xe8+ ♔xe8 24 ♗d3 ± Van der Wiel-Reinderman, Brussels Z 1993.

b) **13 0-0** f4! 14 c4? b4 15 ♘c2 ♗g4 16 ♕xh7 ♖g6 17 h3 ♗f3 18 ♕xg6 fg 19 gf ♖a7 –+ Smagin-Yurtaev, Hartberg 1991.

13 ... ♖xg2!

Bravely taking up the challenge! The less energetic **13...♖c8** led

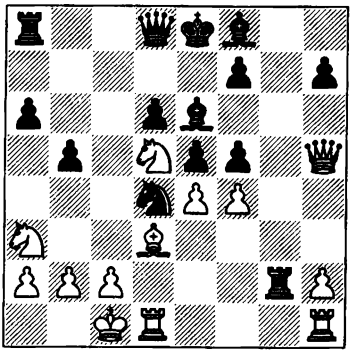
after 14 ♘b1 h6 15 ♕e2 ♘d4 16 ♕e1 fe 17 ♗xe4 f5 18 ♖xd4 fe 19 ♕xe4 ♖g4 20 f4 ♖c5 21 g3 ♔f7 22 ♖d2 ♕a8 23 ♖hd1 ef 24 ♖e2 ♖g6 25 ♕xf4+ to a winning position for White in Dvoirys-Kalinichev, Berlin 1992.

Black could have gained reasonable chances for success in Morgado-Milovanović, corr 1991, where he employed **13...h6** with the idea of capturing the white queen (14...fe and 15...♗g4). The encounter continued thus: 14 h3 ♖c8 15 f4 ♖xg2 16 ♕f3 ♖g8? 17 ef ♘d4 18 ♗xb5+! ab 19 ♖xd4 ed 20 fe ♖g6 (20...fe 21 ♕h5+ ♔d7 22 ♕f7+ ♗e7 23 ♘f6+ ♔c6 24 ♘xg8 +–) 21 ♘xb5 ♕a5 22 f5 ♖g5 23 h4 d3 24 ♘dc3!, and White won. But if Milovanović had played instead 16...♖g7!, then White's combination, had play proceeded in the same way, would not have worked because of 20...fe, for example 21 ♕e2 ♔f7 22 ♖e1 ♖g6 with a distinct advantage for Black.

14 f4

The capture on g2 is considered dangerous for Black precisely because of this continuation. After **14 ♕f3** ♖g4! 15 ef ♗xd5 16 ♕xd5 (16 ♕xg4 ♗xh1 17 ♖xh1 d5 is also good for Black) 16...♘b4 18 ♕b7 ♖b8 White's affairs are in a sorry state.

14 ... ♘d4 *(D)*



W

15 ♘e3

If **15 ♖hg1**, then 15...fe 16 ♖xg2 ed, and White has a bad position, while the game Kindermann-Skrobek, Warsaw 1983, continued **15 c3** ♕a5 (15...♗xd5 16 ed b4! 17 cb ♕b6 allows White a strong initiative) 16 ♔b1 ♗xd5 17 ed b4 18 ♘c4 ♖xb2+ 19 ♔xb2 bc+ 20 ♔a1 ♕a4 and then **21 ♖b1?** ♕xc4! led to a winning position for Black (22 ♗xc4 walks into 22...♘c2#). However, by playing **21 fe!?** ♘b3+ 22 ♔b1 ♖b8 23 e6! ♘d4+ and then **24 ♔a1** White, according to Kindermann's analysis, could have held on, but in the event of **24 ♔c1** ♗h6+! 25 ♕xh6? ♕c2+! 26 ♗xc2 ♘e2# he is mated in really beautiful style.

The variation is not totally convincing, but the main thing is the move ...♗f8-h6, and the idea connected with it of giving smothered mate had already been found!

There is one other interesting point in Kindermann's analysis; he also shows this variation: **15 ♘e3** ♖f2 16 ef ♗xa2 with the idea of ...♖a8-c8 and ...♘d4-b3#. Now it only remains to unite these two ideas, which Kramnik does brilliantly. But why did Brodsky go into a variation which ended (according to Kindermann's analysis) with the symbol −+? The fact is that he had prepared an interesting tactical blow ... thus:

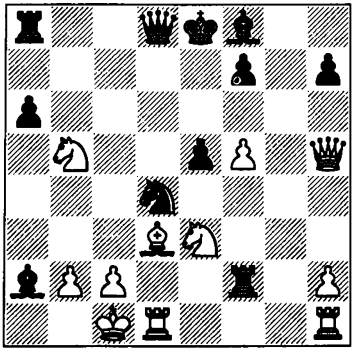
15 ... ♖f2
16 ef ♗xa2
17 fe

After **17 ♘g4** Black can carry out his plan immediately: 17...♖c8 and ...♘b3#.

17 ... de

17...♖c8 is premature due to 18 ♗xb5+ ♘xb5 19 ♘xb5 ab 20 ed with an unclear game.

18 ♘xb5!? *(D)*



B

This is what Brodsky had prepared. One gets the impression that White, who is better mobilized, has seized the initiative. After the natural **18...ab** 19 ♗xb5 ♘xb5 20 ♖xd8+ ♖xd8 21 f6 his position is more promising.

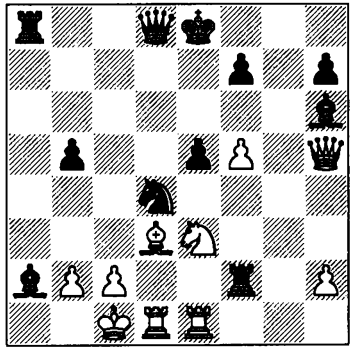
18 ... ♗h6!!

After White's novelty comes a mighty counterblow, which decides the outcome of the duel.

19 ♖he1

We already know the theme of the line **19 ♕xh6?** ♖xc2+ 20 ♘xc2 ♘b3#, or 20 ♗xc2 ♘e2#.

19 ab *(D)*



W

20 ♗xb5+

Again, not **20 ♕xh6** because of 20...♗c4, and misfortune reaches White from the other side.

20 ... ♔e7
21 ♕h4+

21 ♕xh6 still does not work due to 21...♖xc2+. **21 f6+** ♖xf6 22

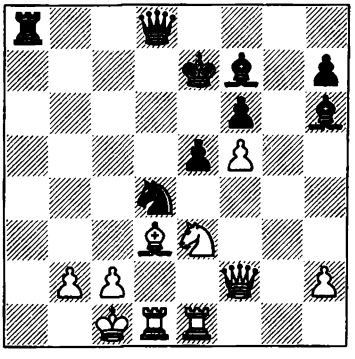
♕xe5+ ♖e6 23 ♕c5+ ♕d6 –+ is no good either.

21 ... f6
22 ♕xf2 ♗f7

All the black pieces are taking part in the attack, and moreover the queen and rook are doing so without moving from their places.

23 ♗d3 *(D)*

If **23 b3**, then 23...♕a5 24 ♗a4 ♕c3 25 ♖d3 ♘xb3+ 26 ♔d1 ♗h5+!. The mobility of this bishop, which creates threats in every corner of the board, is amazing.



B

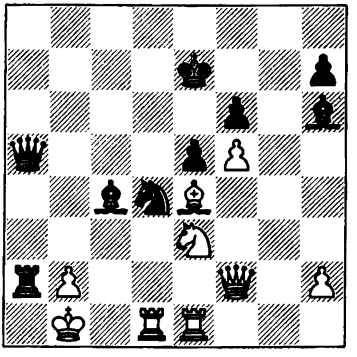
23 ... ♕b6
24 ♗e4

24 c3 ♖a1+ 25 ♗b1 ♗a2 also loses.

24 ♖a2

This is a more exact move than **24...♖a1+** 25 ♔d2 ♕b4+ 26 ♔d3, when a straightforward win is not in evidence.

24 c4 ♗xc4
25 ♔b1 ♕a5 *(D)*



W

26 ♘d5+

The abundance of pretty mating finales which are possible in the different variations of this game is simply startling. In particular, if **26 ♘c2**, then 26...♖a1+ 27 ♘xa1 ♕a2#.

27 ... ♗xd5
28 ♕xd4 ♖a1+
29 ♔c2 ♖xd1

The prosaic **29...ed** 30 ♗xd5+ ♕xe1 was also possible, but Kramnik prefers to continue the game to mate.

30 ♕xd1 ♕a4+
31 ♔c3

0-1

In general the Sveshnikov produces a high percentage of beautiful games. We think that this is because conflicting play very often arises within it, and sometimes it is

only possible to gain a conclusion in such sharp conflicts at the expense of tactical decisions. And if one side does not manage or allow such possibilities, then retribution will not be slow in coming.

Now we will examine the moves that were popular in the early days of this variation – ...0-0 and ...f5-f4. These days they still cannot complain of a lack of attention by chess players.

Game 21

Timoshenko – Zeziulkin

Warsaw 1992

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gf 10 ♘d5 f5 11 ♗d3 ♗e6

12 ♕h5

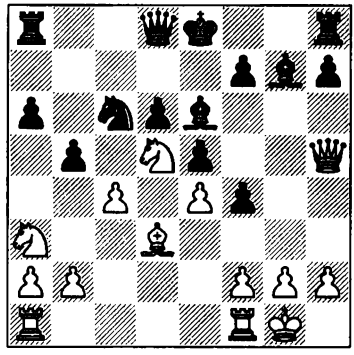
A 1994 game, G.Kuzmin-Zeziulkin, tested the alternative **12 c3**, viz. 12...♗g7 13 ♘xb5 ♗xd5 14 ed ♘e7 15 ♘a3 e4 16 ♗c2 ♘g6 17 ♕h5 ♕f6 18 h4 ♖b8 19 ♘c4 ♖xb2 20 ♗a4+ ♔f8 21 0-0 ♘f4 22 ♕g5 ♕xg5 23 hg and the game ended peacefully.

12 ... ♗g7

13 0-0 f4

After **13...♖b8** 14 c4 fe 15 ♗xe4 ♘e7 16 ♖ad1 ♘g6 17 f4 ef 18 ♘xf4 ♕b6+ 19 ♔h1 ♘xf4 20 ♖xf4 White has the advantage, Kruppa-Muraviev, Alushta 1994.

14 c4 *(D)*



B

The most principled and dangerous move in this variation. By not giving away any breathing space, White immediately strengthens his mastery of the light squares.

14 ... bc

14...b4 does not change the assessment of the position, which is unpromising for Black, who lacks counterplay. Thipsay-Chowdury, Calcutta 1994, continued: 15 ♘c2 ♖b8 16 b3 (16 ♖fd1 straight away is also good) 16...0-0 17 ♖fd1 ♕d7 18 ♗e2 f5 19 ♗f3 fe 20 ♗xe4 ♗f5 21 ♕e2 f3? 22 gf ♗xe4 23 fe ♖f7 24 ♖d3 ♖bf8 25 ♖f1 ♖f3 26 ♕xf3 ♖xf3 27 ♖xf3 ♕g4+ 28 ♖g3 +–.

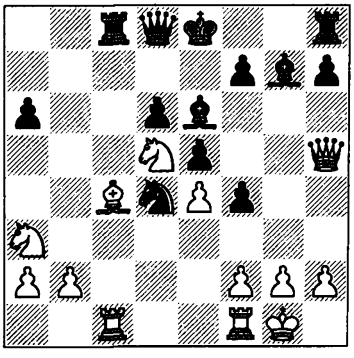
15 ♗xc4

It is important to keep the pieces in control of d5, so moving the knight to c4 is best left for a more appropriate moment. Furthermore, after the invasion of the knight onto

d4, White's knight route alters (♘a3-c2).

15 0-0

Maintaining all the possibilities for the knight here: ...♘d4, ...♘e7 or even ...♘a5. **15...♘d4** has independent significance; **16 ♖ac1 ♖c8!?** *(D)* is an interesting idea by Filipenko:



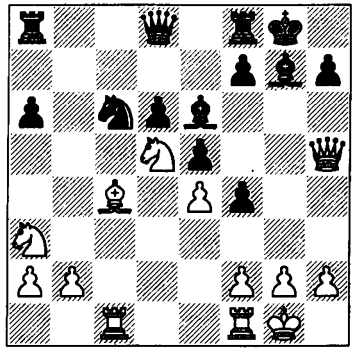
W

a) The game Osipov-Kozyrev, Cheliabinsk 1991, continued **17 ♗xa6** ♖xc1 18 ♖xc1 0-0 19 ♘b5!? ♘xb5 20 ♗xb5 ♗xd5 21 ed f5 22 ♗a6 ♕f6 23 ♖c8 e4 24 ♖xf8+ ♗xf8 25 h3 e3 =. A strong passed pawn and opposite-coloured bishops ensure that Black will escape trouble.

b) **17 ♘b6!?** is a stronger idea: 17...♖xc4!? (17...♗xc4 is no good: 18 ♘axc4 ♖b8 19 ♘d5 0-0 20 ♔h1 f5 21 f3 ± Arsenev-Filipenko, Kharkov 1980) 18 ♘axc4 0-0 with the idea of ...f7-f5, developing an initiative on the kingside; but to be honest, we, unlike Filipenko, are not yet convinced that Black has enough compensation for the exchange after 19 ♕d1.

16 ♖ac1 *(D)*

Creating the threat of 17 ♘xf4, for example, **16...♖a7** 17 ♘xf4 ef 18 ♗xe6 ♘e7 19 ♗c4 ♘g6 20 ♖c2 ♖e7 21 ♗d5 ♖e5 and White has an extra pawn, although Black does have some counterplay, Dobsa-Wefling, corr 1990-1.



B

16 ♖b8

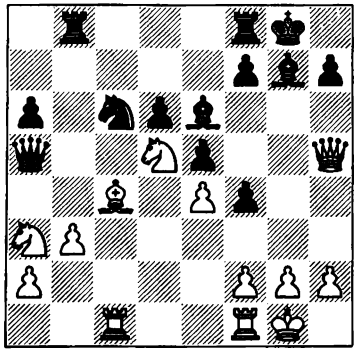
Black experiences greater problems after 16...♘d4 17 ♘c2 ♘xc2 18 ♖xc2 ♔h8 19 ♖fc1 ♖c8, e.g. **20 b4** a5 21 a3 ab 22 ab ♖b8 23 ♗d3 ♕d7 24 b5 ♕a7 25 b6 ♕a5 26 g3 fg 27 hg h6 28 g4! ♖g8 29 ♘e7 ♕xb6 30 ♘xg8 ♖xg8 31 ♗c4 +– Ulybin-Ju.Nun, Sochi 1988, or **20 ♖c3** a5 21 ♖d1 h6 22 ♕e2 ♖c5 23 a3 f5 24 b4 ab 25 ab ♖c6 26 b5 ♖c5

27 ♗a2 ♕a5 28 ♖xc5 dc 29 ♘e7 ♗xa2 30 ♘g6+ ♔g8 31 ♘xf8 +– Pedzich-Wehmeier, Miedzybrodzie Zyw., 1991. It is obvious that exchanging the strong d4-knight for the knight on a3 is no good for Black, and goes against the spirit of the variation.

17 b3 ♕d7

Black has tried to avoid moving his queen and exchange straight away on d5, but without success: **17...♗xd5** 18 ♗xd5 ♘b4 19 ♖fd1 ± ♘xa2 (otherwise White will play the simple 20 ♖d2) 20 ♖c6 ♕e7 21 ♘c4 ♘b4 22 ♖xd6 ♘xd5 23 ♖6xd5 ♖xb3 24 ♘d6 h6 25 h4 ♖fb8 26 ♘f5 ♕f8 27 ♕g4 ♖b1 28 ♘xh6+ ♔h7 29 ♘f5 ♗f6 30 ♖xb1 ♖xb1+ 31 ♔h2 ♖b7 32 ♖d6 ♗g7 33 ♖d8 1-0 Wolff-Bronstein, Wijk aan Zee 1992.

Recently **17...♕a5** *(D)* has become popular:



W

a) **18 ♘b1** ♔h8 19 ♖fd1! (19 a3?! ♕d8! 20 ♘xf4? ef 21 ♗xe6 fe 22 ♖xc6 f3 23 g3 ♖xb3 –+ Ernst-Timoshchenko, Tbilisi 1988; 19 ♘bc3 f5 20 ♖fd1 ♖be8? 21 ♖d3 fe 22 ♘xe4 ♗f5 23 ♘df6! ♗xf6 {or 23...♗g6 24 ♕xg6 ♗xf6 25 ♖h3 +–} 24 ♕xf5 ♘d4 25 ♕h5 ♕d8 26 ♖h3 ♖e7 27 ♗d3 ± Marecek-Sturk, corr 1990) 19...♘d4 (both the planned 19...f5 20 ♘xf4! ef 21 ♗xe6 ♘d4 22 ♗xf5 ♘xf5 23 ♘d2!, and 19...♕xa2 20 ♘bc3 ♕b2 23 ♘a4 ♕a2 22 ♘dc3 ♕a3 23 ♘b1 with the idea of 24 ♗xe6 and 25 ♖xc6 are bad; a question suggests itself – why play 17...♕a5, since one cannot take the a2-pawn, and it moves the knight away more quickly from a3?) 20 ♘bc3 f5?! (20...f3!? is a standard blow with the knight on d4) 21 ♘e7! ♗xc4 22 ♘g6+ ♔g8 23 ♘e7+ ♔h8 24 bc ♖f6 25 ♘xf5 ♘xf5 26 ef ♖g8? 27 ♘e4 ♖h6 28 ♘xd6! 1-0 Vavarin-Cherniaev, Moscow 1992.

b) **18 ♘c2?!** ♕xa2!? 19 ♕d1 ♕a5 20 ♖a1 ♕c5 21 ♖xa6 ♔h8 22 ♘e1 ♘d4 23 ♘d3 (White plays too many knight moves) 23...♕c8 24 ♖xd6 f3! with a powerful attack for Black, Todorović-Timoshchenko, Pula 1988.

c) **18 ♗d3!?** ♘b4 (in the amusing Koch-Kasparov, Evry sim 1988, the World Champion continued 18...♘d4 19 ♘c2 ♘b5 20 ♘e7+

♔h8 21 ♘c6 ♕xa2 22 ♘2b4 ♕xb3 23 ♘xb8 ♖xb8 24 ♘xa6 ♕xd3 25 ♘xb8 and after 26...♘d4 he later confused his opponent and won, but had to give up too much material for the initiative) 19 ♘c4 ♕d8 (19...♕xa2 20 ♘xb4 ♖xb4 21 ♖a1 ♕xb3 22 ♖a3 ±) 20 ♘xb4 ♖xb4 21 ♖fd1 ♖b7 (the interesting brief skirmish after 21...a5!? 22 ♗e2 a4 23 ♘xd6 ab 24 ab ♗xb3 25 ♖d3 ♗e6 26 ♘xf7 ♗xf7 27 ♖xd8 ♗xh5 28 ♖xf8+ ♗xf8 29 ♗xh5 ♖xe4 led to a complete exhaustion of forces in Liss-Cesarsky, Tel Aviv 1991) 22 ♗e2 ♖d7 23 ♗g4 (23 g3!?) 23...f5 24 ♗f3 with a small advantage to White, C.Horvath-Nosko Koivisto, Haifa 1989.

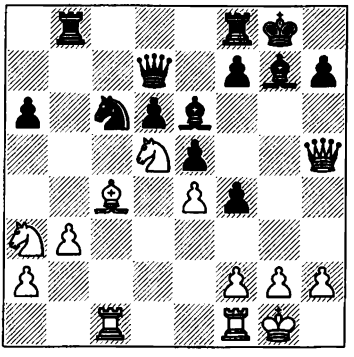
Therefore, following 17...♕a5, White has the better prospects after both 18 ♘b1 and 18 ♗d3!?.

It is characteristic for White, not paying any attention to the small loss on the queenside, to try to create threats against the king via the centre. The appearance on the kingside of perhaps one piece to aid the queen is often enough for an unstoppable attack – indeed the light squares in the black camp are not adequately defended.

We return to the main line after 17...♕d7 *(D)*:

18 ♕h4

In this position as well, several continuations have been tested:

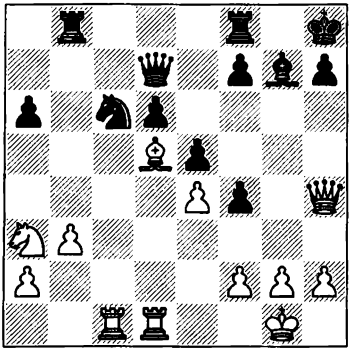


W

a) **18 ♕g5** ♗xd5!? (18...f6 has gone out of fashion) 19 ♗xd5 ♘b4 20 ♖fd1 ♘xa2 21 ♖c6 ♔h8 22 ♘c4 ♘c3 23 ♖xd6 ♕b5 24 ♖f1 ♕xb3 and now White must avoid **25 ♘e3?** ♕b1! 26 h3 (there is no time for 26 ♘f5?? because of the reply 26...♕xf1+! mating) 26...fe 27 ♖xb1 ♖xb1+ 28 ♔h2 ef 29 ♖d8 f1♕ 30 ♖xf8+ ♗xf8 31 ♕xe5+ 0-1 Koch-Podlesnik, Manila 1992. White did not fall into that trap in the game Prasad-Saveen, Calcutta 1994. However, after **25 ♘xe5** ♘xd5 (if 25...♕b1 now, then 26 g3) 26 ♖xd5 f6 27 ♘g6+ hg 28 ♕xg6 ♖b5 29 ♕h5+ ♔g8 he also achieved a lost position.

b) **18 ♖fd1** (a more popular continuation) **18...♔h8 19 ♕h4** (Black overlooked a typical tactical blow in this variation after 19 h3 ♘d4 20 ♘c2 ♘xc2 21 ♖xc2 f5 22 f3 ♖bc8?! 23 ♖dc1 ♕d8? 24 ♘xf4! ef 25 ♗xe6 ♖xc2 26 ♖xc2

♕a5 27 ♖e2 ♗d4+ 28 ♔h2 winning in Pereida-Charushin, corr Wch f 1989) **19...♗xd5** (19...f5!? 20 ♘xf4!? ef 21 ♗xe6 ♕xe6 22 ♖xc6 fe 23 ♖cxd6 ♕e8! 24 ♖d7 {24 ♘c4 is possible} 24...e3 25 ♕e7 ef+ 26 ♔xf2 ♕g6 with an active position for the pawn, Blank-Mrkvicka, corr 1990) **20 ♗xd5** *(D)*:



B

b1) **20...♘d4** 21 ♖c4! f5 22 ♘c2 ♖bc8 (22...fe) 23 ♘xd4 ed 24 ♕xf4 fe 25 ♖xc8 ♕xc8 26 ♕xe4, and Black could not solve his problems, Ernst-Bergström, 1989.

b2) **20...♘b4** 21 ♖d2 f5 22 ♘c4 (22 ♕h3 ♘xd5 23 ♖xd5 ♕b7 24 ♕f3 fe 25 ♕xe4 f3! ∓ Marković-Nurkić, Pula 1990) 22...♘xd5 23 ♖xd5 fe 24 ♖xd6 ♕f5 25 h3 h5 26 ♕e7 e3 28 fe fe 28 ♖d7 ♗f6 29 ♘xe3 ♕e4 30 ♕c5 ♗g5 31 ♘d5! ♕f5 32 ♘e7! ♕xd7 33 ♕xe5+ ♔h7 34 ♕xg5 with an attack, Renet-Korchnoi, Lugano op 1988.

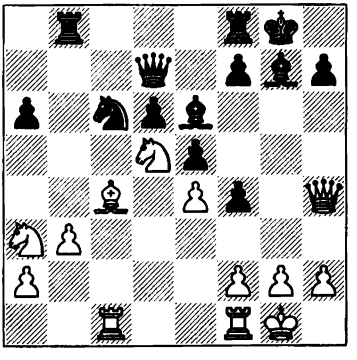
c) **18 ♗d3**:

c1) **18...♘b4!?** 19 ♘xb4 ♖xb4 20 ♕e2 f5 (20...d5!?) 21 ♘c4 fe 22 ♕xe4 ♗f5? (22...♗h6!? {with the idea of 23...f3} 23 ♕f3 with an unclear game) 23 ♕d5+ ♔h8 24 ♖fd1 f3!? 25 ♕xd6 ♕xd6 26 ♘xd6 ± Kovalev-Granik, USSR 1988.

c2) Insofar as 18 ♗d3 contradicts the idea of controlling d5 with pieces, it is probably worth inflicting a blow on it: **18...♔h8 19 ♖fd1 f5!?** (Black is already threatening to play 19...♗xd5) 19 ef ♗xd5 20 f6 ♗xf6 21 ♗f5 ♕g7 22 ♖d5 ♘e7 23 ♖c7 (23 ♖xd6? ♘xf5 24 ♕xf5 ♗e7) 23...♖g8! 24 g3 ♘xd5 25 ♖xg7 ♖xg7 ∓.

d) **18 ♖c3!?** ♗xd5 19 ♗xd5 ♘b4?! 20 ♖d1 ♘xa2?! 21 ♖h3 h6 22 ♘c4 ♔h7 23 g4! ± Rogalewicz-Rzepecki, corr 1993-4.

Now we return to the main line after 18 ♕h4 *(D)*:

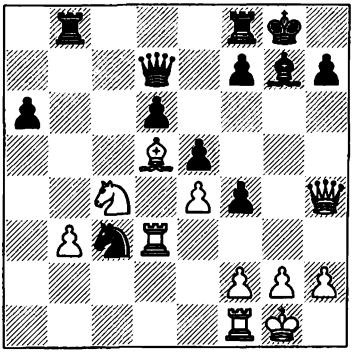


B

18 ... ♗xd5
19 ♗xd5 ♘b4
20 ♖cd1!?

If **20 ♖fd1**, then White should make one more rook move after 20...♘xa2. His best bet is to bring the knight into the battle on c4 straight away.

20 ... ♘xa2
21 ♘c4 ♘c3
22 ♖d3 *(D)*



B

Threatening 23 ♘xd6 when the knight is hanging, and furthermore 23...♘xd5 is no good due to 24 ♖xd5 ♖xb3 25 ♘xd6 with the idea of ♘d6-f5 (the game is reminiscent of Wolff-Bronstein), but Black has no alternative...

22 ... ♘e2+
23 ♔h1 ♘d4

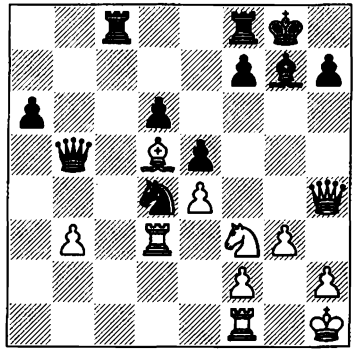
Thus the bishop on d5 remains the lord and master of the light squares. The livelier knight does not threaten it. One can establish that 20 ♖cd1 allows the variation to be determined in White's favour.

24 g3! f3

Forced, as otherwise the open g-file is deadly for Black.

25 ♘d2 ♖bc8
26 ♘xf3 ♕b5 *(D)*

After exchanging the enemy knight White clearly has the strategically won position for which he must strive in similar situations. Therefore Black decides to sacrifice the exchange.



W

27 ♗c4 ♖xc4
28 bc ♕xc4
29 ♖fd1 ♘xf3
30 ♖xf3

White has a won position, but now time trouble starts to interfere with the battle. But all the same, it is Black who will make the final blunder.

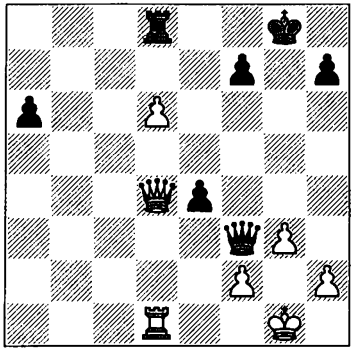
30 ... d5
31 ed?!

The cold-blooded 31 ♖e1 would have left Black no hope whatsoever.

31	**...**	**♕e2**
32	**♖fd3**	**e4**
33	**♖3d2**	**♕f3+**
34	**♔g1**	**♗c3**
35	**♕g5+**	**♔h8**
36	**d6**	**♗xd2**
37	**♕xd2**	

Black has won back the exchange, but his position remains difficult, indeed the d-pawn has held out.

37	**...**	**♖d8**
38	**♕d4+**	**♔g8** *(D)*



W

39 ♖c1?

Of course, White could win by 39 d7.

39	**...**	**♕d3**
40	**♕e5**	**♕d2?**

It is Black's turn to astonish. Why didn't he take the d6 pawn?

41 ♖c6!

The time scramble is over, and Timoshenko lets no more chances escape.

41	**...**	**♕d1+**
42	**♔g2**	**♕f3+**
43	**♔h3**	**h5**
44	**♖c3!**	**♕g4+**
45	**♔g2**	**♕g6**
46	**d7**	**1-0**

If we look at the statistics of this variation, then White has a big advantage. In this very game all the visible difficulties are for Black, who must seek new routes. Good luck to him!

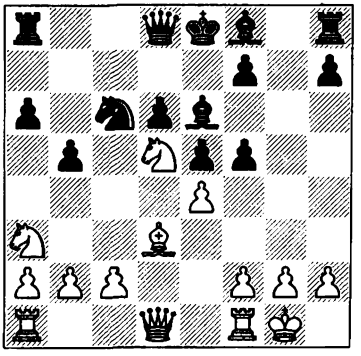
Another plan involves White beginning by castling short. One should note that in this game two Sveshnikov experts met.

Game 22
Dolmatov – Chekhov
Bundesliga 1992

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gf 10 ♘d5 f5 11 ♗d3 ♗e6

12	**0-0** *(D)*	
12	**...**	**♗xd5**
13	**ed**	**♘e7**
14	**c3**	

The active **14 c4** gives Black good counterchances, for example, **14...e4** 15 ♗e2 ♗g7 16 ♕d2 bc 17 ♘xc4 0-0 18 ♖ad1 ♖b8 19 ♕f4



B

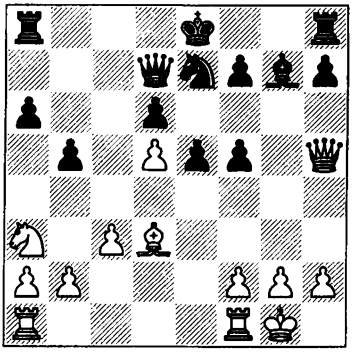
♖b5! with equality, Novik-Kramnik, Leningrad 1991, or possibly **14...♗g7** 15 cb e4 16 ♗c4 ♗xb2 17 ba ♗xa1?! (it's obviously not worth accepting the sacrifice; the quiet 17...0-0 is better) 18 ♕xa1, and Black fell foul to a dangerous attack in Brustman-Arakhamia, Debrecen wom Echt 1992.

The even more aggressive **14 ♘xb5** is also totally harmless for Black. After 14...♗g7 15 ♘c3 e4 16 ♗c4 Zsuzsa Polgar twice in the same tournament received a promising position as Black against prominent grandmasters: **16...♕a5** 17 ♘e2 ♖c8! 18 ♗b3 ♗xb2 19 ♖b1 ♗e5! Anand-Zsu.Polgar, Munich 1991; **16...♘g6!** 17 ♕h5 ♗xc3 18 bc ♕f6 19 f4 0-0 20 ♗b3 ♖fc8 ∓ Nunn-Zsu.Polgar, Munich 1991.

14 ... ♗g7

15 ♕h5 ♕d7 *(D)*

Chekhov's attempt to improve the variation. The otherwise used **15...e4** 16 ♗c2 0-0 (16...♕a5? 17 ♖ae1! ♖a7 18 ♔h1 ♗xc3 19 bc ♕xa3 20 ♗b3 ♕b2, Zso.Polgar-Kramnik, Guarapuava 1991, could have led to a large advantage for White after 21 ♕h6!) 17 ♖ae1 ♖c8?! 18 ♗b3! ♖c5 19 ♘c2 ♕d7 20 f3! a5 21 a3 ef 22 ♕xf3 ♗e5 23 g3! is clearly in White's favour because of the chronic weakness of Black's kingside, Kovalev-Palac, New Isenburg 1992.



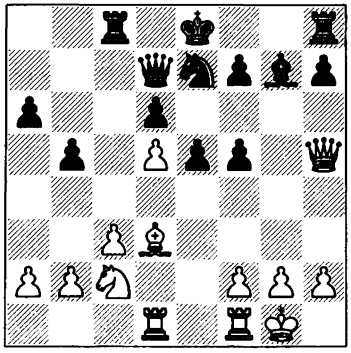
W

16 ♖ad1 ♖c8

In reply to **16...0-0** Dolmatov had planned to continue 17 ♗b1, intending ♘a3-c2-e3 and play on the light squares.

17 ♘c2 *(D)*

At the moment the plan shown in the previous note does not work: **17 ♗b1?!** ♖c5 18 ♘c2 ♘xd5!? 19 ♘e3 (or 19 b4 ♘f4 20 ♕g5 f6 ∓) 19...♘xe3 20 fe e4 ∓. Therefore 16...♖c8 was very timely.



B

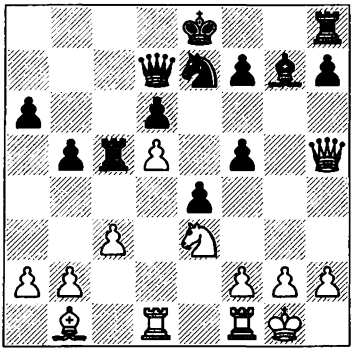
17 ♖c5

17...e4 would have been rash: 18 ♗e2 0-0 19 f3 ±, and White breaks up his opponent's pawn centre.

18 ♘e3 e4

Of course not **18...f4?** 19 ♘f5, when White dominates the light squares.

19 ♗b1 *(D)*



B

19 ... 0-0

Again Chekhov could not show any activity with **19...f4**, when the following development of events would have been possible: 20 ♘g4 ♕f5 (20...0-0 21 ♘h6+ ♗xh6 22 ♕xh6 ±) 21 ♕xf5 ♘xf5 22 f3! (if 22 ♗xe4, then 22...♘e7!, and it unexpectedly becomes clear that there is no defence from 23...f5 or 23...h5, and one of the white pieces perishes) 22...♘e3 (22...h5 23 ♘f2!? ♘e3 24 ♘xe4 ♖c7 25 ♘xd6+ ♔f8 26 ♘f5 ♘xd1 27 ♖xd1 ±) 23 ♘xe3 fe 24 ♖fe1 ♗h6 25 ♗xe4, and after g2-g3 and f3-f4 White's large advantage is not in doubt.

20 g3!

White's fundamental idea is to play f2-f3 in order to destroy Black's pawn centre. However, this does not work immediately: **20 f3** f4 21 ♗xe4 f5 ∓.

20 b4?!

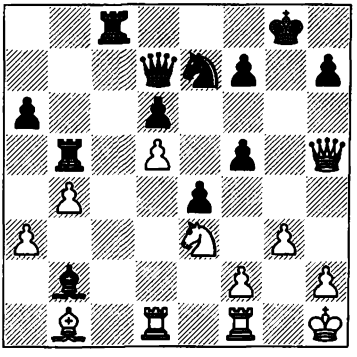
A quite natural attempt by Black to organize a counterattack on the queenside, but his forces are too far withdrawn from his king. However, Chekhov was facing a difficult problem. After **20...♖b8** White could have replied 21 ♖d2!?, so that after 21...b4 22 c4, the b2-pawn would be defended.

21 cb ♖b5
22 a3 ♗xb2
23 ♔h1!

Dolmatov quite justifiably suggests that it is better to carry out the advance f2-f3 when everything else has been covered. If **23 f3?!**,

then 23...♕a7 gives rise to complications.

23 ♖c8 *(D)*



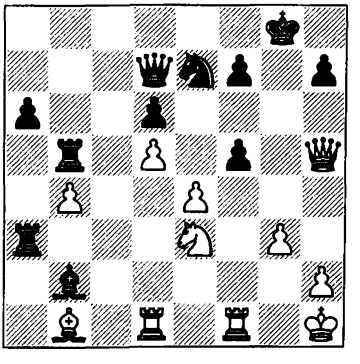
W

24 f3!

White has finished his preparations and has finally carried out the 'programmed' continuation.

24 ... ♖c3
25 fe ♖xa3 *(D)*

The knight is indirectly defended: **25...♖xe3** 26 ♕g5+.

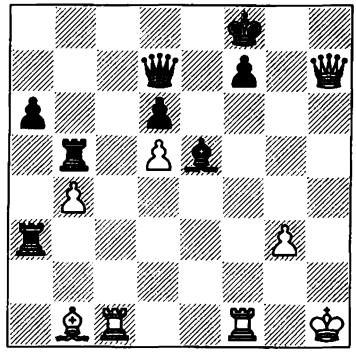


W

26 ♘xf5 ♘xf5
27 e5!

A beautiful refusal to take the black knight. In the event of **27 ♖xf5** Black would have continued 27...f6, and after ...♗b2-e5 could have strengthened his own position.

27 ... ♘xg3+
28 hg ♗xe5
29 ♕xh7+ ♔f8
30 ♖c1! *(D)*



B

Now all White's pieces are already taking part in the attack. 31 ♖c8+ and 31 ♖xf7+ are major threats. This continuation is significantly stronger than winning the queen for bishop and rook after **30 ♗g6** ♖b7 31 ♖xf7+ ♕xf7 32 ♗xf7 ♖xf7, when Black is still holding on.

30 ... ♖b7
31 ♗f5 ♕b5
32 ♗e6 **1-0**

Conclusion

In this chapter we have examined games from one of the most aggressive variations of the Sveshnikov. If White plays 12 ♕h5, a very sharp game arises, giving rise to reasonable counterchances for Black.

However, the plan linked with 12...♖g8 seems more promising. After 12...f4 and 13...♗g7 he often falls into a difficult position. The game goes on in a more positional mood after 12 0-0 with a small advantage (as, strictly speaking, is predetermined) to White.

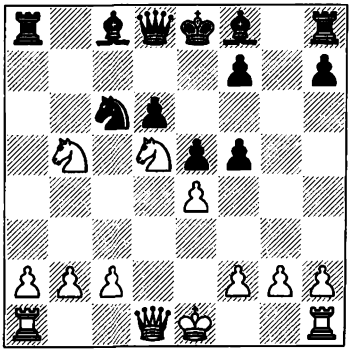
9 Classical Sveshnikov: 11 ♗xb5

Nowadays it is quite rare to see White sacrificing a piece on b5 on move 11. Moreover, if the knight sacrifice has gone completely out of use, then taking with the bishop is wrong, as this scene shows...

Game 23
Vitolinš – Cherniaev
Kherson 1990

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘ba3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gf 10 ♘d5 f5

11 ♗xb5 ab
12 ♘xb5 *(D)*

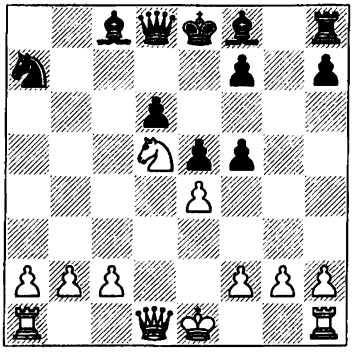


B

The diagram position has never been particularly popular, and is rarely seen in contemporary tournament practice. Black opposes White's attack, led by his queen and two knights, with harmonious counterplay by all his pieces. In spite of the irrational character of the struggle, fewer patches of white remain in this variation.

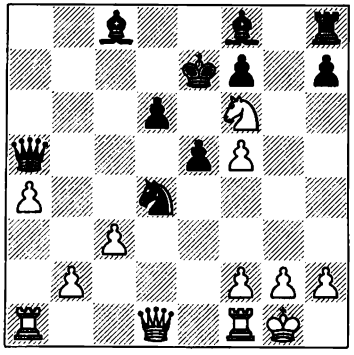
12 ♖a4!

The very strongest continuation – Govelov's idea. The black rook not only comes out from behind the lines, but also takes an active part in the battle. There is a less successful attempt to pay White off with the exchange, **12...♖a7**. After **13 ♘xa7 ♘xa7** *(D)* White has two promising possibilities at his disposal:



W

a) **14 ef! ♘b5!? 15 a4** (a novelty) **15...♘d4** (if 15...♘c7 then one may continue 16 a5 ♗b7 17 c4 ♘xd5 18 a6!? ♗a8 19 cd, and the white passed pawn is very dangerous) **16 c3 ♕a5 17 ♘f6+ ♔e7 18 0-0** *(D)* and now:



B

a1) **18...♘xf5?** 19 b4 ♕d8 20 ♘d5+ ♔e6 21 a5 ♗b7 22 c4 winning for White, M.Pavlović-Todorović, Yugoslavia 1992.

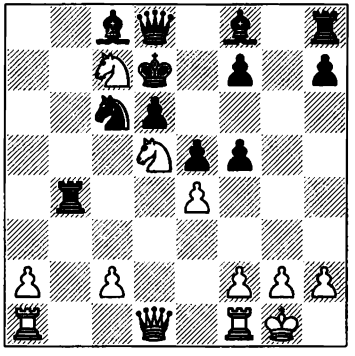
a2) **18...♔xf6** 19 cd ♗xf5 is better, although here too White's chances are somewhat preferable because of the hopeless position of the black king, and also thanks to his advantage in development and passed pawns.

b) **14 c3** ♘b5 15 ef (15 a4 ♘c7 16 a5! ± seems more promising) 15...♘c7 16 ♘e3 ♗b7! 17 ♕a4+?! (it would have been better to continue 17 ♕b3! ♕a8 18 0-0-0 ♗xg2 19 ♘xg2 ♕xg2 20 ♔b1 with some initiative to White) 17...♕d7 18 ♕b3 ♘a6 19 ♘d5 ♘c5 20 ♘f6+ ♔e7 21 ♘d5+, and in this position, having repeated moves twice, Shirov, against Mitkov, France 1994, decided to take the white knight, which, however, did not change the assessment of the position as level.

13 b4

Vitolinš had already used this continuation without any particular success in a game against Kishnev, Jurmala 1981.

13	**...**	**♖xb4**
14	**♘bc7+**	**♔d7**
15	**0-0** *(D)*	



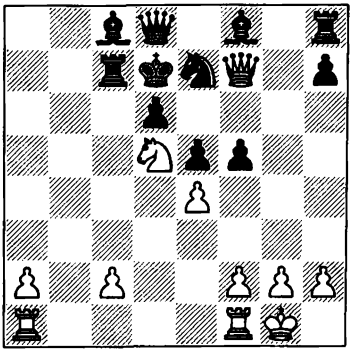
B

Black here has various possibilities. **15...♖g8** featured in the aforementioned game Vitolinš-Kishnev, Jurmala 1981, when after **16 ♘xb4** ♘xb4 17 ♘d5 ♘xd5 18 ♕xd5 ♔e7, Black realized his advantage. Obviously, the authors of the idea have found an improvement for

White. It hasn't been ruled out that it is linked with the continuation **16 ♕h5**, which practically forces Black to give the queen back, for example, 16...♘e7 17 ♕xf7 ♕xc7 18 ♘xc7 ♔xc7, and a hugely complicated position arises, which fully corresponds with Vitolinš's creative outlook. But Cherniaev returns to a well-trodden path.

15...♖xe4 deserves attention.

Another alternative is **15...♖b7** 16 ♕h5 ♖xc7 17 ♕xf7+ (White could announce a perpetual check by 17 ♕f5+ ♔e8 18 ♘f6+ ♔e7 19 ♘d5+) 17...♘e7 *(D)*:



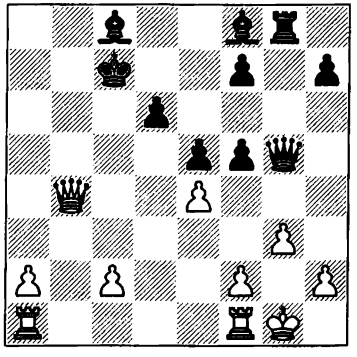
W

...and now rather than **18 ♘f6+** ♔c6 19 ♖ab1 (definitely threatening mate – 20 ♕c4#) 19...d5! 20 c4 d4! 21 c5 ♖b7 22 ♘e8! ♖g8! 23 ♕c4 ♕a5 24 ♖b6+ ♖xb6 25 cb+ ♔xb6 26 ♖b1+ ♔a7 when Black repulsed the attack, preserving a decisive material advantage in the game Meister-Kharlov, USSR 1990, White should play **18 ♘b6+** ♔c6 19 ♖ab1 d5 20 ♕f6+ (20 c4!? also deserves attention) 20...♕d6 21 ♕xh8 ♘g6 22 ♕g8 ♖g7 23 ♕xd5+, after which a complex endgame arises.

15 ♕g5!

This move fulfils several aims at once. It allows an attack to begin, thins out the area around the king, and hinders an active thrust by the white queen onto h5. Besides, this continuation allows Black to avoid the forced draw that can ensue after **15...♖b7**.

16 ♘xb4 ♘xb4
17 ♕b1 ♖g8
18 g3 ♔xc7
19 ♕xb4 *(D)*



B

An extraordinarily sharp and tense situation has arisen. Black has two bishops for a rook and pawn, plus a possible future attack on the

king. White's hopes are also linked with a direct attack on the enemy king and a strong passed a-pawn. Such a clash of plans promises a very interesting struggle.

19 ... ♔d7

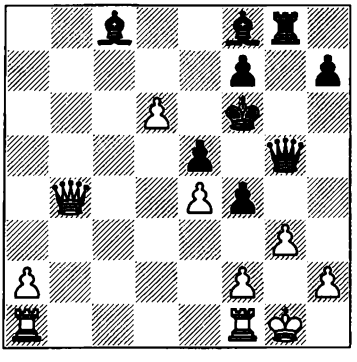
First Cherniaev wishes to put his own king into safety. It's quite reliable, but probably not the strongest plan. The sharp **19...fe** would have opened up wide possibilities, not only for the black light-squared bishop, but also for its colleagues.

20 c4 f4
21 c5

Vitolinš is trying to destroy the king's pawn shield. Naturally, Black cannot take on c5 because of 22 ♖fd1+.

21 ... ♔e6
22 cd ♔f6 *(D)*

A very comfortable refuge for Black's king.



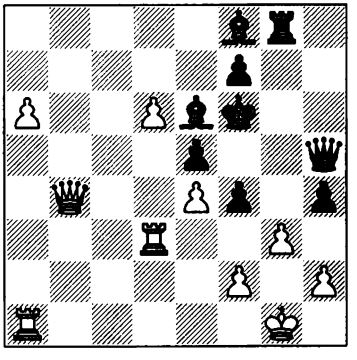
W

23 ♖fd1?

Losing a tempo, which in this situation turns out to be fatal. He should have quickly set the a-pawn off on its way.

23 ... ♗e6
24 a4 h5
25 a5 h4
26 ♖d3 ♕h5
27 a6 *(D)*

Both contestants are playing on 'their' flank, but all the same their forces will come into contact, and it will become clear that Black has manoeuvred more successfully.



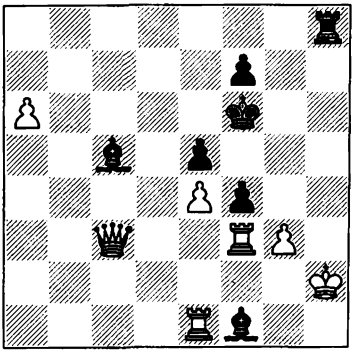
B

27 ... hg
28 fg ♕e2
29 ♕c3 ♗xd6

The bishop enters the game with great effect. 30 ♖xd6 is impossible because of 30...f3 with an inevitable mate (31 ♖d2 f2+).

30 ♖e1 ♗c5+
31 ♔h1 ♕f2
32 ♖f3 ♗d4

Now Cherniaev, who was in time trouble, misses a chance to end the game straight away by 32...♕xh2+ 33 ♔xh2 ♖h8+ 34 ♔g2 ♗h3+ 35 ♔h2 ♗f1# *(D)*.



W

33 ♖xf2 ♗xc3

Now Black must again prove his superiority.

34 ♖b1 ♗d4
35 ♖f3 ♗g4
36 ♖a3 ♖a8
37 gf ef
38 ♖f1 ♔e5

Black has reliably blocked the a-pawn from moving, and now turns to decisive action.

39 ♖a5+ ♔xe4
40 ♖a4 ♗e2
41 ♖xd4+

An attempt to turn the game into a theoretically drawn ending leads to a swift denouement.

41 ... ♔xd4
42 ♖xf4+ ♔e3
43 ♖xf7 ♗f3+
44 ♔g1 ♖g8+
45 ♔f1 ♗e2+

0-1

Conclusion

12...♖a4 seems to be the best antidote to the bishop sacrifice on b5. The continuation 12...♖a7 creates fewer pre-requisites for Black to seize the initiative, although both lead to an extremely sharp battle which demands exact knowledge as well as iron nerves and a clear sense of the fantastic.

10 Classical Sveshnikov: 9 ♘ab1

Strictly speaking, play in this variation begins only on move 11, because White most frequently plays it with a transposition of moves: 9 ♘d5 ♗e7 10 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 11 ♘b1. However, it's also possible for a straightforward move order, which begins with 9 ♘ab1. We think the virtues and drawbacks of the variation will soon become clear to the reader. White makes too many moves with one knight, and lags behind somewhat in development, but if Black cannot use this circumstance energetically, White will develop his pieces in comfort.

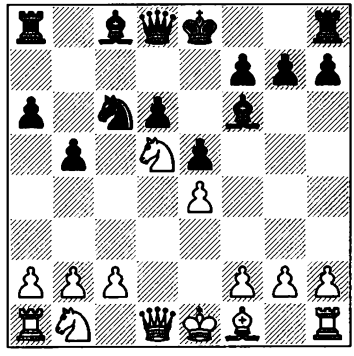
Game 24
Čabrilo – Beliavsky
Lvov 1993

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5

9	**♘d5**	**♗e7**
10	**♗xf6**	**♗xf6**
11	**♘b1** *(D)*	

With a transposition of moves, a position has arisen which is characteristic of the variation with 9 ♘ab1.

11 ... 0-0



B

The move **11...♖b8** (with the idea of preventing 12 a4) has been tested:

a) Hoffman-Yakovich, Munich 1992 continued **12 g3** 0-0 13 ♗g2 ♗e6 14 0-0 ♗xd5 15 ed ♘a5 16 ♘d2 ♘c4 17 ♘xc4 bc 18 b3 ♕c7 19 ♖e1 ♕a7 20 ♖e4 ♖fc8 21 ♗f1 c3 22 ♕d3 h5 ∓.

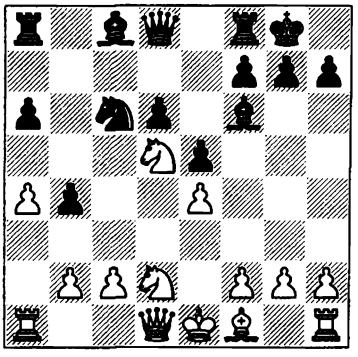
b) Stefansson-Schandorff, Copenhagen 1994, developed differently: **12 ♘d2** ♗g5 13 ♗d3 ♘e7 14 ♘xe7 ♕xe7 15 0-0 0-0 16 ♕e2 g6 17 a4 ba 18 ♖fb1 ♗d7 19 ♗xa6 f5 20 ♗c4+ ♔h8 21 ♗d5 ♖fc8 22 ♕d3 ♖b4 ∓.

12 a4!

White does not delay in beginning to worry his opponent on the queenside.

12 ... ♖b8

Another plan has been tried: **12...b4**, for example, **13 ♘d2** *(D)* and now:



B

a) **13...♗e6** 14 ♗c4 ♗g5 15 ♘f3! ♗h6 16 ♕d3! a5 17 0-0 ♔h8 18 ♖ad1 ♖b8 19 ♗b5 ♘a7 20 c4 bc 21 bc f5 22 c4 fe 23 ♕xe4 ♗f5 24 ♕e2 ± Minasian-Chandler, Manila OL 1992.

b) **13...♗g5** was an interesting attempt to improve on this in Koshi-Barua, Isfahan 1993. Now fascinating complications would have arisen after 14 ♘c4!?, for example 14...♖b8 15 a5 ♖b5! 16 ♘db6 (16 ♘cb6?! ♖c5! ∓) 16...♗e6 17 ♘xd6 (17 ♕xd6?! ♘d4 18 ♗d3 b3 19 cb ♖xb3 20 ♕xd8 ♖xd8 21 ♗b1 ♖b4! ∓; White must fight just for equality) 17...♖xa5 18 ♖xa5 ♘xa5 19 ♘d5 ♘c6 with good counterplay for Black.

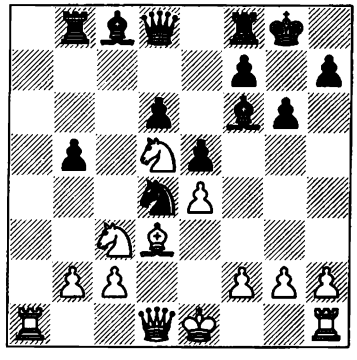
13 ab ab

14 ♘bc3 ♘d4

It's not worth pressurizing the white knight, as it could occupy an active position on b5. After **14...b4** 15 ♘b5 ♘d4 16 ♘xd4 ed 17 ♗c4 White has managed to finish his development and his pieces are very well placed.

15 ♗d3 g6 *(D)*

Here **15...b4** deserved attention, for example, 16 ♘e2 ♗g4 17 c3 bc 18 bc ♘xe2 19 ♗xe2 ♗e6 with equality.



W

16 0-0 ♗g7

17 ♘a2!

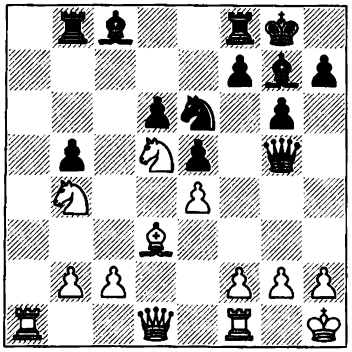
Čabrilo prepares to evict the black knight from d4, and at the same time move his own to the excellent square b4.

17 ... ♕g5

18 ♔h1

It was worth thinking about **18 f3!?**, preparing against Black's attack before it happens.

18 ... ♘e6
19 ♘ab4 *(D)*



B

19 ... ♘f4!

After **19...f5** 20 f3 ♘c5 21 ♕e2 White is clearly better.

20 ♘xf4 ef
21 c3 ♗e6
22 ♖a5 ♖fc8
23 ♕e2 ♖c5!

One of the moves which is often seen in the Sveshnikov, transferring the rook to the fifth rank to attack the king.

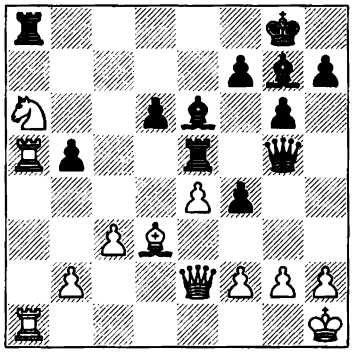
24 ♘a6

White had a more reliable plan: **24 f3** and if 24...♕h6?!, then the reply 25 ♕f2 ♖h5 26 ♕g1! winning for White.

24 ... ♖a8
25 ♖fa1

25 ♘xc5 ♖xa5 26 ♘xe6 fe 27 f3 was also possible, with a small advantage to White.

25 ... ♖e5 *(D)*



W

26 ♘c7?

Čabrilo misses a tactical blow. The continuation **26 f3** would have still allowed him to preserve a minimal advantage. Now the picture of the battle changes sharply in Black's favour.

26 ... ♖xa5
27 ♖xa5 f3!

White can take the pawn neither with the queen, due to the back rank mate, nor with the pawn in view of ...♗e6-h3. An intervening check changes nothing.

28 ♖a8+ ♗f8
29 ♕f1 fg+

Beliavsky energetically carries out the conclusive attack.

30 ♕xg2 ♕d2
31 ♕g3 ♕d1+
32 ♔g2 ♗g4
33 ♘e8 ♗f3+

The finale. If 34 ♕xf3 then 34...♖g5+.

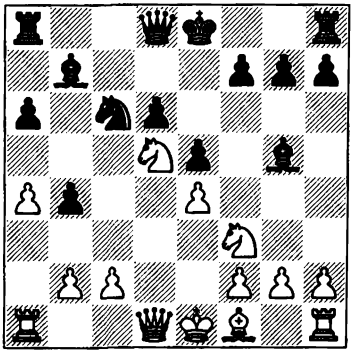
0-1

Black used an interesting novelty in the following duel, namely 11...♗b7.

Game 25
Shaked – Cherniaev
New York 1993

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♘d5 ♗e7 10 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 11 ♘b1

11	**...**	**♗b7!?**
12	**a4**	**b4**
13	**♘d2**	**♗g5**
14	**♘f3** *(D)*	



B

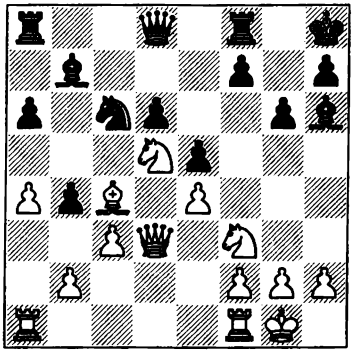
White's knight has spent seven moves to get to its 'rightful' place. This alone testifies to the fact that Black has already achieved at least a level game. However, he must act energetically, otherwise the permanent weaknesses in his position might make their presence felt.

14	**...**	**♗h6**
15	**♗c4**	**0-0**
16	**0-0**	

An attempt to pressurize the d6-pawn with **16 ♕d3 ♔h8 17 ♖d1** is parried by means of 17...♕a5!? 18 0-0 ♖ad8 with a complex game.

16	**...**	**♔h8**
17	**♕d3**	**g6**
18	**c3** *(D)*	

If **18 ♘e3** then Cherniaev was going to play 18...♘e7 19 ♖fd1 ♗xe3!? 20 ♕xe3 ♕c7 21 ♗b3 f6! 22 ♖d3 a5 23 ♖ad1 ♖ad8 24 h4 ♘c8 with the idea of organizing counterplay after ...♘c8-b6. However, **18 ♖fd1** deserves attention.



B

18 bc

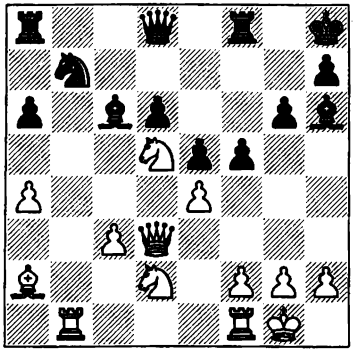
This move was not forced. He could have followed his plan more consistently with **18...f5**. After this it would be a mistake to take on b4: 19 cb fe 20 ♕xe4 ♘xb4 21 ♖fd1 ♖f4 22 ♕e2 ♖xc4 23 ♕xc4 ♘xd5

24 ♖xd5 ♕g8 25 ♖ad1 ♖c8, and White will perish because of the weakness of his back rank.

19	**bc**	**f5**
20	**♖ab1**	

Shaked is trying to organize some counterplay on the b-file, but his opponent elegantly redistributes his pieces.

20	**...**	**♘a5**
21	**♗a2**	**♗c6**
22	**♘d2**	**♘b7** *(D)*



W

Black's pieces are very harmoniously placed and are ready to play over the whole board. White's position is difficult, so he makes a despairing attempt to get stuck into complications.

23	**f4**	**ef**
24	**♘xf4**	**♘c5**
25	**♕h3**	**♗xf4**
26	**♖xf4**	**♘xe4??**

A fatal error in time trouble, leading to a rapid loss. The cold-blooded **26...♕g5** 27 ♖h4 ♖a7 would have led to a Black win.

27	**♘xe4**	**♗xe4**

Black cannot be saved by **27...fe** 28 ♖xf8+ ♕xf8 29 ♖f1 with a decisive attack.

28	**♖xe4!**	**fe**
29	**♖b7**	**h5**
30	**♕e3**	**g5**
31	**♕xe4**	**1-0**

Conclusion

This variation does not present any real danger for Black. Furthermore, the continuations 11...♖b8 and 11...♗b7 allow him to count on seizing the initiative.

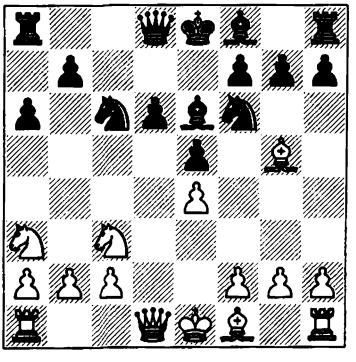
11 Bird-Larsen Variation: 8...♗e6

This variation doesn't as a rule lead to such complex situations as the Classical. Therefore, in order to play it, one needs to know far fewer forced variations. But learning them, as is well known, is not to everybody's taste.

Game 26
Ki.Georgiev– Shirov
Biel 1992

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3

8 ... ♗e6 *(D)*



W

The idea of this move is rapid development and control over d5. The serious disadvantage of the move is that White can swiftly bring the a3 knight into the battle.

9 ♘c4

Georgiev quickly uses the opportunities he is afforded – indeed Black should also think about doing this!

9 ... ♖c8!

'Not only a mobilizing but also a waiting move; when White removes the knight from c4, ...♗f8-e7 and ...0-0 will become possible' – Sveshnikov.

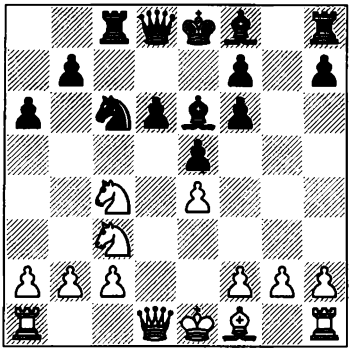
10 ♗xf6

10 ♘e3 does not win White any laurels. After 10...♗e7 11 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 12 ♘cd5 ♗g5 13 c3 (or 13 ♗d3 0-0 14 0-0 g6 15 c3 ♔h8 16 a4 f5 = Mellado-Yakovich, Cordoba 1991) 13...0-0 14 ♗e2 g6 15 0-0 ♔h8 16 ♔h1 f5 17 ef gf 18 f4 ♗h6 19 ♗d3 e4 20 ♗c2 ♕h4 Black equalized in Xie Jun-Kharlov, Moscow 1992.

10 ... gf *(D)*

Or **10...♕xf6** 11 ♘b6 ♖b8 12 ♘cd5 ♕d8 and now **13 c3** ♗e7 14 ♗c4 0-0 15 a4 (Grünfeld-Cifuentes, Novi Sad 1990, continued 15 0-0 ♗g5 16 a4 ♔h8 17 ♔h1 g6 18 ♕e2 ♗h6 19 ♖ad1 f5 with fair counterplay for Black) 15...♗g5

16 ♕e2 g6 17 0-0 is only marginally better for White, Bologan-Cifuentes, Las Palmas 1993, or **13 ♗e2** g6 14 0-0 ♗h6 15 c3 0-0 16 a4 ♔h8 17 ♕d3 f5 with fair counterchances for Black, Reinderman-Cifuentes, Wijk aan Zee 1994.



W

11 ♘e3

The continuation **11 ♗d3** (with the idea of avoiding the immediate attack on the knight which occurs after 11 ♘e3 ♗h6) was seen in the game Anand-Morović, Las Palmas 1993: 11...♘e7 12 ♘e3 ♗h6 13 0-0 ♗xe3 14 fe ♕b6 15 ♕c1 ♘g8 16 ♔h1 ♕c5 (16...h5 is interesting, and if 17 ♘d5, then 17...♗xd5 18 ed ♘e7 19 e4 f5!, destroying the white pawn centre) 17 ♕d2 h5 18 ♖ad1 h4 19 h3 ♔f8 20 ♕e2 ±.

11 ... ♗h6

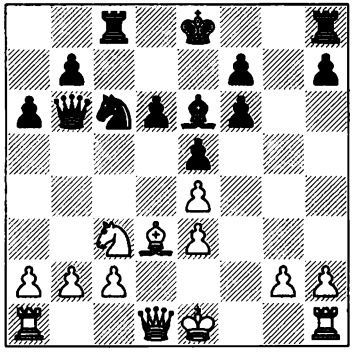
12 ♗d3

Not hindering Black's standard idea of giving up one of his bishops for White's strong knight. And although he will get doubled pawns, the pressure on the vital f-file is still a factor of greater importance.

12 ... ♗xe3

13 fe ♕b6 *(D)*

After **13...♖g8** 14 0-0 ♕b6 15 ♕f3 ♘e7 16 ♘d5 ♗xd5 17 ed f5 18 ♗xf5 ♘xf5 19 ♕xf5 ♕xe3+ 20 ♔h1 ♖c7 Black managed to hold the position in Konguvel-Bhattacharia, Calcutta 1994.



W

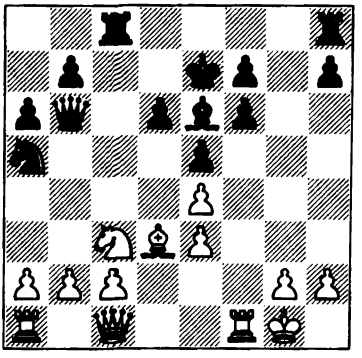
14 ♕c1

A strong and natural move, although a pawn sacrifice was also possible: **14 0-0** ♕xe3+ 15 ♔h1 with a sharp game.

14 ... ♘a5

After **14...♘b4** White could have continued 15 a3 ♘xd3+ 16 cd d5 17 ed ♗xd5 18 0-0, for example, 18...♗b3 19 ♕d2 ♖g8 20 d4 ♖d8 21 d5 with a noticeable advantage.

15 0-0 ♔e7 *(D)*



W

16 ♕e1!

A move which pursues two aims at once: moving the queen over to the kingside, where Black has few defenders, and also threatening to continue 17 b3, after which the a5-knight's prospects are altogether miserable.

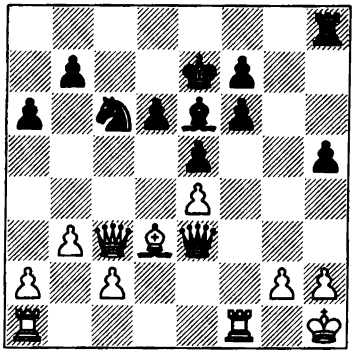
16 ... h5

Shirov has not decided on an active continuation, but if **16...♕xb2**, then White after 17 ♘d5+ ♗xd5 18 ed e4 19 ♗xe4 would have been given a tangible advantage.

Thus **16...♘c4** deserves attention, for example, **17 ♗xc4** ♖xc4 18 ♕f2 ♖g8 19 ♘d5+ ♗xd5 20 ♕xf6+ ♔d7 21 ed ♕xe3+ 22 ♔h1 ♖f4 23 ♖xf4 ♕xf4 24 ♕xf4 ef 25 ♖f1 ♖e8 26 ♔g1 ♖e4, and Black holds on. However, **17 ♘d1** h5 (17...♘xb2 18 ♘xb2! ♕xb2 19 ♖b1 ♕xa2 20 ♖xb7+ ♗d7 21 ♕h4 ♕e6 22 ♖xf6!) **18 b3** ♘a3! 19 c4 ♕c5 20 ♘c3 b5 21 ♘d5+! would have preserved the better chances for Georgiev. It is possible that instead of 18 b3, the move **18 a4** is even stronger, and again the black knight starts to become uncomfortable.

17 b3! ♕c5?

A decisive error. It would have been worth complicating White's problems with an exchange sacrifice: **17...♖xc3 18 ♕xc3 ♕xe3+ 19 ♔h1 ♘c6** *(D)*, although here as well White faces a happy choice:



W

a) **20 ♖f3** ♕c5 (20...♕g5 21 ♗xa6!; 20...♕b6? 21 ♖af1 ♖h6 22 ♕d2 ♖g6 23 ♖xf6!; 20...♕d4 21 ♕e1 h4 22 c3) 21 ♕xc5 dc 22 ♖af1 ♖h6 23 ♖g3, and his chances are clearly better.

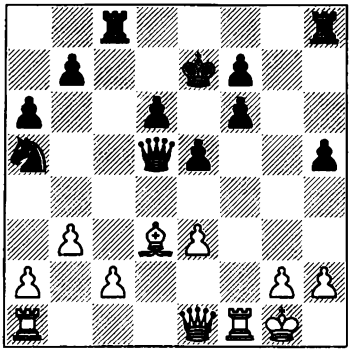
b) **20 ♖ae1** ♕c5 21 ♕d2 ♘b8! 22 ♖f3 ♘d7 23 ♖ef1 with a small advantage.

Now Black loses by force.

18 ♘d5+!

Georgiev is still not satisfied by a quiet continuation: **18 ♘a4 ♕c7** 19 c4, although it would also have offered wonderful prospects.

18 ... ♗xd5
19 ed ♕xd5 *(D)*



W

20 b4 was threatened, and if **19...♕c3**, White could have continued 20 ♕h4 ♖h6 21 ♖ad1 ♖g8 22 h3, after which he doubles rooks on the f-file, gaining a decisive advantage.

20 ♖d1! ♖cg8

Not **20...e4?** 21 ♗c4, and after any departure by the queen from the fifth rank, 21 ♖d5 wins the knight. If **20...♘c6**, then 21 ♕h4 ♖h6 22 ♗f5 is decisive.

21 ♕f2 ♖h6

Other moves cannot save him:

a) **21...♕e6** 22 ♗f5, and Black's queen is trapped.

b) **21...♔f8** 22 ♗c4 ♕e4 23 ♖xd6.

22 ♗g6! 1-0

A beautiful final blow! After 22...♕xd1 White can insert the lethal check 23 ♕xf6+.

Game 27
Smagin – Kharlov
Moscow 1991

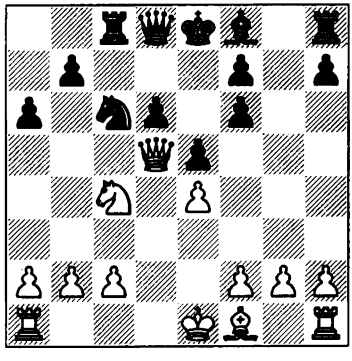
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 ♗e6 9 ♘c4 ♖c8

10 ♗xf6

If White wishes to continue on the next move with 11 ♘d5, then it is more exact to do so immediately: **10 ♘d5** ♗xd5 11 ♗xf6 gf 12 ♕xd5.

10 ... gf
11 ♘d5 ♗xd5
12 ♕xd5 *(D)*

12 ed?! ♘e7 gives White no advantage.



B

12 ... b5

After **12...♘d4** 13 ♗d3 ♕e7 14 b4 ♕c6! 15 ♘e3 ♕xd5 16 ♘xd5 ♘xc2+ 17 ♗xc2 ♖xc2 18 0-0 ♗h6, **19 a4** ♔d7 20 ♖a3 ♔e6 21 ♖f3 ♗g5 would have led to a small advantage for Black in Belikov-Kharlov, Moscow 1992, but after **19 ♖fd1** ♔d7 20 ♖d3 ♔e6 21 ♖f3 ♗g7 22 ♖g3 ♖hc8 23 ♖f1 ♗h6 in Leko-Morović, Lyon 1993, a level position arose.

13 ♘e3 ♗h6

Here too **13...♘e7** deserves attention.

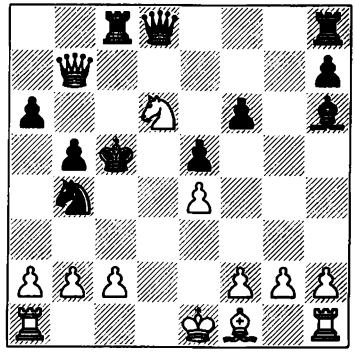
14 ♘f5! ♘b4
15 ♘xd6+ ♔d7
16 ♕xf7+

16 ♗xb5+ ab 17 ♕xb5+ was also possible, with an unclear game. But Smagin had something else in mind...

16 ... ♔c6
17 ♕b7+ ♔c5 *(D)*

If **17...♔xd6**, then 18 ♖d1+ ♔e6 19 ♖xd8 ♘xc2+ 20 ♔e2 ♖hxd8 21 f4 and 22 ♔f3 with a big advantage to White.

According to the evidence of eyewitnesses, Kharlov assessed this position as fully acceptable for Black. He was not afraid of the perpetual check, as after **18 ♕a7+** ♔c6 19 ♗xb5+ ab 20 ♕b7+ ♔xd6 21 ♖d1+ ♔e6 22 ♖xd8 ♘xc2+ 23 ♔e2 ♖hxd8 24 ♖d1 ♘d4+ Black repulses his opponent's attack. But a nasty surprise awaited him.



W

18 ♖d1!

A novelty, which underlines the shady side of early activity by the king.

18 ♘xc2+

Black has nothing else. **18...♖c7** is no good due to 19 c3! ♘c2+ (19...♖xc7 loses to 20 ♘xb7+ followed by 21 ♘xd8) 20 ♔e2, and after 20...♕xd6? White executes a beautiful mate with the king: 21 ♖d5+ ♔c4 22 ♔f3 – mate!

19 ♔e2 ♘d4+
20 ♖xd4 ed
21 ♕d5+ ♔b6
22 ♘xc8+ ♕xc8
23 ♕xd4+

Smagin has two extra pawns, and he steers the game precisely to victory.

23 ... ♔a5
24 ♔f3 f5
25 g3 ♖d8
26 b4+ ♔a4
27 ♕b6 fe+

28 ♔g2 ♔xb4

Otherwise Black is mated, but this loses the bishop. He could have taken his final bow by now.

29 ♕xh6 ♕c3
30 ♗e2 ♖d2
31 ♖b1+ ♔a5
32 ♖b3 ♕c2
33 ♖a3+ ♔b4
34 ♕xa6 ♖xe2
35 ♖b3+ ♔c5
36 ♖xb5+ 1-0

Conclusion

Although the Bird-Larsen Variation is not considered defective, all the same Black quite often runs into difficulties in practice.

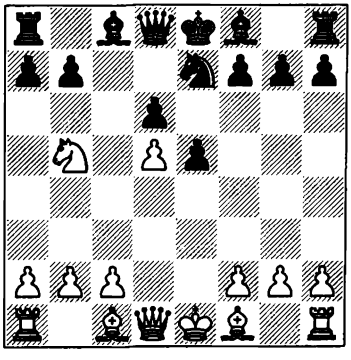
12 7 ♘d5

In this variation White avoids the sharpest of continuations in favour of a clearer strategic route. However this does not by any means signify avoiding a battle. You will see the kind of storms that can rage in this 'quiet' variation by looking at the following entertaining encounter.

Game 28
Yudasin – Kramnik
Wijk aan Zee Ct (1) 1994

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6

7	**♘d5**	**♘xd5**
8	**ed**	**♘e7** *(D)*



W

9 a4

9 c3 is more exact, since after **9...a6?** White can reply 10 ♕a4. If **9...♘g6**, then 10 ♕a4 ♗d7 11 ♕c4 ♗xb5 (11...♖c8 is answered by 12 ♕b4!) 12 ♕xb5+ ♕d7 13 a4! a6 14 ♕xd7+ ♔xd7, and by bypassing the complex variations which are characteristic of the Sveshnikov, White gains a better ending (he has the bishop pair and a queenside pawn majority). **9...♘f5** keeps d6 defended, and after 10 a4 a position arises from the game we are investigating.

By using this move order, White practically forces the knight to occupy f5, where it is not very comfortably placed, as it hinders the advance ...f7-f5. Therefore the knight continues to follow the route f5-h4-g6, but this loses time.

White may also try **9 c4**, for example, 9...♘f5 10 ♗d3 ♗e7 11 0-0 0-0 12 ♔h1 a6 13 ♘c3 ♘h4 14 f4 f5 15 ♕c2! e4 16 ♗e2 g5 17 fg?! (17 g3!) 17...♗xg5 18 b4 ♗f6 19 ♗h6 ♖f7 20 ♖ad1 ♘g6 = Mainka-Sakaev, Dortmund 1991.

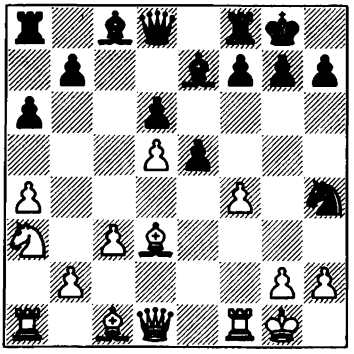
9 ♘f5

For the reasons shown above, **9...♘g6** is more promising, but Kramnik has decided to follow a

little-used plan with ...g7-g6 and ...♗f8-g7.

10 c3 g6

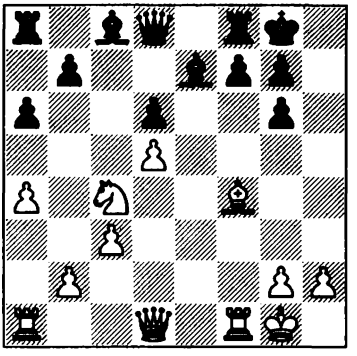
10...♗e7 is more prevalent, for example, **11 ♗d3 0-0 12 0-0 ♘h4 13 f4 a6 14 ♘a3** *(D)* and then:



B

a) **14...ef** (straightforward but not necessarily best) **15 ♗xf4 ♘g6 16 ♗xg6!** (White has gained nothing after 16 ♗g3 ♗h4! 17 ♗xh4 ♘xh4 18 ♘c4 a5 19 ♕d2 b6 20 ♖f4 ♘g6 21 ♗xg6 hg 22 ♕e3 g5! 23 ♖d4 ♗a6 24 ♕g3 ♗xc4 25 ♖xc4, and Black is already somewhat better, Rodriguez-Kramnik, Guarapuava 1991) **16...hg 17 ♘c4** *(D)* and now:

a1) **17...♗f5** 18 ♖e1 ♖c8 19 ♕b3 ♗d3 20 ♘b6 is unpleasant for Black: **20...♖c7** 21 ♖ad1 ♗f5 (Matulović-N.Nikčević, Yugoslavia 1992) and here too 22 ♕b4 with the idea of 23 ♖xe7 would have given White a decisive advantage;



B

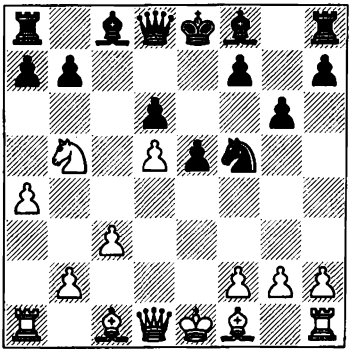
the clever **20...♗c2** is met by an interesting tactical refutation: 21 ♘xc8 ♗xb3 22 ♘xe7+ ♔h7 23 ♖e3 ♕b6 24 a5 ♕c5 25 ♔h1 ♕xe3 26 ♗xe3 ♖e8 27 ♗g5 f6 28 ♖e1 fg 29 ♖e3 g4 30 ♔g1 ±.

a2) **17...♕c7!?** 18 b3 (18 ♕b3?! ♕c5+ 19 ♔h1 ♕xd5 20 ♖ad1 ♕c6 21 ♘xd6 ♗h3! 22 ♖d2 ♗xd6 23 ♗xd6 ♗e6, and the position of the white king isn't hopeful, Apicella-Gagarin, Bucharest 1993) 18...♗f5 19 a5 ♗e4 20 ♖e1 f5 21 ♕d2 ♖ae8 22 ♖ad1 ♕d8, and the threat of the pawn storm by ...g6-g5-g4, ...♖f8-f7, and ...h7-h5 looks very dangerous, as in Ye Jiangchuan-Novik, Moscow 1992. All the same 23 h3 leads to an interesting, double-edged game.

b) **14...f5** 15 ♘c4 ♘g6 16 g3!? (16 a5 is no good: 16...♘xf4! 17 ♗xf4 ef 18 ♖xf4 g6 19 ♖f1 ♗d7 20 ♘b6 ♖b8 21 ♘xd7 ♕xd7 22 ♕a4 ♕c7 23 ♖ae1 ♗f6 24 ♖e6

♖bc8 25 ♔h1 ♗e5, and Black has all the chances to develop a strong attack on the enemy king, moreover the presence of opposite-coloured bishops favours the attacker in such situations) 16...ef (16...♗d7 17 ♗e3 b5 18 ab ab 19 ♖xa8 ♕xa8 20 ♘b6 ♕b7 21 ♘xd7 ♕xd7 22 ♕b3 ♖b8 23 fe ± I.Kuznetsov-Tolstikh, Russia 1992) 17 gf ♗d7 18 a5 ♗b5 19 ♘b6 ♗xd3 20 ♕xd3 ♖b8 21 ♗d2 ♕c7 22 b4 ♖be8 23 ♖ae1 ♖f7 24 c4, and the pawn majority on the queenside, as well as his control over e6, predetermines White's solid advantage.

Now we return to the main line after 10...g6 *(D)*:



W

11 ♗e2

In the next chance he got, Yudasin-Kramnik, Wijk aan Zee Ct (3) 1994, White significantly improved his play: **11 ♗d3! ♗g7** 12 0-0 0-0 13 ♕b3!? ♖e8 14 ♖e1 and then after **14...b6?** 15 a5! (intending a5-a6) 15...a6 16 ab ♖b8?! 17 ♘a3! ♖xb6 18 ♕a4! ♘e7 19 ♘c4 ♖b5 20 ♘a5 ♖b6 21 ♕a2 ♗f5 22 ♗f1 ♗c8 23 ♗d2 ♘f5 24 b4, having made all the moves which are standard in similar positions, he could count on victory. Of course, 14...b6 is a terrible mistake. Kramnik suggests **14...♗d7** 15 ♕b4 ♗f8, or even **14...♗f8** immediately, but Black's difficulties, in the first place in organizing counterplay, are striking. As a result of the unhappy position of the knight on f5 and the excellent placing of his white counterpart on b5 (if ...a7-a6, then ♘b5-a3-c4-b6) Black will have a passive, if stable, position for a long time. Not without reason has Kramnik's trainer, Tseshkovsky, called this variation a blind alley.

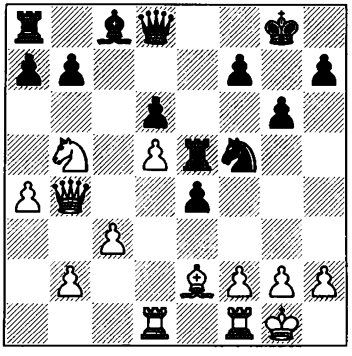
11	**...**	**♗g7**
12	**0-0**	**0-0**
13	**♕b3!?**	**♖e8**
14	**♕b4**	**e4**

It would have been possible to hold on by waiting tactics: **14...h5** (14...♗d7 15 g4 leads to a complicated game) 15 a5 ♗d7 16 ♘a3 ♕c7 17 ♘c4 followed by ♖b1, ♗d3, b3, ♗a3, and the time for action by Black might not even come. Therefore he uses his very first opportunity to cross the line of demarcation.

15 ♗f4

Here **15 a5!?** also deserves attention.

15 ... ♗e5
16 ♗xe5 ♖xe5
17 ♖ad1 *(D)*



B

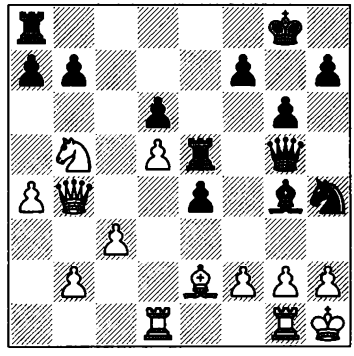
17 ... ♘h4?!

A very bold, but suspect decision. **17...a5!** 18 ♕a3 (18 ♕c4 ♗d7 and ...♗xb5) 18...h5 followed by ...♕e7 and ...♗d7 was more reliable.

18 ♔h1

18 ♕xd6 is no good; 18...♕g5 19 g3 ♗h3 20 ♖fe1 ♘g2 21 ♖f1 ♘f4 22 ♖fe1 ♘xe2+ 23 ♖xe2 ♗g4 with material gains. Unclear consequences follow **18 ♘xd6** a5! 19 ♕c5 ♕g5 (19...♗h3!?; 19...b6 20 ♕c6 ♗d7 21 ♕b7 ♖b8 22 ♕a7 ♖a8 =) 20 g3 ♗g4 – White must avoid 21 gh?? ♗f3+ 22 hg ♖xg5#.

18 ... ♕g5
19 ♖g1 ♗g4 *(D)*



W

20 ♗xg4

20 ♖de1 ♗xe2 21 ♖xe2 a5 22 ♕xd6 ♖d8 followed by ...♖dxd5 was scarcely any better.

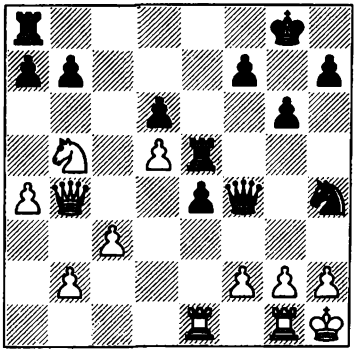
20 ... ♕xg4
21 ♖de1

As before, it is no good to take on d6: **21 ♘xd6** ♘f3!, or **21 ♕xd6** ♕h5!, threatening ♘xg2 and hindering 22 ♘d4 – the pawn on d5 is hanging.

21 ♕f4 *(D)*

Here good play by both sides would have led fittingly to a peaceful result: **21...♘f3!** 22 gf ♕xf3+ 23 ♖g2 e3! 24 fe (24 ♕g4 ef 25 ♖f1 ♖e1 26 ♕c4 ♖ae8 27 ♘d4 ♖xf1+ 28 ♕xf1 ♖e1 29 ♘xf3 ♖xf1+, and Black wins) 24...♖g5 25 ♖g1 ♖xg2 26 ♖xg2 ♕d1+ with a perpetual check.

The text move is linked with a fantastic idea, which, it is true, has a refutation. Alas, Yudasin passed it by.



W

22 ♕xd6??

Perhaps one should also supply an exclamation mark for the co-authorship of such a beautiful piece of work. After **22 ♘xd6**, Kramnik had intended to play **22...♖h5**, threatening 23...♕xh2+, and if 23 ♖xe4, then 23...♘f3. However, just here a shattering blow awaits him: 24 ♖e8+! ♖xe8 25 ♕xf4 winning. He would have been forced to seek salvation after **22...a5** 23 ♕d4 (after 23 ♕xb7 ♖f8 Black keeps the initiative, but 23 ♖xe4 ♖xe4 24 ♕xe4 ♕xd6 25 ♕xh4 ♕xd5 26 b4! is quite possible, with a small advantage for White) 23...♖h5 (with the threat of 24...♕xh2+ followed by 25...♘f5#) 24 ♖xe4 ♕xd6 25 ♖ge1!? ♖f8 26 ♖xh4 ♖xh4 27 ♕xh4 ♕xd5 28 ♕d4 ♕xd4 29 cd ♖c8.

22	...	**♘f5!**
23	**♕c7**	**e3!**
24	**♖xe3**	

If **24 fe**, then 24...♘g3+ 25 hxg3 ♖h5#. But now this idea is embodied in another situation.

24	...	**♕xe3!**
25	**♘d6**	

Yudasin did not wish to allow Black to fulfil his plan after **25 fe** ♘g3+ 26 hg ♖h5#. However, his position is hopeless all the same.

25	...	**♖e7!**
26	**♘xf5**	**gf**
27	**♕d6**	**♕e5**
28	**♕b4**	**♖ae8**
29	**♕h4**	**f6**
30	**h3**	**♕xd5**

0-1

One does not often see at such a high level the incarnation of such grandiose ideas.

Game 29
Yudasin – Kharlov
USSR Ch 1991

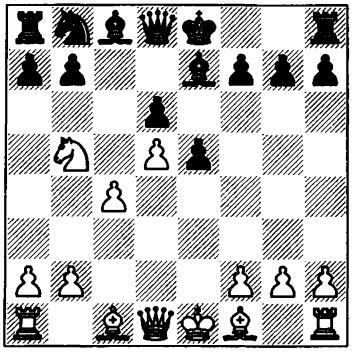
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♘d5 ♘xd5 8 ed ♘b8

9 c4

Estonian Grandmaster Oll had an interesting idea: **9 ♗e3!?**. This is how it worked out in his game against Cherniaev, London 1994: 9...♗e7 10 ♕d2 a6 11 ♘a3 ♘d7 12 ♘c4 0-0 13 a4 b6 14 ♗e2 (14 f3 f5 15 ♗f2 a5 ∓ Oll-Kramnik, Moscow 1992) 14...f5 15 g3 ♗b7!? (15...♖b8!? 16 0-0 ♘f6 leads to an

unclear game) 16 0-0 f4 17 gf ♕e8 18 fe de 19 ♔h1 ♖d8 20 f3 ♕h5 21 ♖ad1 ♔h8 22 ♗xb6!! ♘xb6 23 ♘xb6 ♖d6 24 ♕e3 ♖f4 25 ♖f2 ♖h6 26 ♘c4! 1-0.

9 ♗e7 *(D)*

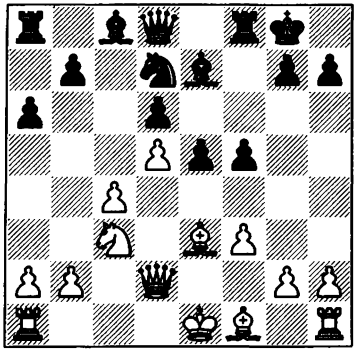


W

10 ♗e2

White may try two alternative ideas:

a) **10 ♗e3 a6 11 ♘c3 0-0 12 ♕d2 f5 13 f3 ♘d7** *(D)*:

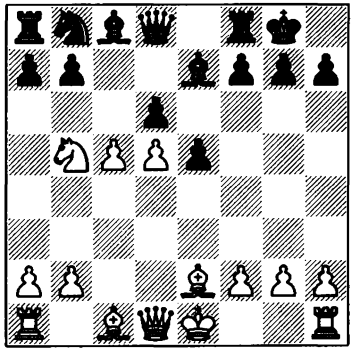


W

a1) **14 ♗d3?!** b6 15 0-0 g5 16 b4 e4 (here is the problem with 14 ♗d3 – if the bishop is on e2, such a breakthrough can be met by the standard f3-f4) 17 fe f4 18 ♗d4 ♗f6 19 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 with good compensation for the pawn, thanks to Black's possession of the strong e5 square, I.Kuznetsov-Golodaev, USSR 1991.

a2) **14 ♗e2** ♗h4+ 15 g3 ♗f6 16 0-0 b6 17 b4 f4!? 18 ♗f2 fg 19 hg ♗g5 20 ♕c2 is better, with the idea of strengthening the centre after ♔g2, ♗d3, and ♘e4.

b) White's plan consists of preparing the advance c4-c5, and a question therefore arises as to why can't he carry it out immediately: **10 c5 0-0 11 ♗e2** (11 cd is worse: 11...♗xd6 12 ♘xd6 ♕xd6 13 ♗e2 ♗f5 14 0-0 ♗e4, and here the passed pawn on d5 becomes a weakness) and now *(D)*:



B

b1) **11...a6?!** 12 cd ♗xd6 13 ♘xd6 ♕xd6 14 0-0 (I.Kuznetsov-Apostoikh, Russia 1992) and now, thanks to the extra tempo, White can seize the initiative: **14...♗f5** 15 ♕b3 or **14...♖d8** 15 ♗g5 f6 16 ♗e3 ±.

b2) **11...♗f5** 12 0-0 dc!? 13 d6 ♗f6 14 ♘c7 ♘c6 15 ♘xa8 ♕xa8 with good counterplay for the sacrificed exchange.

b3) **11...♘a6!?** leaves White behind in development.

Thus, 10 c5 looks premature.

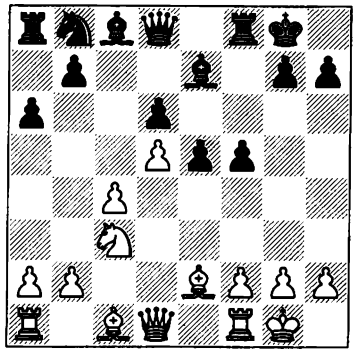
10	**...**	**a6**
11	**♘c3**	**0-0**
12	**0-0**	**f5**

Black is afraid of the arrangement ♗c1-e3 and f2-f3, and therefore plays 12...f5 straight away, so that if 13 ♗e3 he can reply 13...f4. In our opinion, the idea of exchanging the dark-squared bishop doesn't look bad: **12...♘d7** 13 ♗e3 ♗g5!? – exactly now, when White has not had time to hide the bishop on f2 after playing f2-f3.

White has two plans in the position after 12...f5 *(D)*:

1) pay no attention to Black's counterplay, and try persistently to develop a queenside initiative, involving 13 a3, 13 ♖b1!?, or 13 a4;

2) immediately take precautions: 13 f4 or 13 f3 followed by ♗c1-e3. Sooner or later White must defend his king, and, as fans of



W

precautionary activity reason, isn't it better to do this straight away?

13 a3

Let us examine the other possibilities, the first two of which represent, like the text, the plan of ignoring Black's play:

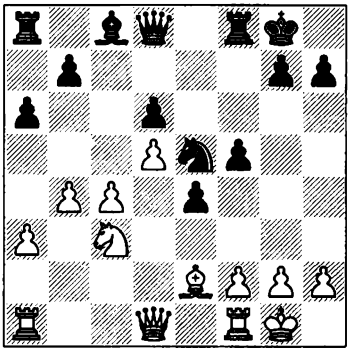
a) **13 ♖b1!?** ♘d7 14 b4 e4 15 ♗e3 ♗f6 16 ♗d4 ♗e5 17 c5 ♕f6 18 ♗xe5 ♘xe5 (18...♕xe5 19 ♘a4) 19 c6! ♘f3+ 20 gf ♕xc3 21 ♕c1 (21 ♖b3 ♕e5 22 fe fe 23 a4 with an unclear game) 21...♕f6 22 f4 ♕h4 (22...bc 23 dc d5 24 ♖fd1 ♗e6 25 ♕e3 ± or 25 ♕c5 ±) 23 ♔h1?! (23 ♖b3!? ♖f6 24 a4! ♖h6 25 h3 ♖g6+ 26 ♔h2 ±) 23...♖f6 24 ♕e3 ♖h6 25 ♕g3 ♕xg3 26 fg bc 27 ♗c4 c5 28 bc dc 29 ♖fc1, and White has good compensation for the sacrificed pawn, as in Ye Jiangchuan-Chekhov, Beijing 1991.

b) **13 a4** ♘d7 (13...a5?! 14 c5!? dc 15 ♘b5 ♗d6 16 f4 e4 17 b3 with the rough plan of ♗b2, ♗c4, ♔h1

and g4) 14 a5 ♗f6 15 b4 (15 f3!?) 15...e4 16 ♖a3 ♗e5 17 f4 ef 18 gf? (18 ♖xf3 ∓) 18...♗xh2+! 19 ♔xh2 ♕h4+ 20 ♔g1 (20 ♔g2? ♖f6 –+) 20...♕g3+ (20...♖f6 21 ♖f2 +–) 21 ♔h1 ♖f6! 22 ♕e1 ♕h3+ 23 ♔g1 f4! 24 ♗d3 ♘e5 with a decisive attack. This variation shows the dangers that lie in wait for White in the event of thoughtless play.

c) **13 f4** ♗f6 (13...♘d7 14 ♔h1 ♗f6 15 ♕c2 ef 16 ♗xf4 ♗e5!? 17 ♗d3 g6 18 ♖ae1 ♗xf4 19 ♖xf4 ♘e5 20 ♘e2 ♕g5! 21 ♖ff1 ♗d7 22 ♘f4 ♖ae8, and thanks to his strong e5-knight Black is better, Inkiov-Tzermiadianos, Khania 1993) 14 g3!? ♘d7 15 ♕c2 (or 15 ♔h1!?) 15...ef 16 gf ♗d4+!? 17 ♔h1 ♘c5 18 ♗f3 ♗d7! 19 ♖b1! b5!? (also 19...a5!? deserves serious study) 20 b4 ♘e4 21 ♘xe4 fe 22 ♗xe4 bc 23 ♕xc4 ♕f6 24 ♖d1 ♖ae8 25 ♕xd4 ♖xe4 26 ♕xe4 ♗f5 27 ♕d4 ♗xb1 28 ♕xf6, and very sharp play in Yudasin-Kramnik, Wijk aan Zee Ct (7) 1994 led to a peaceful conclusion.

13	**...**	**♘d7**
14	**b4**	**e4**
15	**♗e3**	**♗f6**
16	**♗d4**	**♗e5**
17	**♗xe5**	**♘xe5** *(D)*



W

The position recalls that in the game given above, Ye Jiangchuan-Chekhov, with the only difference that instead of the active 13 ♖b1, the passive 13 a3 has been played, which stops White from playing c5-c6 in comfort. If one were to describe the scheme of the battle in the game it would look something like this: White's play has led him to a dead end, and so as not to find himself under the threat of a direct attack on his king, he decides with the assistance of a pawn sacrifice (c5-c6) to open up the queenside. But nothing can stop the central black pawns now, and behind them Black's pieces will reach the king all the same.

18	**♕d4**	**♗d7**
19	**c5**	**♕f6**
20	**♖fd1**	**♖fc8!**

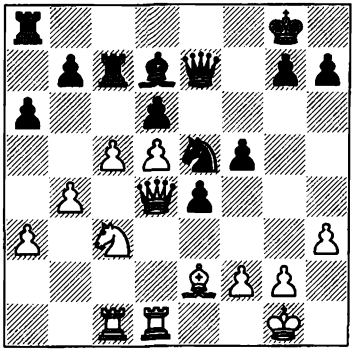
The a6 pawn must be defended in case of c5-c6.

21 ♖ac1?!

White must already think about saving the game. To this end the best chance was **21 c6**, for example, 21...bc 22 dc ♖xc6 23 ♘d5

♕f7 24 ♘b6 (24 b5 ♖c2) 24...♖e8 25 ♘xd7 ♕xd7 26 b5 ♖c2 27 ♕d5+ ♔h8 28 ♖a2 ♖xa2 29 ♕xa2 ab 30 ♕d5 with fair drawing chances.

21 ... ♖c7
22 h3 ♕e7!? *(D)*



W

23 ♔f1?

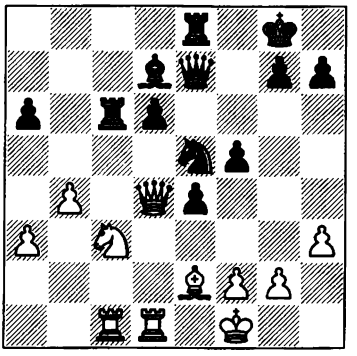
White is now utterly lost; losing time in this way was inadmissible, all the more so as the king is in a worse position on f1 than g1. He should have played **23 c6**.

True, the text move does contain a trap, threatening 24 cd ♕xd6 25 ♘xe4 fe 26 ♖xc7 ♕xc7 27 d6, when Black cannot play 27...♕c2 – the bishop on e2 is defended. But Black is on the alert.

23 ... ♖e8!
24 c6

24 ♘b1 does not work here – a capture on c5 was threatened.

24 ... bc
25 dc ♖xc6 *(D)*



W

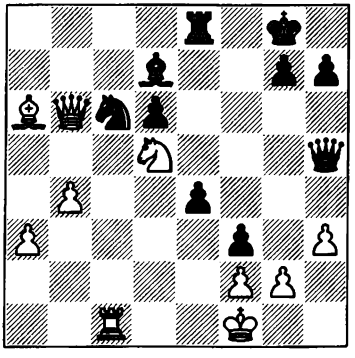
26 ♘d5 ♕f7
27 ♖xc6 ♘xc6
28 ♕b6 f4!
29 ♗xa6

29 ♗c4 gives nothing because of 29...♔h8 followed by 30...♘e5.

29 ... ♕h5!

Now Black's play resembles the work of a bulldozer, as he sweeps away everything in his path.

30 ♖c1 f3 *(D)*



W

31 ♘f4?

The decisive error. 31 ♖xc6 also loses: 31...fg+ 32 ♔xg2 ♗xh3+ 33 ♔h2 ♗g4+ 34 ♔g1 ♗f3 with an inevitable mate, but 31 ♕e3 would have allowed more stubborn resistance.

31	**...**	**fg+**
32	**♔g1**	**♕g5**
33	**♖xc6**	**♕xf4**
34	**♖c3**	**♕d2**
35	**♖g3**	**e3**

The second pawn makes its presence felt.

36	**♖xe3**	**♕c1+**
37	**♔xg2**	**♗c6+**
38	**f3**	**♖xe3**

0-1

Conclusion

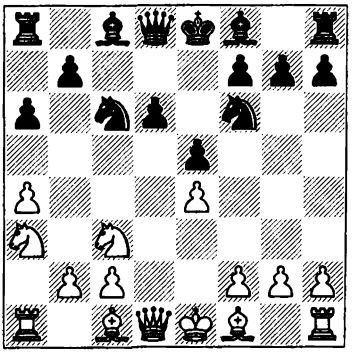
In the variation with 7 ♘d5, in spite of the externally tranquil canvas, complications frequently arise which are no less sharp than in other variations of the system. At present, it seems to us that 8...♘b8 is the more dependable continuation, although 8...♘e7 also allows hopes for a playable game.

13 7 a4

This variation also leads to a game which is rich in content, and is founded on a solid positional basis.

Game 30
Rublevsky – Kharlov
Podolsk 1992

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6
7 a4 a6
8 ♘a3 *(D)*



B

In this situation there are two principally different possibilities.

With 8...♗e6, Black tries to bring his pieces into the battle quickly: ...♖c8, ...♘d4, creating pressure on the c-file. Alternative continuations:

a) Black has tried by the mechanical means of **8...h6** to hinder a pin on the knight, but after 9 ♗c4 ♗e6 10 0-0 ♖c8 11 ♖e1 ♘b4 12 b3 ♗e7 13 ♗b2 0-0 14 ♕e2 ♕c7 15 h3 ♖fe8 16 ♖ad1 ♕c5 17 ♖d2 ♔h7 18 ♖ed1 (Radulov-Neckař, Vratsa 1975) White firmly seized the initiative.

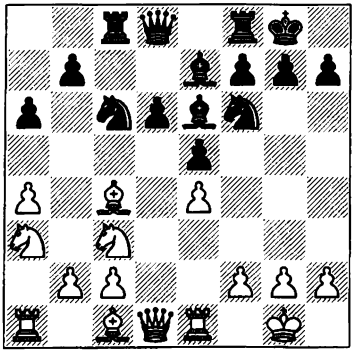
b) **8...♗e7** solves the problem of developing the kingside.

b1) It would seem that Black then also makes **9 ♗g5** difficult, although after **9...♘xe4** 10 ♘xe4 (10 ♗xe7 ♘xc3 11 ♗xd8 ♘xd1 =) 10...♗xg5 11 ♘xd6+ ♔e7 12 ♘ac4 ♗e6 13 ♕f3! ♘d4 14 ♕xb7+ ♕d7 15 ♕xd7+ (15 ♕e4 f5 16 ♕d3 ♗f6 with the initiative in return for the sacrificed pawn) 15...♔xd7 16 ♗d3 ♗e7 (Langier-Kramnik, Guarapuava 1991) White can sacrifice his knight for the initiative: 17 ♘xf7 ♗xf7 18 ♘xe5+ ♔e8 (or 18...♔e6 19 f4 ±) 19 0-0-0. But 8...♗e7 has a more profound idea, which the following variation after 9 ♗g5 illustrates: **9...0-0!?** 10 ♗xf6 (the capture is now necessary, in view of 10...♘xe4 being threatened in earnest) 10...♗xf6 11 ♗c4 ♗g5 12 0-0 ♔h8 13 ♘d5 f5! (with

the bishop on e6 and the king on g8 this move is no good because of ♘b6!) 14 ef (14 f3 is answered by 14...♗e6, when 15 ♘b6?? is impossible because of 15...♕xb6+) 14...♗xf5 followed by ...e4 and ...♘e5. The bishop has landed on f5 in one move.

The fight for an extra tempo and better distribution of pieces is in general characteristic of the minor variations of the Sveshnikov, and in this case the prophylactic move 7 a4 gives Black too much freedom of movement and a large choice.

b2) Line 'a' demonstrated a very promising arrangement of the white pieces, which is probably also possible after 8...♗e7, for example, **9 ♗c4 0-0 10 0-0 ♗e6 11 ♖e1** (11 b3 ♘xe4) **11...♖c8** *(D)* and now:

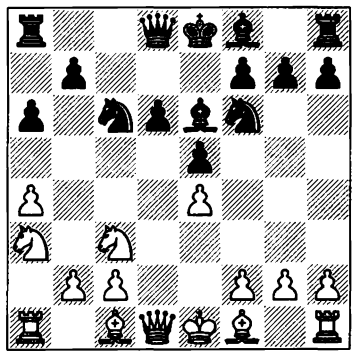


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b21) **12 b3** ♗xc4! (it's surprising that until this point this simple move had not been seen) 13 ♘xc4 ♘a5! 14 ♘xa5 ♕xa5 15 ♗d2 ♕c7! (a queen sacrifice is also possible: 15...♖xc3 16 ♖e3 ♖xe3 17 ♗xa5 ♖xe4 with some compensation), and Black is OK. This means that the plan with b3 is not beneficial.

b22) White could try **12 ♘d5** ♗xd5!? 13 ed ♘b8 14 ♗f1 (planning to arrange the white forces thus: ♗e3, ♘c4 and a5, ♖a4-b4 or ♘b6, c4, b4) 14...♖c5! 15 c4 b6! (15...a5!? 16 ♗e3 ♘fd7!? 17 ♗xc5 ♘xc5 with the idea of ...♘ba6, ...f5, ...♗f6) 16 b4 ♖c8 with a further battle for the dark squares by means of ...♘fd7 and ...a5. From this it is clear that Black's opportunities are much richer without the passive ...h6.

8 ♗e6 *(D)*



W

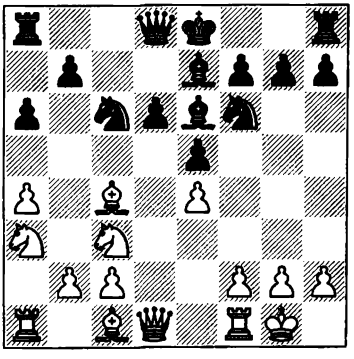
9 ♗c4

The continuation **9 ♘c4?** is not justified; in Korchnoi-Morović,

Santiago (5) 1991 Black continued 9...♖c8 10 ♗e3 ♘d4?! (10...♘b4! is stronger: 11 ♘b6 ♖c6 12 ♘bd5 ♕a5 13 ♘xf6+ gf 14 ♗d3 d5 ∓) 11 ♗xd4 ♗xc4 12 ♗xc4 ♖xc4 13 ♗e3 with equality.

9 ... ♖c8

Due to the precarious position of the king Black cannot immediately solve his problems and seize the initiative by means of a standard trick from similar positions: **9...♗e7 10 0-0** *(D)* and now:



B

a) **10...♗xc4** 11 ♘xc4 ♘xe4? 12 ♘xe4 d5 13 ♕g4! g6 14 ♖d1 f5 15 ♕g3 fe 16 ♗e3 d4 (16...0-0 17 ♘b6 d4 18 ♘xa8 ♕xa8 19 ♗h6 ♖f5 20 ♕g4 ♖h5 21 ♗d2 ♖h4 22 ♕e6+ ♔h8 23 ♖e1 and g3 ±) 17 ♘xe5 ♗d6 18 ♘xc6 ♗xg3 19 ♘xd8 de 20 fg ♖xd8 21 ♖xd8+ ♔xd8 22 ♖e1 ♔d7 23 ♖xe3 with a winning rook ending for White, Rublevsky-Sveshnikov, USSR Ch 1991.

b) **10...♘xe4** is also dangerous straight away because of **11 ♗xe6** ♘xc3 12 ♗xf7+ ♔f7 13 bc d5 14 ♕f3+ ♗f6 15 ♖b1 with a strong attack, or gaining a better ending after **11 ♘xe4** d5 12 ♗b3 de 13 ♗xe6 ♕xd1 (13...fe 14 ♕h5+ g6 15 ♕g4) 14 ♗xf7+ ♔xf7 15 ♖xd1.

c) **10...♖c8** 11 ♗g5 0-0 12 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 13 ♘d5 ♗g5 14 c3 ± Rublevsky-Chekhov, USSR Ch 1991.

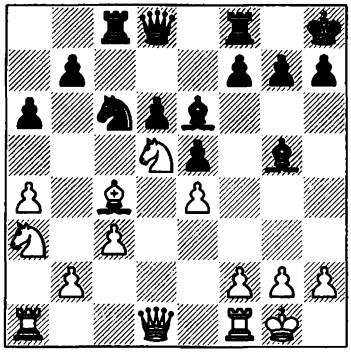
10	**♗g5**	**♗e7**
11	**♗xf6**	**♗xf6**
12	**♘d5**	**0-0**
13	**0-0**	**♗g5**
14	**c3**	**♔h8** *(D)*

In our opinion Black has not conducted the opening very accurately. Some doubt exists as to the expediency of the plan with ...♗e6 and ...♖c8.

Nevertheless, one of the key positions of the entire variation has arisen, and understanding it is very important for playing similar positions, which as a whole are typical of the Sveshnikov.

After **14...♘e7** 15 ♕b3 ♗xd5 (15...♘xd5 16 ed and 17 ♕xb7) 16 ♗xd5 ♘xd5 17 ♕xd5 ♕c7 18 ♖fd1 ♖fd8 19 ♘c2 an ideal correlation of pieces, with possession of d5, arises for White, which gives him a big advantage; furthermore, Black is forced to watch passively as White reinforces, and counterplay with ...f5 is at this point too late.

Clearly Black should avoid such positions by every means possible.



W

15 ♗a2

If **15 ♕e2**, then **15...♘b8!?** is not bad, with the plan of transferring the knight to c5, whilst also keeping an eye on the a4-pawn and preparing ...f5. Recently this manoeuvre in the Sicilian Defence (the Boleslavsky System, for instance) has become very popular, and is longer called into doubt (for losing time?), as moving the knight to c5 and pressurizing e4 is too good an idea.

On the other hand, **15...♘e7** scarcely allows Black to hope for equality after 16 ♘xe7 ♕xe7 17 ♖ad1 ♖fd8 (the moves ...♔h8 and ...♖fd8 don't fit together well) 18 ♗xe6 fe 19 c4, with a slight advantage for White, although Black has quite a solid position.

15 ... ♘e7

Here, **15...♘b8** is no good because of 16 ♘c4, but the continuation in the game is quite sufficient for equality, as the bishop on a2 is not best placed. In general Black has to follow the nuances constantly, and, depending on White's continuation, vary his game. For example, why exactly did Black play 14...♔h8? Evidently to prepare ...f5. But the time for this plan has not yet arrived, in that **15...f5** is met by 16 ♘b6! gaining material.

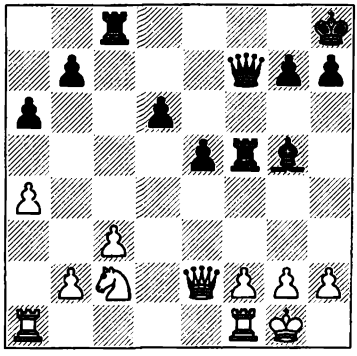
It is possible that this blow will not be carried out, but it does not mean that we should hurry to condemn the king move as an error. The threat was created all the same, and White was forced to deal with it somehow. True, alongside 14...♔h8, **14...♘b8**, with the idea of bringing the knight to c5, deserved attention.

16 ♘xe7 ♕xe7
17 ♘c2 f5?!

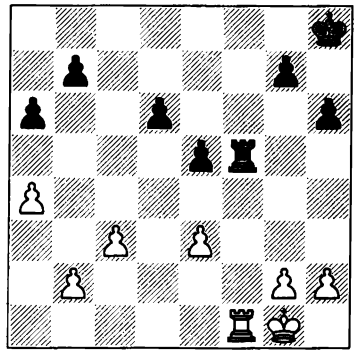
Everything is already prepared for the blow, but it was possible to play the stronger **17...♗xa2** 18 ♖xa2 f5 19 ef ♖xf5 20 ♘b4 e4 ∓. From this we can conclude that 15 ♗a2 is weaker than the previously seen 15 ♕b2.

18 ♗xe6 ♕xe6
19 ef ♖xf5
20 ♕e2 ♕f7?! *(D)*

20...♖ff8 is more precise, with the idea of ...d5.



W



B

21 ♘e3! ♗xe3

Not **21...♖f6??** losing a piece to 22 ♕g4, while after **21...♖f4** 22 ♖ad1 ♖xa4 23 ♖xd6 White maintains a small advantage.

22 fe! h6?!

22...♖xf1+ is better: 23 ♖xf1 ♕d7 24 ♕f3 h6 with defensive chances.

23 ♕g4! ♖f8??

Black's previous move was inexact, but did not yet have grave consequences, but just created additional defensive complications. Therefore, after **23...♖xf1+** 24 ♖xf1 ♕e8 White would be left with only a slightly more pleasant position.

The text, allowing a transfer to a pawn ending via a rook ending, gives White a decisive advantage.

24 ♖xf5 ♕xf5
25 ♕xf5 ♖xf5
26 ♖f1! *(D)*
26 ... ♖f6

Clearly, Black cannot leave the f-file for an invasion by the white rook. There remain two possibilities of moving into a pawn ending. Let us examine them:

a) **26...♖xf1+** 27 ♔xf1 ♔g8 (moving to the left does not help the king either: 27...♔h7 28 ♔e2 ♔g6 {or 28...b4 29 c4 ♔g6 30 ♔d2 ♔f5 31 ♔c3 ♔e5 32 a5 and Black is in zugzwang} 29 ♔d3 ♔f5 30 a5 +–) 28 ♔e2 ♔f7 29 ♔d3 d5 (after 29...♔e6 30 ♔c4 both 30...d5+ 31 ♔c5 and 30...b6 31 e4 lose) 30 e4 ♔e6 31 a5! ♔d6 32 b4 ♔e6 33 ed+ ♔xd5 34 c4+ ♔d6 35 ♔e4 ♔e6 36 b5 ♔d6 37 b6! winning.

b) **26...g6** 27 e4 (27 ♖xf5? gf =; 27 g4 ♖xf1+ 28 ♔xf1 ♔g7, and White has no win because of the weakness of the kingside) 27...♖f4 28 ♖xf4 ef 29 ♔f2 ♔g7 30 ♔f3 g5 31 a5! ♔f6 (31...♔g6 32 ♔g4 and then h2-h4) 32 h4 ♔e5 33 hg hg 34 ♔g4 ♔xe4 35 ♔xg5 ♔e5 36 c4 ♔e4 37 ♔f6 ♔d3 38 ♔f5 and White wins.

27	**♖xf6**	**gf**
28	**e4!**	**b5**
29	**ab**	**ab**
30	**♔f2**	**♔g7**
31	**♔e2**	**h5**

31...♔g6 32 g4 +–.

32	**♔f3!**	**♔g6**
33	**g4!**	**h4**
34	**♔e3**	**h3**
35	**♔f3**	**♔f7**
36	**♔g3**	**♔e6**
37	**♔xh3**	**d5**
38	**♔g3**	**de**
39	**♔f2**	**1-0**

A very tense game, in which Black did not use all his opportunities, while White shone in technical accomplishments and played the endgame virtuously.

Conclusion

The move 7 a4 does not cause Black any special trouble; thanks to the extra tempo he has good development and a large choice of plans, and he simply does not need to force events (...♘f6xe4 is very often premature and fails to equalise). But adherents of quiet positional play (whilst indeed many variations in the Sveshnikov are quite sharp) can boldly be advised to play it as White; the precautionary move a2-a4 deprives Black of his activity on the queenside (...b7-b5), and if he succeeds in holding onto d5 with little loss of blood, then he can expect a definite advantage.

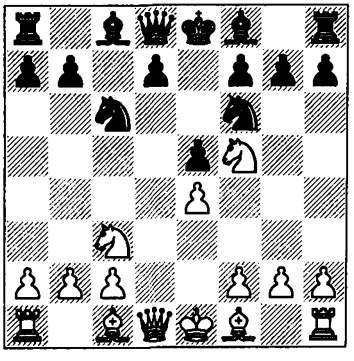
14 White plays 6 ♘f5

In this final chapter we will examine a deviation for White from the main variation in the very early stages of the battle. 6 ♘f5 is the one that deserves most attention.

Game 31
Akopian – Yakovich
Rostov on Don 1992

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5

6 ♘f5 *(D)*



B

6 ♘f5 is Bronstein's move, which in all theoretical reference works is said not to lead to an advantage. The question then is why did a grandmaster who is experienced in the finer points of the variation choose this move? In the first place, he could have seen the unnecessarily extravagant waste of four tempi only to transfer the knight to a3. But in the second place, Akopian may have prepared something new...

6 d5!

Only this advance allows Black to gain a level game.

7 ed ♗xf5

8 dc bc

Exchanging queens is somewhat weaker: **8...♕xd1+** 9 ♘xd1 bc 10 ♘e3 ♗e6 11 ♘c4 ♘d7 12 ♗e3 f6 13 0-0-0 ♗c5 14 ♘a5 with a minimal advantage to White.

9 ♕f3

9 ♕xd8+ ♖xd8 is not dangerous for Black, for example, 10 ♗e3 ♖b8 11 0-0-0 ♗b4 12 ♗c4 a5 13 f3 0-0 14 ♘a4 e4! with a level game.

9 ... ♕d7

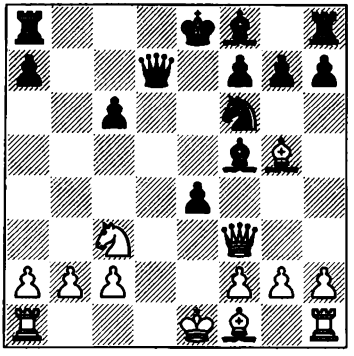
9...♕c8 is no good, as it allows White to seize the initiative firmly: 10 ♗a6! ♕xa6 11 ♕xf5 ♗d6 12 ♗h6! ♘d5 13 ♘e4 ♗e7 14 ♗xg7.

10 ♗g5 e4 *(D)*

After **10...♗b4** 11 ♗xf6 gf 12 ♗d3 ♗xc3+ 13 bc ♗xd3 14 cd ♕e6 15 0-0 0-0 16 ♖ae1 ♔h8 17 ♖e4 f5 (Sax-Fedorowicz, Dubai OL

1986), 18 ♖c4 would give White the better chances.

Besides that, in this situation **10...♗e7** suggests itself.



W

11 ♕e2 ♗e7
12 ♖d1

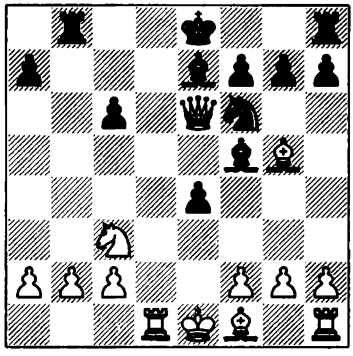
Winning a pawn by means of **12 ♗xf6** ♗xf6 13 ♘xe4 0-0! 14 ♘xf6+ gf 15 ♕d2 ♖fe8+ 16 ♔d1 ♕e7 led to a long-term initiative for Black in Tsaturian-Markauss, corr 1988-9.

12 ... ♕e6!?
13 ♕c4 ♖b8!

13...0-0 14 ♕xe6 ♗xe6 15 ♘xe4 ♘xe4 16 ♗xe7 ♖fe8 17 f3! ♖xe7 18 fe ♗d5 19 ♗d3 ♗xe4 20 ♔f2 leads to an ending that is somewhat worse for Black.

14 ♕xe6? *(D)*

Akopian, evidently, had not foreseen Yakovich's reply. Otherwise he would have chosen **14 b3**, which may lead after 14...♗b4 15 ♕xe6+ ♗xe6 16 ♗d2 to a position from the next note.



B

14 fe

And here is a surprise, but it is not White who has sprung it, but Black! Possibly Akopian was basing his play on the game Parutenko-Markauss, corr. 1988-9, which continued **14...♗xe6** 15 b3 ♗b4 16 ♗d2 0-0 **17 ♗e2** ♖fd8 ∓. One might suggest that the Armenian Grandmaster wished to fight for an advantage by means of **17 ♘a4**.

15 b3

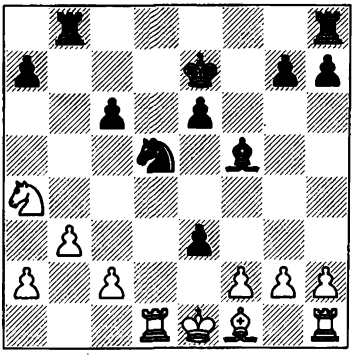
15 ♘a4? loses to 15...e3.

15 ... ♘d5
16 ♗xe7 ♔xe7
17 ♘a4

Of course, White's idea was not to improve Black's pawn structure. After **17 ♘xd5**, 17...ed or even 17...cd would give Black an unquestionable advantage.

17 ... e3 *(D)*

Black is promised no real advantage after **17...♘b4** 18 c3! ♘c2+ 19 ♔d2 e3+ 20 ♔c1 ♖hd8 (20...ef 21 ♖d2) 21 ♗e2!.



W

18 c4!

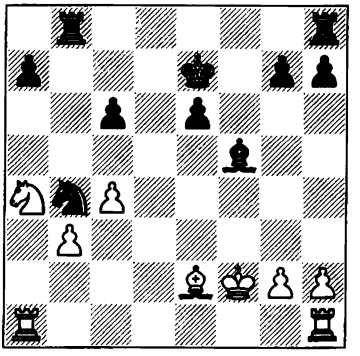
White must defend very carefully. Trying to bring the bishop into the struggle would have had unpleasant consequences: **18 ♗d3** ef+ 19 ♔xf2 ♖hf8 20 ♔g3 ♘e3 21 ♖d2 ♗xd3.

18 ... ef+
19 ♔xf2 ♘b4
20 ♗e2!

Again Akopian defends cleverly. Neither **20 ♘c5** ♖hd8 21 ♗e2 ♘xa2 22 ♖a1 ♖d2 23 ♖hd1 ♖xe2+ 24 ♔xe2 ♘c3+ 25 ♔e1 ♘xd1, nor **20 ♘c3** ♖hf8 21 ♔e3 ♘xa2! was any good.

20 ... ♘xa2
21 ♖a1 ♘b4 *(D)*

21...♖hf8 was also possible, but it would not have led to a decisive advantage either: 22 ♗f3 ♘b4 23 ♘c5 a6 24 ♖hd1 (24 ♘xa6? ♘d3+) 24...e5 25 ♔g3.



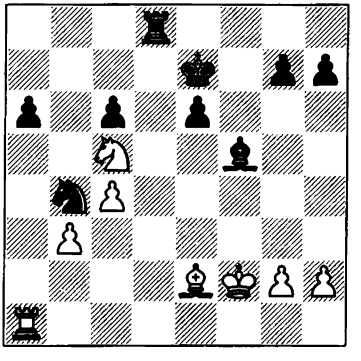
W

22 ♘c5 a6
23 ♖hd1!

White falls into a dangerous position after **23 ♘xa6** ♘xa6 24 ♖xa6 ♖xb3 25 ♖xc6 ♖b2 26 ♔e3 ♖a8.

23 ... ♖hd8
24 ♖xd8 ♖xd8 *(D)*

If **24...♔xd8**, then 25 g4.



W

25 ♖a4 ½-½

Attempting to play actively by means of **25...♘c2** 26 g4! ♗g6 27 ♖xa6 ♖d2 28 ♖a7+ ♔f6 29 h4 ♘d4 30 ♘d7+ ♔e7 31 ♔e3 would have placed Black in a difficult position, whilst **25...♖b8** would have led to many exchanges and a draw.

Conclusion

Although the author of the system, Evgeny Sveshnikov himself, suggested that Black might await difficulties after 6 ♘f5, this has not yet been confirmed in practice. Black gains equality without any particular difficulties.

Index of Variations

1 e4 c5
2 ♘f3 ♘c6
3 d4 cxd4
4 ♘xd4 ♘f6
5 ♘c3 e5

A: 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♘d5
B: 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gxf6 10 ♘d5 ♗g7
C: 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gxf6 10 ♘d5 f5
D: Other lines

A

6 ♘db5 d6
7 ♗g5 a6
8 ♘a3 b5
9 ♘d5

9 ♘ab1 ♗e7 10 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 11 ♘d5 111

9 ... ♗e7

9...♕a5+ 10 ♗d2 (10 c3 49)
10...♕d8:
11 ♗g5 – see move 9!
11 c4 44
11 ♗d3 44
11 ♘xf6+ 45

10 ♗xf6

10 ♘xe7 40

10 ... ♗xf6
11 c3
11 c4 63
11 g3 74
11 c4 20
11 g3 20

11 ♘b1:
11...0-0 111
11...♖b8 111
11...♗b7 114

11 ... ♗b7

11...♘e7 20

11...0-0 12 ♘c2:
12...♗g5 24
12...♗b7 21

12 ♘c2 ♘b8

12...♖b8:
13 a3 34
13 ♕d3 29
13 ♗d3 30
13 ♗e2 29
13 b4 36
13 h4 36

13 a4 bxa4

14 ♘ce3 14
14 ♖xa4 16

B

6 ♘db5 d6
7 ♗g5 a6
8 ♘a3 b5
9 ♗xf6 gxf6
10 ♘d5 ♗g7
11 c3

11 ♗d3 ♘e7 12 ♘xe7 ♕xe7:
13 c3 54
13 0-0 0-0 14 c4 59
11 f5
12 exf5
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15 ♗d3 79
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15...b4 64
15...♖b8 65
15...♗xd5 67

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10 ♘d5 f5
11 ♗d3
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13 c3 91
13 0-0 91
13 0-0-0 91

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After 10...gxf6:
11 ♘e3 117
11 ♗d3 117
11 ♘d5 119

The Sicilian Defence features many dramatic variations, but for sheer violence few can equal the Sveshnikov. Black aims for maximum piece activity at the cost of a shattered pawn structure.

Black's aim is to seize the initiative, regardless of the cost. If he is successful, then the pawns will look after themselves. On the other hand, White is looking to use Black's weaknesses as spring-boards for a ferocious attack of his own. Even Sveshnikov endings are dynamic and imbalanced. No wonder it has been a favourite of ambitious players for many years!

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Peter Marusenko is also from the Ukraine. He is an renowned chess writer, who plays in many tournaments across Europe.

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